

NOT A POTATO

THE SPACES BETWEEN



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Chapter 1 — The Potato

The raft was not going to work, and everyone on it knew except the camera.

Yusuf had built rafts before — Sudan, a flooded road, jerrycans and a door — and he could feel the wrongness through his heels the way you feel a tooth before it aches. Too much above the waterline. The basalt column lay lashed athwart eight oil drums and a frame of green mangrove poles, and it sat there like a dropped sentence, going nowhere, while the tide that was supposed to lift it kept its own counsel out on the reef flat.

The column itself was a beautiful thing. Six-sided, near enough — nature's own carpentry, a lava log cooled and cracked into a prism a long time before anyone thought to want it. Three metres of it. Maybe four tonnes. A modest one, chosen on purpose; you did not start a demonstration with the fifty-tonne monster.

"Sea's coming," said Dione.

Dione Aldis was the engineer, and the engineer did not believe in any of this, which Yusuf liked about her immediately. She was Pohnpeian on her mother's side and a graduate of somewhere damp and serious on her father's, and she had agreed to run the lift the way you agree to drive a relative to the airport: out of duty, and faintly insulted that the duty existed. She wore a high-vis vest over a church shirt and she kept checking her phone, which had no signal out here, which is a thing people do when they would rather not be looking at you.

"Tide's at three-forty," she said. "We've got it for about an hour either side of high. After that the channel's too shallow and the flat's too deep, and you've got a four-tonne paperweight in the wrong place

forever.”

“Forever’s a long time,” said Frik, cheerfully, from the bow, where he had appointed himself ballast.

“Look around you,” said Dione.

They looked around. Behind them — and this was the whole trouble with the demonstration, the thing nobody had quite costed — stood Nan Madol.

You have to come at it by water, on the tide, the way the order requires, and the first sight of it does something physical to the back of the neck. Walls of stacked black columns rise straight up out of the sea, mortarless, the long faces and the cut ends alternating course on course like the corner of a log cabin built by something the size of weather. Ninety-two islets, give or take, laced together by canals — the spaces between, which is what the name means, the gaps and the water and what runs in them. Nandauwas, the great royal mortuary, lifts its seaward wall five, six, seven metres clean, and on the corner of it sits a single stone that the books say weighs around fifty tonnes, and it has sat there, dry-laid, holding its line, since a few centuries before anyone alive was born.

The whole thing is medieval. That is the part that ambushes people. Radiocarbon puts the monumental building from about AD 1180 — younger than the cathedral at Chartres was getting started, give or take. This was the capital of the Saudeleur, the dynasty that pulled Pohnpei into one fist and held it until a man called Isokelekel took it back, around the early seventeenth century. A real dynasty. A real fall. Names that families on this island still carry the weight of.

A ceremonial city for the dead, built on a reef flat that grows no food and holds no fresh water, where no living soul could last a week without a canoe coming out to feed them.

Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt, hauled there.

Edith was up on the islet wall with the long lens, not pointed at the raft. She’d asked first — she always asked first now, that was the new Edith, the one who left a beat of silence before the shutter to see if anyone wanted to say no — and the elder who’d accompanied them,

a slight man named Salihken who said almost nothing and missed nothing, had inclined his head a fraction toward the masonry and away from the graves, which was permission and instruction in one motion. So she shot the wall. The header-and-stretcher of it. The way the stone bound the stone with nothing but its own honest weight.

Mira stood at the canal edge, not on the raft, watching Dione's face.

Hi, friends. Hecklefish here. The official story, straight, because we play it straight: medieval islanders, brilliant builders, stacked a mortuary city on a reef. True. Revered. Award the gold star. Now somebody explain to me why the engineer's already left the building behind her eyes, and the tide hasn't even — oh. Oh, here we go.

"Drums," said Dione.

The tide came in the way it does on a reef flat, not as a wave but as a decision: a sudden general rising, the brown water going green going clear, the mangrove poles creaking, the drums knocking and lifting. The raft floated. There was a small involuntary cheer from somewhere — Frik — and Dione did not join it, because Dione was watching the freeboard, and the freeboard was nothing.

"Stop loading the front," she said. "Yusuf. Off."

He went off, into water to his chest, warm as a bath and full of small fish investigating his legs. The raft rose a hand's width. With the column on it, four tonnes of dead prism lashed across the beam, it answered the smallest swell like a tray carried by someone arguing. It wanted to roll. It would not stop wanting to roll.

"This is the textbook method," Yusuf said. Not arguing. Reading aloud. "Float it at high water, walk it down the channel, lever it up the islet face on rollers and ramps. They did it ninety times. A hundred. Over four centuries that's — what —"

"Eighteen hundred tonnes a year," said Mira, without looking up. She'd done the arithmetic the night before, flat, the way you'd read a tide table. Seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes, four hundred years. A wall's worth a month, more or less, forever, for longer than the United States has existed. "Sustained."

“Sustained,” Yusuf agreed.

“For four centuries,” said Dione, “by people who left no rollers, no ramps, no sledges, no quarry road, no broken drag-tackle, nothing. Pull.” This last to the men on the canal bank with the line. “Gently. *Gently*. It’s not a tug-of-war, it’s a baby.”

They pulled the raft into the canal mouth. For a length, two lengths, it was almost grand — the black column riding the green water between the black walls, the past and the demonstration of the past sliding along together, and Edith came down off the wall to get it low and level, the lens just above the waterline, because that was the shot, that had always been the shot: *here is how easy it was*.

The raft touched the islet face.

The islet face is where the textbook quietly stops being a textbook.

Because now you have a four-tonne stone floating at your chest and a wall going straight up in front of you, and you have to get the stone from the one to the other and up, and there is no crane, there has never been a crane, the whole point of the exercise is that there was never a crane. Dione had brought a sheerlegs — three lengths of steel scaffold pole lashed into a tripod, a chain hoist hung from the apex, the most generous possible interpretation of *levers and human ingenuity*. It was, she’d said when they unloaded it, more help than the builders ever had. She’d said it the way you confess to cheating at solitaire.

They set the sheerlegs on the lowest course. Coral rubble underfoot, basalt at the shins, the tide at its absolute top now and beginning, you could feel it, to think about leaving. The chain hoist took up. The column came off the raft, swung free, four tonnes turning slowly on a chain over green water, and for one held breath it was going to work, the genre was going to win, the demonstration was going to demonstrate.

The lowest course shifted.

Not much. A column the long way is a header, its cut end out; the next course up lies the other way, a stretcher, long face out; that alternation is the whole grammar of the wall, that is what makes it

stand without mortar, and it stands because every stone in it was placed dead and never asked to take a sideways load. The sheerlegs' foot put a sideways load on it. The header rolled a finger's width in its bed and the stretcher above it dropped its end with a sound like a door closing in another house, and Dione had the hoist's brake off and the column down onto the raft before Yusuf had finished saying her name.

The column landed badly. The raft took it badly. One drum folded its lashing and went, and the prism slid, and the green water came over the low edge in a sheet, and then the column was not on the raft.

It went in clean. No drama to it at all. A four-tonne stone enters the sea the way a coin enters a fountain — a chunk, a swallow, a column of bubbles, gone. Three metres of water on the flat now and the basalt sitting on the bottom of the canal it had been meant to climb, as level and as patient as it had been on the truck.

The tide began to leave.

And there it is. The Potato.

Best kit. Best plan. A real engineer, a chain hoist the medievals would've wept for, a column they picked because it was easy — and one wall behind them, just the one, ten metres of it, that has stood flawless and silent through eighteen generations of weather and a couple of wars and now, apparently, through us. The brightest people in daylight made a potato. The thing on the reef did not.

Funny how nobody's laughing.

Nobody was laughing. Frik was wet to the eyebrows and grinning the wide useless grin of a man whose adrenaline has nowhere to go, but his eyes weren't in it. Edith had not raised the camera. The column lay in the canal and would have to be got out before the lagoon edge dropped enough to strand it, and Dione was already roping the recovery, fast and unsurprised, like a woman who'd known the ending of this film before the credits.

That was the thing Yusuf clocked, standing in the falling water with the small fish gone and the mud coming back.

Dione had known.

She'd brought the sheerlegs anyway. She'd set the lift on the lowest course anyway, the worst possible course, the one any builder would tell you not to touch. She'd let the textbook fail in front of the lens cleanly, professionally, on the record.

"Who's paying for this," Yusuf said. Quietly. He'd come up beside her on the wall while the others worked the line.

Dione didn't stop coiling rope. "You are. Your production company. The grant."

"No. Who's paying *you*." He'd seen the invoice that morning by accident, the header on it, a development consultancy out of somewhere with a glass lobby, *feasibility*, and her name in the cc line on an email she'd minimised too slow. "You don't believe the textbook can do it. Fine. Neither do I, after that. But you didn't run it to find out. You ran it to *show*. You ran it to put a film in the world that says *look how impossible this is, look how nobody can manage this place, look how it just sits here being a riddle nobody can answer*."

The rope stopped.

For a second something honest moved across Dione's face — and Mira, on the bank, twelve metres off, in the noise of the recovery and with her back half-turned, caught it the way she caught everything, before the words, instead of the words. Not guilt. Closer to grief. The face of someone doing a job they understand the shape of better than the people who hired them.

"You should ask Salihken," Dione said, "what the wall's for. Not me. Not your engineer." She got the rope moving again. "And when he tells you he doesn't know — listen to *how* he doesn't know."

She went down to the line.

The water was nearly off the flat now. The reef came back grey and streaming, and the city stood up out of it the way it had stood up out of it every single day for eight hundred years, dry-laid, mortarless, the fifty-tonne corner holding its line against nothing but its own weight and the patience of whoever had set it there and then declined to leave a single note explaining how.

Behind them in the canal, their column waited to be hauled out of the only thing the day had actually proven.

Salihken stood at the edge of the islet with his hands folded, looking not at the failed lift and not at the wall, but at Mira — who had turned, now, fully, and was looking back at him. Neither of them said anything. There was nothing yet that needed saying, and both of them, in their different schools of it, were fluent in that.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story, Straight

The tide let them in at a quarter past nine.

Edith felt it before she saw it — the skiff's hull stopped grinding coral and started gliding, the channel opening like a held breath, and then the first wall came at them out of the mangrove shade, black and stacked and wrong-sized for anything human. She had her camera up before she'd decided to. That was the body remembering its job. Twenty years of pointing a lens at things that didn't want to be looked at, and the hands still moved first.

She didn't press the shutter.

There was a man in the bow who hadn't given them permission yet, not the real kind, and she'd learned the difference between a place you may photograph and a place that lets you. This was the second kind. You waited.

"That's Nandauwas," the archaeologist said. Dr. Ioanis Saimon — Pohnpei State, a clipboard he never looked at, a hat gone the colour of the reef. He said the name the way you'd say a relative's. "The royal mortuary. The big one. We'll come at it slow, because the tide says so, not because I'm building suspense."

Frik laughed — too loud, the way he did when he was nervous and trying to fill the air. "Slow's fine. Slow's good."

Mira didn't laugh. She was watching Saimon's mouth and his hands both, the way she watched everyone, and Edith caught her doing it and thought: *she's already reading him*. Mira signed something small to Yusuf — *easy*, maybe, or *patient* — and Yusuf, who signed like a

man wearing oven mitts, signed back something that was probably *understood* and possibly *aubergine*.

The skiff slid into a canal.

Edith had read the briefing. The numbers. She'd thought she understood the numbers. *Spaces between* — that was the name, Nan Madol, the gaps between ninety-two islets, the water doing as much work as the stone. She had not understood that the gaps would *breathe*. The canals were tidal. The whole city inhaled twice a day and exhaled twice a day, and the basalt sat in it patient as a crocodile, and the light came down green through the mangrove and lay on the black columns like something poured.

"Land it," she said, before she could stop herself. Then, to Saimon, hand half-raised: "May I — the wall?"

He looked at the man in the bow. The man in the bow looked at the wall, then at her, and gave a nod so small it was barely weather.

She made the photograph.

"So," Saimon said, when they'd put in at a stone landing furred green at the waterline. "The official story. You want it straight, your fixer said. I can do straight. I like straight. Straight is the part I can stand on."

He walked them up onto the islet, and the crew followed, and Edith hung back half a step the way she always did, because the half-step was where the frame lived.

"This is a city for the dead," Saimon said. "Built by a real dynasty — the Saudeleur — who unified this island under one rule and held it for centuries. We have the radiocarbon. The monumental building, the stone you're standing on, starts around **AD 1180**." He let that sit. "Medieval. Same century the Europeans were arguing about who got to build cathedrals. While that was happening, here" — he spread a hand at the black walls — "people were doing *this*."

"How many islets?" Yusuf asked. He'd pulled out his little notebook, the waterproof one. Yusuf liked a number he could hold.

"About ninety-two. Artificial — every one. Built up on the reef flat. The

core runs maybe a kilometre and a half by half a kilometre, threaded with the canals you came in on.” Saimon crouched, put his palm flat on a basalt column the size of a fallen tree. “And here’s the first thing everybody gets wrong, so let’s kill it now. People look at these and think somebody carved hexagonal logs. Nobody carved anything.” He rapped it with a knuckle. “Columnar basalt. When thick lava cools slow, it cracks into columns — six-sided, mostly. The Giant’s Causeway. Devils Tower. Nature pre-cut the stone into these long prisms. You could go up the coast and find them lying in the ground like cordwood.”

“So that’s the easy part,” Frik said.

“That’s the *free* part,” Saimon said. “Nature did the quarrying-shape for you. Don’t let anyone tell you that’s the mystery. The columns being column-shaped is not the mystery.” A beat. “Hold onto that. We’ll need it.”

Edith watched Mira’s eyes go to *we’ll need it* and stay there a moment. Filing it. Mira filed things the way Edith framed them — sideways, for later.

He walked them around to the foot of the great enclosure and Edith stopped breathing properly for a while.

The wall went up. That was the only honest way to put it: it went *up*, in a way photographs of it on a laptop in a hotel in Kolonia had entirely failed to do, because a photograph flattens and a wall like this is the refusal of flat. Five and a half metres in the low places. Seven and a half where it reared at the corners — taller than the skiff was long, taller than three Friks, black logs laid one across the next, the long face then the end, the long face then the end, course on course climbing into the canopy.

“Header and stretcher,” Yusuf murmured. He was looking at the binding pattern. “Like — like brick. Like a wall a person would build.”

“Like a *good* wall a person would build,” Saimon said, and there was real love in it. “Log-cabin style. You alternate — lay one along, lay the next across so it ties the course below. No mortar. Nothing holding it but its own weight and the way it’s woven. On a base of coral rubble

fill.” He looked up at it with them. “It’s been standing eight hundred years. Through typhoons. On a reef. Mortarless.”

The fish — they’d brought the fish, of course; it rode in a cooler of seawater and had opinions — surfaced in the cooler Frik had set down and said, conversationally, *“Eight hundred years and no mortar. My last landlord couldn’t keep a shelf up for eight hundred hours.”*

“Ignore him,” Frik said.

“I never ignore a fish,” Saimon said, gravely, and Edith decided then that she liked him.

“Give me the numbers,” Yusuf said. “The whole-thing numbers. I want the mass.”

Saimon’s face did something — a tightening, almost a wince, like a man asked to say aloud a figure that he privately found indecent.

“All of it. The whole complex. Best estimates: around **three-quarters of a million tonnes** of basalt.” He let it land. “Seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes of stone, out here, on the reef.”

Yusuf wrote it. Looked at it. “Over how long?”

“The monumental phase — call it four centuries.”

Edith watched Yusuf do the arithmetic in the notebook, lips moving, and watched the number come out the bottom of the sum, and watched his face when it did. He turned the notebook so the others could see, the way you’d show someone a strange insect.

“That’s eighteen hundred and fifty tonnes a year,” Yusuf said. “Sustained. Every year. For four hundred years.” He looked up at the wall. “Two tonnes of basalt, near enough five days out of seven, hauled out onto this reef and *put up there*, for four hundred years without a gap long enough to forget how.”

“That’s the number,” Saimon said quietly. “I told you I like straight. That’s as straight as it gets.”

Mira had moved to the base of the wall. She’d put her hand on the lowest course — flat, the way Saimon had — and she was looking up the face of it, and Edith lifted the camera and got her there: the small

woman, the great black wall, her head tipped all the way back. The composition wrote itself. *Don't caption it*, she told herself. *Just keep it.*

"And the cornerstone," Saimon said, because Yusuf had the look of a man who would ask.

He took them around to the corner. The corner is where a builder tells the truth. Anyone can lay a wall along; the corner is where the load turns, where the woven courses have to bind in two directions at once, and the stone at the bottom of a corner carries everything above it.

"This one," Saimon said.

It was not a column. It was a *boulder* of basalt, a single block, and Edith's eye — which was good at this, which had measured rubble and rebar in a dozen ruined cities to know where it was safe to stand — refused it at first, the way you refuse a thing whose size your brain files under *impossible* and bins.

"How much?" Frik said.

"Around fifty tonnes."

Nobody said anything. The canal breathed. Somewhere off in the mangrove a bird made a sound like a hinge.

"Fifty tonnes," Yusuf repeated. He'd stopped writing.

"One stone," Saimon said. "At the bottom of the corner. Where the whole thing turns." He crouched by it, not touching, just near. "Now. The columns themselves — your ordinary wall-stone — those run anywhere from five tonnes to twenty-five. Plenty of them on the heavy end. Twenty-five tonnes, lifted into a wall seven metres up. No mortar to forgive your mistakes. By hand."

Frik said, slowly, "On a reef."

"On a reef."

"With no crane."

"No crane. No documented ramp. No machine of any kind we've found, and nothing left lying about that says *here's how we did it.*"

Saimon stood, brushed his knees. “And the basalt didn’t come from *here*. The good column stone is up the other side of the island. Call it twenty-five miles. By sea.”

The fish, from the cooler, said: “*So they floated a fifty-tonne rock twenty-five miles, then lifted it. I float, and I can tell you, fifty tonnes does not float.*”

“No,” Saimon agreed. “It doesn’t.”

This was the part Edith would think about later, in the skiff, going back out on the falling tide. The way Saimon told it.

A lesser man — a man with something to sell — would have leaned into the mystery here. Lowered his voice. Said *and no one knows how* with a little theatrical shiver, the way the documentaries did, the way the resort prospectus did (she’d seen the prospectus; Yusuf had seen who was paying for the prospectus). Saimon did the opposite. Every fact he laid down made the feat *larger* and he laid each one down flatter, with more respect, like a man building a wall himself — header, stretcher, header, stretcher — and the more he revered it, the higher it rose, and the more impossible the thing in front of them became.

That was the trick of it, Edith understood, watching him. There was no trick. He wasn’t building the mystery. The mystery was what you got when you took the official story — the real one, the medieval dynasty, the radiocarbon, the known kings, the textbook columnar jointing, nature doing the quarrying for free — and you *believed every word of it* and then you stood at the corner and looked at the fifty-tonne stone.

The fringe wanted it to be aliens because aliens were *easier*. Aliens let you off the wall. What Saimon was doing was harder and braver and Edith loved him for it: he was refusing to make it easy. He was saying *people did this*, and meaning it, and then standing in the gap that left.

“You’re not going to tell us how,” Frik said. It wasn’t quite a question.

Saimon smiled, and there was no shiver in it, no theatre, just a tiredness that went back further than the morning. “I’m going to tell you

what we know. We know who. We know when. We know what it's made of and how the courses bind. We know it's a grave for kings." He looked up the wall one more time. "How they got fifty tonnes onto that corner — by hand, off a raft, eight hundred years ago?" He spread his hands, and for the first time the clipboard hand and the empty hand did the same thing. "We've tried to do it again. People have come, good people, with rigs and a plan. It doesn't come out like this. It comes out — less."

"Less how?" Yusuf said.

"Less *standing*," Saimon said.

The man in the bow had come up the landing while they talked. He stood now at the edge of the islet where the stone met the water, an older man, very still, and he had been listening — Edith was sure of it — to all of it.

Saimon turned to him, and something in the turn changed the room. The archaeologist who'd held the floor all morning, who'd given them the numbers and the love and the cold straight truth of it, took half a step back the way Edith took half a step back, and made the older man the centre of the frame without a word.

"This," Saimon said, "is Soulik. He keeps this place." A pause that was itself a kind of protocol. "If you want past the official story — and everyone always wants past the official story —" the smallest dry smile "— that's not mine to give."

The crew waited. Frik, for once, kept his mouth shut. The fish, for once, kept its.

Mira was watching the old man's face.

She'd gone very still herself, the particular stillness Edith had learned to read over three books together — not the stillness of someone who'd stopped seeing but of someone who'd seen something and was deciding what to do with it. Mira's eyes moved from Soulik's mouth, which hadn't opened, to his hands, which hadn't moved, to the set of his shoulders against the great black wall.

The old man said, in careful English, looking out at the canal and not at any of them, "We don't know how they did it."

And Edith, lens down at her side, watched Mira hear that — watched the words land — and watched something close behind Mira's eyes that was not disappointment.

It was recognition.

Mira didn't lift her hands to sign it. She just held it, the way you hold a stone you've decided not to throw.

The tide had turned. Out in the channel the water had begun, very quietly, to leave.

Chapter 3 — The Man Who Reads the Wall

The tide came in the way Pohnpei does everything, without hurry and without apology, and the skiff sat down on the reef flat as gently as a hand laid on a table. Frik climbed out into shin-deep water that was warmer than the air and stood there a second, holding the gunwale, feeling the coral fill grind under his soles — not sand, not stone, a rubble of broken reef packed down by people who'd been dead four hundred years.

He looked up at the wall and his chest did the thing it does.

He was an engineer. He had been an engineer since he was eight years old and took the back off his mother's radio to see why it talked, and the feeling that came over him at Nandauwas was the same one — the *who did this, and how, and may I please understand it* — multiplied by a number he didn't have a name for. The wall went up out of the canal like a thing that had decided to. Five and a half metres at the low end. Past seven where it cornered. Black basalt logs, hexagonal in cross-section, the long ones laid flat and the short ones laid end-on into the face, course on course, so the whole mass bound itself together by its own geometry. No mortar. None. He'd read that and not believed it and now he was looking at the gap between two columns where you couldn't have slid a coin.

"Okay," Frik said, to nobody. "Okay. That's not fair."

"Took you long enough," said the fish, from the dry-bag clipped at his hip, in the voice he'd long ago stopped questioning. *"Wall's been standing eight centuries. You've been standing in it ninety seconds."*

“Give me a minute.”

“It’s not going anywhere. That’s sort of the whole problem with it.”

Mira had come ashore further along, picking her way up the islet’s edge with that economy she had, the watching economy, reading the footing the way she read everything. Edith was already low and sideways behind the camera, finding the angle where the wall ate the sky. And then there was Jakobus, last out of the boat, the way he was always last, off his own ground and a long way from the Beast — which sat shipped and idle and entirely useless on a continent where there were roads, because there were no roads here, only water and the spaces between.

He didn’t look up at the wall first. Friik noticed that. Everyone looked up at the wall first; it pulled your eye like a held breath. Jakobus looked at the *base*. At the coral, at the waterline, at the place where the bottom course of columns sat into the fill. He crouched there with his forearms on his knees and he read it the way Friik had once watched a structural man read a forty-year-old bridge: not impressed, not unimpressed, *attending*.

Friik went and crouched next to him because that was where he wanted to be.

“It’s a raft,” Jakobus said, after a while. Quiet. Not to the crew. More like a man saying a thing aloud to check whether it stayed true once it left his mouth. “The whole islet. Coral rubble piled on the reef to make ground that isn’t ground. Then the wall sits on the raft.” He put two fingers flat against the lowest column, the wet one, the one the canal had been licking since the Saudeleur were kings. “Soft thing carrying the hard thing. Usually it’s the other way round.”

“It hasn’t subsided,” Friik said. He couldn’t keep the wonder out of it and didn’t try. “Seven metres of stacked stone, no foundation but coral fill, on a *reef*, in the wettest place on earth, and it’s *plumb*. That should have slumped. That should have walked itself into the canal three hundred years ago.”

“Why hasn’t it?”

“Because they built it as a—” Friik stopped, because he was about to caption the thing and Jakobus hadn’t asked him to. “I don’t know yet.”

“Good,” said Jakobus, and there was no sting in it. He stood, knees cracking, a man who’d crouched on a great many made things in a great many places that were not his home. “Now look at how it stands.”

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it is true, and the people who reconstructed it did so with patience and trowels and radiocarbon and decades, and they deserve the love they don’t usually get.

Nan Madol is a city for the dead. Ninety-odd artificial islets laid on the reef flat off the southeast coast of Pohnpei, threaded with tidal canals so the place reads from above like a drowned chessboard — the Venice of the Pacific, the brochures say, and for once the brochures undersell it. The name means *the spaces between*. The water between the islets is not a moat or an accident; it is the architecture. You move through this city by canoe, on the tide, the way you move through Venice by boat, except no one ever lived here. There is no fresh water on these islets. Nothing edible grows. Every cup, every fish, every breath of cooking smoke had to be paddled in across the lagoon. It was a capital with no citizens — the seat of the Saudeleur, the dynasty that bound Pohnpei under one rule, and above all a place to lay their dead, in the great enclosure called Nandauwas, behind walls a grown man cannot see over.

The stone is the joke that nature told first. It’s columnar basalt — the same physics that built the Giant’s Causeway, the same that stands Devils Tower up out of Wyoming. Thick lava cools, contracts, and cracks itself into long prismatic columns, hexagonal, regular, *log-shaped*. Nature pre-cut the blocks. You do not have to quarry a square edge out of these; the planet hands them to you ready to stack. That’s the part the lost-continent crowd never sits with, because it deflates the magic in exactly the wrong direction: the miracle is not that the stones are strangely shaped. The miracle is what was *done* with them after nature was done being clever.

And the megalithic city is medieval. Radiocarbon puts the monumental phase at around AD 1180 — not antediluvian, not pre-flood, not a relic of sky-people, but contemporary with the building of the great cathedrals, raised by a known dynasty that fell to a man named

Isokelekel around the early seventeenth century. It is hard, cited, astonishing, ordinary-human archaeology.

And yet.

Jakobus walked the face of the wall slow, with one hand trailing along it, and Frik walked with him, and the fish kept its peace for once, which it only did when it was watching too.

“Header,” Jakobus said, and tapped a column laid end-on, its hexagon staring out of the wall like a stopped clock. He moved his hand a course up and along. “Stretcher.” A long column, laid flat, running the length of the face. “Header. Stretcher.” His hand kept moving and the pattern kept being there, course alternating against course, the long ones running one way and the short ones biting back into the depth of the wall behind them, knitting the outer face to the rubble core. “It’s a log cabin. Exactly a log cabin. You lay your logs long, then you turn a course and lay them across so they grip the ones below. A child builds a fence this way with sticks. The grammar’s the same whether the stick weighs a kilo or—”

“Five tonnes,” Frik said. “These run five to twenty-five tonnes. The columns. Each.”

Jakobus stopped walking.

He stood and looked at the wall the way you look at a sentence in a language you half-know, finding the verb. “So the binding’s free,” he said. “The geometry does the binding. You don’t need mortar because every stone you lay across pins the two stones under it, and the weight does the rest. That’s why it’s plumb after eight hundred years. It isn’t holding *together*. It’s holding *down*. Every course presses the one below into the coral, and the coral takes it, and the canal takes the coral, and the reef takes the canal.” He moved his flat hand down through the air, course by invisible course, all the way to the water. “It’s a stack of weight finding the sea floor. That’s how it stands.”

Frik felt the back of his neck prickle. It was right. It was *obviously* right, and he hadn’t had it, and a man who couldn’t have told you a megapascal from a mango had read it off the stone in four minutes flat because he wasn’t asking the engineer’s question. He was asking the older one. *What is the made thing, and what holds it up.*

“You’re good at this,” Frik said, and meant it the whole way down.

“I look at things that don’t fall down for a living,” Jakobus said. “There’s a grammar. You learn the grammar.” He glanced at Frik, dry. “You learn it faster than I did. You just learned it pointing the wrong end.”

“He’s not wrong,” the fish offered. “You did walk up and start admiring the part nature already did.”

“I’m allowed to admire the basalt.”

“Admire away. The basalt did nothing. The basalt cooled. Big day for the basalt.”

Here is the part where the easy story sits down in the mud and won’t get up.

Say you accept it all — the dynasty, the date, the log-cabin grammar, nature’s pre-cut blocks, the coral raft taking the weight down to the reef. Lovely. Now build it.

The basalt isn’t here. The quarries are on the far side of the island, the Sokehs side, something like twenty-five miles off — across open water, on the tide. So before you lay a single header you have to get a five-tonne column, or a fifteen-tonne column, or in one particular case a cornerstone weighing somewhere around fifty tonnes, off a hillside, down to a shore, onto something that floats, *across the sea*, and up onto a reef. By hand. With rope and timber and people and the tide. No crane. No iron. No wheel that would do you any good on a reef anyway. And then you have to lift it — not roll it, *lift* it, course on course, up a wall that ends seven and a half metres in the air — and you have to do it about seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes’ worth of times, which works out, if you spread it flat across the four centuries the place was rising, to something on the order of eighteen hundred tonnes a year, every year, for longer than the United States has existed, onto islets that grew no food to feed the haulers and held no water to give them to drink.

And here is the cold-eyed part, the part the line will not let anyone shout past: people with degrees and budgets and good intentions have tried to reproduce it. Experimental archaeology. Smart, careful,

modern, *get-the-column-onto-the-wall* tried. And it has not, to date, been done. Not “physically impossible.” Not “therefore aliens” — set that down, it’s not yours and it never was. Just: the brightest people, in daylight, with a plan, tried the easy version, and the easy version did not come.

Frik stood at the foot of the fifty-tonne corner and looked up the height of the wall and felt the number land in his body the way it’s supposed to. He was an engineer. He could spec the lift. He could draw you the sheerlegs and the ramps and the gangs and the rollers, he could put it all on paper and the paper would be beautiful and the paper had been tried and the paper made a potato while the real thing stood flawless and silent at his shoulder, wet at the bottom, plumb to the top, not telling.

“How,” he said. Just the one word.

Jakobus didn’t answer it, because it wasn’t his question and he knew the difference between his and not-his better than any man Frik had ever met.

They stood at the canal’s edge, the four of them, where the islet ran out into the water and the water ran on into the city, between the stone, into the spaces between.

Frik waited for Jakobus to do the thing. To turn to the crew and say *now then*, to hand them the puzzle the way a man hands his apprentices the next bolt. He’d seen it coming the whole walk up the wall, the relay, the moment where the road steps back and lets the cleverer people take the lead. That was the shape Frik expected because that was the shape stories like this always had: the local mystery, the visiting minds, the crack and the solve.

And Jakobus read the wall one more time — the whole of it, the height and the haul and the held weight — and then he turned, and he did not turn to Frik.

He turned to the water. To the far side of the canal, where the custodian had come down quietly while they were lost in the stone and now stood with the patience of a man who had watched a great many outsiders fall in love with a wall, on a bit of ground that was theirs.

“I can read what it is,” Jakobus said, across the spaces between, in the flat plain voice he kept for the truest things. “I can read how it stands. Header and stretcher, weight to the reef, the geometry does the binding.” He let that sit on the water a second. “What I can’t read off the stone is what it’s *for*.”

He didn’t ask it. He set it down at the edge of the canal like an offering and he stepped back from it, and Mira — who had been reading the custodian’s face the whole time, the way she read every face, watching for the truth the words might not carry — went very still, because she had already seen, three beats before the rest of them, that the answer was there behind the custodian’s eyes, kept, whole, and that it was his to give across the water, or his to keep.

The fish, for once, said nothing at all.

The tide turned, and began, without hurry, to come back in.

Chapter 4 — The Door Held Shut

The tide came in the way it had been coming in for eight hundred years, without hurry, filling the canals between the islets a finger-width at a time, and the custodian waited for it the way you wait for a kettle — not watching, just present.

His name was Lehdesin. He had come down the path from the road on his own feet, in flip-flops and a faded shirt with a tuna company's logo on the pocket, and he had brought no one with him, which Mira logged and did not understand yet. He had a face that had spent a lot of years outdoors and a way of standing that put his weight on neither foot in particular, so that he could turn to the water or away from it with the same small effort. He stood at the lip of the canal where the coral fill gave way to the channel, and he looked at the wall of Nandauwas across the water, and he let them arrange themselves.

They were not good at being looked at. That was the thing about the crew, the load-bearing thing — they were the ones who looked, who had spent their whole lives reading rooms because no room had ever just handed them the words. Being on the receiving end of an unhurried gaze made Yusuf check the lashings on his bag twice and made Frik say something about the basalt that nobody answered.

Edith had the camera down. Not off — down, on its strap, against her sternum, the lens cap on, both hands visibly nowhere near it. She had asked Lehdesin before they crossed whether she could shoot, and he had said *some of it*, and she had not yet asked which, and Mira saw that she was not going to until he told her. That was new for Edith. That cost her something. Mira watched the cost cross her shoulders

and settle.

“You can see the courses from here,” Frik said, because he could not help it and because it was true. “Look — long face, then end-on, then long face. Header, stretcher. Same bind as a log cabin.” He was right; Mira had seen Jakobus read exactly that wall the day before, his thumb tracing the alternation in the air, *how it stands, how it stands*. The hexagonal columns lay in the wall like cordwood, five courses, eight, the prisms nature had pre-cut in some old cooling lava field stacked dry, no mortar, the long basalt logs crossing each other to lock the wall against itself. It rose out of the canal to something like the height of a two-storey house and it had stood through every typhoon the Pacific had thrown at it.

“That’s the easy part,” Yusuf said. He said it gently. He had run the arithmetic out loud two nights ago and nobody had enjoyed it. Three-quarters of a million tonnes. Eighteen-fifty a year if you spread it flat across four centuries, which nobody did, which meant the real years were worse. A cornerstone that came in around fifty tonnes — one stone, the weight of a loaded articulated lorry, set onto a wall, on a reef, by hand. The quarry on the Sokehs side, twenty-five miles away across open water. No crane in the record. No ramp left behind. No documented method at all.

The stacking’s a craft, Hecklefish observed from the gunwale of the skiff, where he had appointed himself supervisor. *The stacking I’ll buy. It’s the part where you float a lorry to the haunted Venice that I’d like minuted.*

Mira didn’t look at the fish. She looked at Lehdesin, because Lehdesin had not looked at the wall the whole time Frik was reading it.

He was looking at the water.

Yusuf was the one who asked. He’d been chosen for it without anyone choosing, the way the crew did things — he had the warmest open face of any of them and he asked questions like he genuinely could not wait for the answer, which he could not. He crouched a little to bring himself level, which Mira clocked as the right instinct done a half-beat too obviously, and he said:

"Can I ask you something? The columns. The big ones. Twenty-five miles of open sea, and then up onto the wall." He nodded at Nandauwas, at the cornerstone they could not see from here, at the whole enormous fact of it. "How did they move them?"

The tide turned a small piece of weed in the canal. A skiff went by out past the breakwater islets, an outboard, a man and a boy, the boy's hand trailing in the wake.

"We don't know," Lehdesin said.

He said it kindly. He said it the way you'd tell a child the name of a star you didn't actually know the name of, no shame in it, no shutter coming down that you could hear. He even smiled a little.

"There are stories," he went on, and his voice did the thing a voice does when it is about to recite. "Some people say the brothers brought the stones by air. Olisihpa and Olosohpa. They sang the stones up out of the ground and they flew through the air to the reef and set themselves down. That is one story." He spread one hand at the wall, palm up, an offering, *take it or leave it*. "The scientists came. The university people, they found columns on the seabed out there." A small nod toward the lagoon. "They said: cargo. The canoes were carrying stone and some of it went over the side. Lost in the water." He shrugged, easy. "Maybe that. Rafts, maybe. Many men. We don't know how."

Frik leaned in, lit up. "But the seabed columns — if that's a wreck site, that's transport evidence, that's —"

"Lost cargo," Lehdesin agreed, before Frik could build the cathedral. "That is what they said. Stone that fell off the boats." He let it sit. He did not say whether he thought the boats were rafts or canoes or anything at all. He had handed them the official line, both halves of it, the science and the song, laid side by side on his open palm, and he had stepped back from both.

Well, that was thorough, the fish muttered. He even brought the receipts. Why do I feel like I just got a tour of the gift shop?

Yusuf nodded, and thanked him, and meant it, and turned to Frik to say something about the Oregon survey, and the conversation moved on the way water moves when it finds a lower place to go, and nobody noticed.

Mira noticed.

Here is what she had: a lifetime of hearing rooms. A lifetime spent two beats behind the words because the words came through air she couldn't fully use, so she'd learned to read the channel under the channel — the jaw, the hands, the place where a person's weight goes when they say a thing they mean versus a thing they've decided to say. She did not read minds. She read bodies. She read *that* a thing was held; she never once in her life had read *what*. The content was always somebody else's to give, and she had spent forty years on the wrong side of that, the one talked over, the one spoken for, the one handed the *we don't know* by every doctor and teacher and well-meaning stranger who'd ever decided her not-knowing was simpler than their explaining.

She knew the shape of a *we don't know* that meant *I don't know*.

This was not that shape.

When you don't know a thing, the not-knowing lives in your eyes — they go up and to the side, they go hunting, they cast about in the empty cupboard for the thing that isn't there. Yusuf's eyes did it constantly; it was half his charm. Frik's never stopped doing it. A true *we don't know* leans forward into the gap, because not-knowing is uncomfortable and a person tries to close it.

Lehdesin had leaned back.

His eyes had not gone hunting. They had gone to the water and stayed on the water, steady, the way you rest your eyes on something you already know the whole of. His weight had settled, both feet, the way Mira's father's weight used to settle when a salesman started talking, the way a man stands when he has already decided how much of himself the moment is getting and it is not all of it. His hands, when he spread them at the wall, had opened *toward* them — a gift — but the gift was the story, not the answer, and the difference between offering a story and offering a truth lives in a quarter-inch of the wrist, and Mira had watched the quarter-inch.

And the kindness. That was the tell that finished it. He had been kind. You are not kind to someone about a thing that hurts *you*. You are kind to them about a thing that is *theirs to be hurt by* and not yours.

He had been kind to them the way you are kind to people standing outside a house in the rain — sorry you can't come in, here's the porch, here is some of the porch.

The not-knowing wasn't in him. The not-saying was. They were not the same animal at all, and only one of them lived in the eyes, and his eyes were out on the lagoon where the lost cargo lay, calm as a man who has known exactly where everything is his whole life.

It was a door. Shut. With a hand on the other side of it, holding it, and a face that had got very good at making the holding look like an open palm.

Mira's whole life had wanted to be on the inside of a door like that. Her whole life people had stood at a door and decided what she got of the room beyond it, and she had hated them for it with a clean cold hatred that had never once helped. The wanting came up in her now, fast and familiar, *what is it, what's behind it, I can read you, just stop holding it and let me —*

And she watched it come, and she watched what it was.

It was the salesman's hunger. It was every doctor's *it's simpler if I just*. It was the precise reflex of the person who decides they have a right to the room beyond someone else's door because they're so sure they'd be gentle in there.

She put it down.

She did not decide to put it down so much as recognise that she did not get to pick it up — that the door was his, and the holding was his, and that a man does not stand alone at the edge of his ancestors' grave-city and recite the song and the science both, carefully, kindly, to outsiders, by accident. He had built that little porch on purpose. He had built it many times. He had probably built it for the university people in 1988 and for every documentary crew since, and the building of it was itself the answer to a question they hadn't earned the right to ask: *who is this for, and who is it kept from?*

The others were ten feet down the canal edge now, Yusuf framing the long view for Edith, Edith with her hand finally moving toward the lens cap and then stopping, looking back at Lehdesin first, waiting.

Lehdesin gave her a small nod — *that one, yes* — and she lifted the camera and shot the wall and not the man, and Mira saw him register that she'd understood which was which.

Mira came to stand beside him at the lip of the water. Close enough to be with him, not so close as to crowd the door. She didn't ask anything. She had run out of things she was allowed to ask, and the relief of it was enormous and strange.

The tide had come up another finger. The bottom course of the far wall was wet now, the basalt gone dark where the canal touched it.

"You already know," she said. Not a question. She kept it low and slow so he could see her mouth, and she kept her own face open, no triumph in it, nothing to win. "How they moved them. Whether the dragon's a way of saying something true. What this whole place is *for*." She let her gaze go out to the same patch of lagoon his had been resting on. "You know all of it."

He didn't answer. His weight stayed on both feet.

"That's all right," she said. "I'm not asking."

And she felt — not saw, there was nothing to see, he gave away exactly nothing, which was its own kind of answer — she felt the air at the door change very slightly, the way it does when the person on the inside stops bracing because the knock has stopped coming.

She's not going to make him say it, the fish said, from very far off, and for once there was no heckle in it at all. *Huh*.

Lehdesin looked at her then, properly, the first time he had looked at any of them the way he'd been looking at the water. Whatever he read in her — and she had no doubt he was reading her, that he had been reading all of them since the path, that he out-read her the way the water out-waited her — he seemed to find what he was looking for.

"The tide's right in an hour," he said. "If you want to see the inside of Nandauwas." A pause. "Some of it."

Some of it. The porch, extended. But extended.

"We'd be honoured," Mira said, and meant the word, which she almost never did.

Behind them Yusuf was explaining columnar jointing to nobody, and Frik was arguing with Yusuf about it, and Edith was lowering the camera again because there was a thing happening at the water's edge that wanted not to be filmed, and the wall stood across the canal holding up three-quarters of a million tonnes of pre-cut stone and one entire unbroken silence, and not one of them — not the crew, not the experiments, not the divers, not a hundred years of asking — had laid a hand on it, because it was being held, deliberately, by a man in flip-flops who knew precisely how heavy it was.

The water came in another finger. Lehdesin watched it come.

So did Mira. And for once in her life, she let the thing she could not have stay where it was, on the far side of a door that wasn't hers, and found that the not-knowing, when you chose it instead of having it chosen for you, felt almost exactly like wonder.

Chapter 5 — The Adversary Surfaces

The Pohnpei State office in Kolonia kept its air-conditioner running like a grievance — a window unit, rust-streaked, dripping into a coffee can someone had set beneath it years ago and never moved. The can was full. Yusuf watched a drop hang off the lip, swell, let go. Across the table, a man in a pressed lavender shirt was sliding a folder toward the middle of the laminate like he was dealing a hand he already knew would win.

“We’re calling it Madolenihmw Heritage Gardens,” the man said. His name was Pruitt — Garrett Pruitt, *Director of Cultural Development*, a phrase that had been printed on a card and handed across with both hands, the way you’d give someone a gift. “Working title. Marketing’ll murder it.”

He laughed at his own joke. He had the easy warmth of a man who’d never once been the only person in a room who couldn’t follow the conversation, and so didn’t know to watch for it.

Yusuf opened the folder.

The renderings were good. That was the first thing — they were *good*, expensive, the kind of work that costs real money to make look this effortless. An aerial of the reef flat, the islets laid out in their soft greens and tidal silvers, and woven through them a network of teak boardwalks on slim pilings, lit from below so the canals glowed at dusk. A “discovery center” with a living roof. A “wellness pavilion.” Little figures in linen, leaning on rails, gazing at the basalt with the precise expression of people who have paid to feel something.

“Elevated walkways,” Pruitt was saying. “Zero-footprint. Nothing touches the stone. We had marine guys out, ecology guys. The whole point is preservation — you can’t preserve a thing nobody visits, that’s just decay with extra steps.”

Beside Yusuf, Mira had her chin tipped slightly down, eyes up, the way she sat when the words were going to matter less than the man saying them. Edith had not taken her camera out of the bag. She’d taken her hands off it, which was a different thing, and Yusuf had learned to notice that too.

The lawyer had said nothing yet.

Her name was Loretta Henos. She’d come in with the folder already on the table, which told you whose office this actually was; she sat to the side, not across, a legal pad squared to the table edge and a pen she hadn’t uncapped. Marine Conservation and Heritage Law, the NGO on her lanyard, the letters small. She’d shaken everyone’s hand and then gone still in a way Yusuf recognized because it was his own way — the stillness of someone doing arithmetic while the other person does theatre.

Linen people, said the fish, who had wedged himself into the coffee can’s water and was regarding the renderings with naked contempt. Look at ’em. Gazing. You don’t gaze at a graveyard, pal, you take your hat off.

Yusuf turned a page.

Here was the part he’d been waiting for. Past the renderings, past the ecology appendix with its turtle counts and its mangrove buffers, the language went flat and careful, and flat-and-careful was where the money lived. He read it the way he read everything — slowly, twice, the second time for what wasn’t there.

Whereas the site at Nan Madol is of indeterminate origin and uncertain custodial status —

He read it again.

— and whereas no continuous traditional ownership has been established to the satisfaction of —

“This is beautiful work,” Yusuf said, and meant the renderings, and Pruitt brightened, and Yusuf let him, because the next thing he said

was going to cost the brightness. “Who holds the title now?”

“Well, that’s the elegant part.” Pruitt leaned in. “Nobody, really. It’s State land — reef flat, foreshore. The traditional side, the Nahn-mwarki side—” he made a small respectful gesture, the gesture of a man laying a flower he intends to invoice for “—that’s deeply important, of course, deeply, and we’d want full consultation. But legally, custodially, it’s...” He spread his hands. “It’s open. Which is rare. Which is, frankly, a gift, because it means we can do this *right*, get the framework in place before anybody comes in and does it wrong.”

Indeterminate origin. Yusuf set his finger on the line without pointing to it, just rested it there on the page where Pruitt couldn’t see.

“You’ve done your homework,” Yusuf said.

“We’ve been at this two years.”

“Then you know the radiocarbon. Roughly eleven-eighty for the megalithic phase. You know it’s the Saudeleur capital. You know about Isokelekel, the overthrow, early seventeenth century.” Yusuf kept his voice mild, conversational, a man comparing notes. “That’s not indeterminate. That’s one of the better-dated medieval sites in the Pacific.”

Something moved behind Pruitt’s face. Not alarm. Patience. The patience of a man who has had this exact conversation before and has a paragraph ready.

“You’re right,” Pruitt said. “And isn’t it remarkable? Honestly — it *is*. But here’s the thing.” He tapped the folder, friendly. “We know the *date*. We don’t know the *how*. Nobody does. They quarried that basalt — what, twenty-five miles? Across open water. Seven-and-a-half-meter walls, dry-stacked, a cornerstone people put at fifty tonnes.” He shook his head, and the head-shake was genuine, the wonder was *real*, that was the awful part. “They’ve tried to reproduce it. Smart people, modern equipment. They can’t. Can’t even get close. And if the experts can’t tell you how it was built—” he opened his hands again, the gift gesture, “—then nobody can tell you, with any authority, what it *means*. Or whose it is to speak for. Can they.”

There it was.

Ohh, said the fish, very quietly, all the heckle gone out of

him for a second. *That's a clean one.*

It was. Yusuf would give him that, alone, later, when he wrote it down. It was a clean one. The man had taken the most honest thing about Nan Madol — the genuine, mainstream, expert-acknowledged *we don't know how* — and he'd run it backward, like a current. *We don't know how* became *we don't know what it means*, and *we don't know what it means* became *so it doesn't, securely, belong to anyone*, and a thing that belongs to no one securely is a thing you can build on. The unsolved lift wasn't a problem for the resort. It was the foundation. The mystery wasn't in the way. The mystery was load-bearing.

Yusuf had spent a working life reading documents like this — the grant that funds the road that opens the forest, the conservation easement that turns out to convey the water rights. He knew the shape of a hustle that wore its best clothes to church. This one was tailored.

He glanced at Mira.

She was looking at Pruitt the way you look at a tide line, reading where the water had been. Her hands were quiet in her lap. Then she lifted them, small, just for the crew, and signed — *he believes it. A beat. That part is true.* Her face did a thing that wasn't quite a smile. *Makes the rest worse.*

Yusuf nodded once. That was the trap of it. A liar you can corner. A man genuinely moved by a thing he is also quietly stealing — there's no corner. He'll meet your facts and thank you for them and write them into the brochure.

"The construction question's open," Yusuf said. "I'll grant you that. Honestly open. The lift, the transport — they haven't reproduced it, you're right, and they're frank about it, the good ones. *Not yet reproduced.*" He let the *yet* sit. "But that's a question about an engineering method. It isn't a question about who buries their dead there."

"Buried," Pruitt said gently. "Past tense. With respect."

And the lawyer uncapped her pen.

She didn't write anything. She just uncapped it, set the cap beside the pad, and the small click of it stopped the room the way a tap on a glass stops a table. Pruitt turned to her with the reflex of a man

who'd learned, over two years, exactly which sounds in this office to take seriously.

"Mr. Pruitt has shown you the gardens," Loretta Henos said. Her voice was unhurried and entirely without warmth toward him; toward the crew, neutral, a person establishing a record. "I'd like to show you the parts of the file the renderings sit on top of."

She turned the folder back toward herself, found a page near the bottom without searching, and read.

"'Indeterminate origin.' 'Uncertain custodial status.' 'No continuous traditional ownership established.'" She looked up. "Do you know what those phrases are?"

Nobody answered. Pruitt's smile had gone fixed, a thing left on a shelf.

"They're not findings," she said. "Nobody found those. They're *requests*. They're what you write in the recitals when you want a court, eventually, to treat a thing as empty because saying it's empty enough times in enough documents makes the emptiness load-bearing." She set the page down flat. "The site has custodians. It has had custodians without interruption for eight hundred years. The Nahnmwarki of Madolenihmw holds it. The protocol of who enters, who speaks, what is told and what is kept — that's not a gap in the record. That *is* the record. It's just not written where Mr. Pruitt's lawyers would like to find it filed."

"With respect, Ms. Henos," Pruitt said, and the *respect* was thinner now, "oral tradition isn't title. I wish it were. The State—"

"The State knows exactly what it's sitting on," she said, "which is why this has taken you two years and not two months." She turned to the crew, and now there was the faintest something in her face, dry, almost amused, almost an invitation. "You came here to film stones, I'm told. The lift. The *how*."

"That's what we came for," Edith said. Her hands were still away from the bag.

"Good. Stay on the *how*." Loretta tapped the recital line one more time, the line about indeterminate origin, and she said it without any heat at all, which was what made it land like cold water: "Because

the moment you let him turn *we don't know how* into *we don't know whose*—the second you let those two silences sound like the same silence—you've helped him pour the slab. He's not buying a mystery. He's manufacturing a vacancy. There's a difference, and it's the whole difference, and the only people in this room being paid to confuse them are him."

The window unit dripped into the full can. Pruitt began to say something about partnership, about consultation, about how this was exactly the conversation he'd hoped to have.

Yusuf wasn't listening anymore. He was looking at the rendering — the boardwalks, the underlit canals, the linen people leaning on the rails with their paid-for awe — and he was seeing it the way the lawyer had just taught him to see it in nine seconds flat, faster and cleaner than he'd have gotten there alone. *Zero-footprint*. Nothing touches the stone. Of course nothing touches the stone. You don't have to touch a grave to take it. You only have to get everyone to agree it's a garden.

Mira's hand moved in his peripheral vision. He glanced over.

Two kinds of "don't know," she signed, slow, so Edith could catch it too. *His and theirs*. She looked at Loretta — at the capped pen now recapped, at the woman who had read the whole hand in less time than it took Pruitt to clear his throat. *She knows which is which*. A pause, and then, dry as the rest of her: *We didn't*.

Speak for yourself, said the fish, climbing out of the coffee can dripping, restored to insolence now that there was someone in the room worth respecting. *I clocked the linen*.

Pruitt slid his card across the laminate again, a second copy, in case the first had been lost — both hands, the gift gesture, immaculate to the end.

"Think it over," he said warmly. "There's room in this for everybody."

Loretta Henos stood, gathered her pad, and held the door. She didn't say *that's not true*. She didn't have to. She just held the door, and waited, the way you wait at the edge of a thing that is not yours to cross — and Yusuf understood, picking up the folder, that the silence

she was keeping in that doorway and the silence Pruitt was selling looked, to anyone not watching closely, exactly alike.

He'd been watching closely. It wasn't enough. The drop hung off the lip of the can behind him, swelled, let go.

Chapter 6 — The Water Between

The skiff smelled of two-stroke and bait, and Frik loved it instantly, the way he loved any machine that told the truth about itself. Nothing on it pretended. The outboard had a hose-clamp where a hose-clamp had no business being. The bench he sat on was a plank gone soft at one end, the soft end carefully marked with a strip of red tape so you knew not to trust it. Somebody had thought about this boat. Somebody had read it and made a small repair and trusted the repair to hold, and the boat held.

It was the hour before the colour came back into the world. The lagoon lay flat and pewter and the mangroves were a black saw-edge against a sky that had not yet decided what it would be. Manny had the tiller. He was a wide, unhurried man with a cap that said a thing in faded letters Frik couldn't read and didn't ask about, and he ran the channel without looking at it, the way a man walks his own hallway in the dark.

"Tide's with us," Manny said, to no one, or to the water.

Frik had the dossier on his knees inside a freezer bag, and a pencil, and the small spiral pad he carried everywhere because numbers that lived only in his head got lonely and started lying. He had already, before the diesel-smell, written the thing he could not stop writing.

25 miles. ~50 t. By hand. No crane. Nothing left behind.

Across the boat Mira sat with her back to the bow, watching faces, which was where she lived. She watched Manny mostly. Edith had the camera down in her lap, lens-cap on, both hands around it like a

mug of something hot, and she was watching the light not arrive yet, which was a photographer's particular patience and Frik admired it without understanding it.

"Sokehs," Manny said, and lifted his chin north and west, where the land humped up into a great square-shouldered rock with its head in the cloud. "Where the stone is."

That was the thing. That was the whole impossible sentence, said by a man at a tiller as if it were a grocery errand. *Where the stone is*. The basalt didn't come from Nan Madol. It came from over there — the quarries on the far side, the volcanic flanks where the lava had cooled slow and deep and cracked itself, without a single human hand, into hexagonal logs. Frik liked that part. He liked it enormously. Nature had done the quarrying. Nature had pre-cut the blocks into stackable prisms and stretched them out across the island like a delivery of timber.

And then somebody had to *fetch* them.

He had the official story straight, and he held it with respect, because it deserved respect and because the alternative — the floating-stone, the sky-masons — was an insult to people who had actually done a hard thing.

Here it was, the honest version, the one the archaeologists carried and the one Frik carried with them: a medieval people, a real dynasty with a real name, the Saudeleur, who from around AD 1180 had built a mortuary capital on the reef. Radiocarbon said so. The stone said so — the dry-stacked basalt, header and stretcher, log-cabin courses, a building grammar so legible Jakobus had read it off the wall like a label. Nobody serious doubted the *who*. Nobody serious doubted the *when*.

The doubt — the small clean honest doubt — was the bit in the middle. The bit with the boat in it.

Frik turned in his seat, careful of the soft plank, and looked back at Sokehs. Then forward, southeast, toward the reef they'd come from yesterday, the spaces between the stone. He laid a finger on the gunwale at the rock and dragged it slow across the open water to the place where Nandauwas stood with its seven-metre walls.

“How long’s the crossing?” he asked. “Open water. This boat.”

Manny considered it the way you consider a question that has a real answer. “Hour. Bit more. Depends the sea.” He patted the outboard, which coughed agreement.

An hour, with thirty horsepower and petrol and a hull made for it.

Frik wrote in the pad. He did the thing he did, which Yusuf called *running the potato* and Mira called, with a flat fondness, *Frik being unbearable*. He took the easy version, the move-along version, the version where it was all just a question of effort and grit and many willing hands, and he made it stand up in the daylight and tried to walk it across the room.

~750,000 tonnes total.

He’d checked that figure three ways. It held to an order of magnitude, which was all anyone honest claimed for it. Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt, fetched and floated and stacked.

Over ~4 centuries. ÷ that’s ~1,850 t/yr.

He underlined it twice and felt, as he always did, the strange double thing the number gave him: it was *reassuring*. Eighteen hundred and fifty tonnes a year was not a miracle. It was about five tonnes a day, on average, a working pace, a thing a determined community could plausibly sustain across generations the way cathedrals were sustained, fathers handing trowels to sons. The arithmetic, run cold, did not scream. It hummed. It said: *people did this, over a very long time, and it added up.*

That was the part the sneerers got right, and Frik would give it to them gladly. The total was *not* the hole. The rate was *not* the hole.

He clicked the pencil and turned the page.

The hole was the single block.

“Hecklefish wants to know,” Yusuf said from the bow, deadpan, because somewhere on this boat there was a small waterproof speaker and somewhere in the world there was a fish, “whether you’ve personally lifted fifty tonnes today, or if you’re just going to *write about* it.”

“Tell him I’m doing reconnaissance,” Frik said.

“He says reconnaissance is what people call it when they sit in the boat.”

Mira’s mouth did the thing that wasn’t quite a smile. She wasn’t watching the fish. She was watching Manny, who had heard the fish, and whose face had not moved at all, which was itself a kind of moving.

Frik went back to the page, because the fish was right, which was the unbearable thing about the fish.

He drew the cornerstone. He drew it the way he drew everything, badly and exactly, a fat rectangular prism with hatching for shadow, and beside it he wrote ~50 *t* and beside *that* he wrote, in the small careful hand he used for things that frightened him, *one block*.

Fifty tonnes. The hardest single object to account for in the whole place. The cornerstone of the great enclosure, a column that weighed as much as a loaded articulated lorry — as much as ten of Manny’s skiffs lashed together and stacked to the gunwales — and it had to be quarried out of the Sokehs flank, and brought down to the water, and put *onto* the water, and floated twenty-five miles across the open lagoon and reef on something, and brought to the islet, and then — and this was the part where Frik’s pencil always stopped — then *lifted*. Up. Into a wall. Course on course, dry, no mortar, no crane, no ramp anyone has found, on a reef where there’s no high ground to lever against and nothing solid to footing a sheerlegs into but the city you are in the middle of building.

“What floats fifty tonnes?” he said out loud, not really to the boat. “A raft floats fifty tonnes. Fine. Buoyancy doesn’t care how heavy you are, it cares how much you displace. So you build a big enough raft.” He was sketching it now, a platform, log bundles, the lashing he’d want, and he could feel the thing the sketch was doing, which was getting away from him. “But you load it on a falling tide and float it on a rising one, and the column’s not a neat parcel, it’s a five-metre log of rock, and the moment you’re off the lee shore you’ve got swell, and a thing that displaces that much wants very badly to do one of two things. Sit on the bottom. Or roll.”

“Did they do it on the tide,” Edith asked. It wasn’t really a question

to him. She'd asked it to the water, to Manny, the way you ask the person who actually knows.

Manny had been quiet a while. He throttled down a touch, and the bow came off its plane, and the boat settled into the swell and started to talk to it, lift and fall, lift and fall, and Frik felt in his own gut the difference between *crossing water* and *being on it*.

"My grandfather," Manny said, "would not take this passage in the afternoon."

"Why not," said Frik.

Manny looked at him. Not unkindly. With the specific patience of a man who has watched a great many visitors arrive with a notebook and a number and a theory, and who has learned that the theory will leave on the same plane it came in on, and the passage will still be here.

"Because the wind comes up after midday," Manny said. "And the tide turns. You go out on the morning tide, with the morning wind, light. You come back on the evening tide. There are weeks you do not go at all." He nodded once at the channel ahead, a barely-there seam of darker water Frik would not have seen in a thousand years. "That is the road. The water tells you when. Not you."

Frik looked at the seam.

He looked at his sketch of the raft, and the swell lifting the bow, and the dark line of better water that Manny had been steering down the whole time without once appearing to steer, and he understood — not as a number, as a thing in the body, the boat rising under him — that he had been doing it wrong. He'd been treating the twenty-five miles like a *distance*. A scalar. A thing you divide by a speed. As if you could float fifty tonnes across it any day you chose, given enough rope.

But it wasn't a distance. It was a *door that opened and shut*. A few hours, on the right tide, with the right wind, in the right weeks of the right season — a narrow channel of *permission* through which a raft displacing fifty tonnes might be coaxed, slowly, by people who knew the water the way Manny knew it, the way his grandfather knew it, the way you only know a thing by being told no by it for a lifetime.

And then they did it again. And again. Five tonnes a day, on the days the water allowed. For four hundred years.

The arithmetic hadn't lied. The total was sane. The rate was sane. It was the *single heavy thing, on the single right day, lifted by hand into the single high wall* that wouldn't reduce — that sat in the middle of the sane arithmetic like a stone in a shoe.

Frik did the honest thing then, the cold-eyed thing, the thing the line asked of him, which was to write down not what he believed but what was *true*, measured flat, reached past toward nothing.

He wrote: *No documented transport-and-lift method*. That was a fact. Not a mystery dressed up as a fact. A genuine gap, the kind the experts themselves leave open and shrug at, honestly, the way you shrug at a thing you've decided is solvable but haven't solved. There's no surviving account of the rig. No ramp left in the mud. No abandoned half-floated column on the route to settle the argument — only the ones on the seabed off the Sokehs side, found by divers out of Oregon in the late eighties, and read, soberly and well, as exactly what they most plausibly are: cargo that went over the side. Stone that didn't make the crossing. The wreckage of the haul, not the proof of anything stranger.

And he wrote the other true thing, the one that had been sitting under all of it: *replication has failed*. People had tried. Real people, recent people, with rope and rafts and willing arms and the explicit goal of showing it could be done the routine way — and they had not reproduced it. Not "it's physically impossible." Nobody serious said that, and Frik wouldn't write it. The columnar basalt floats if you build the right raft; the levers work if you have the patience; the arithmetic, run cold, hums and doesn't scream. It is *not yet reproduced*. That was the whole of the honest sentence, and the whole of the honest sentence was enough.

The sun came up, finally, all at once the way it does in the tropics, and the lagoon went from pewter to a green so flagrant Frik laughed at it. Edith took the cap off the lens. Sokehs stood up out of the cloud behind them, the quarry-rock, the *where the stone is*, square-shouldered and complete and entirely unbothered by the fact that nobody alive could say how the stone had got from it to the walls.

"You have your number," Manny said. He'd seen the pad. He missed nothing on his own boat.

"I have my number." Frik turned the pad around and showed him, the way you'd show a man his own hallway. The total. The rate. The fifty-tonne block, drawn badly, drawn exactly. "It works, the average. It's the one block that doesn't. The one block, the one day, onto the wall."

Manny looked at the sketch for a while. The boat lifted and fell.

"My grandfather knew the water," he said again, slowly, and Frik had the clear and humbling sense that this was an *answer*, a whole one, and that he was being trusted with the shape of it but not the inside, the way you're handed a closed box and told, kindly, that the weight of it is the part you get to keep.

"And you know the water," Frik said.

"I know the water." Manny put the throttle back up. The bow came onto its plane and the seam of dark channel opened ahead of them, plain as a road now the light was on it, a road Frik would never have found and Manny could not *not* see. "There are things the water tells you," Manny said, over the engine, not turning round, "that you cannot write down."

Frik looked at the pad. At the number that hummed and didn't scream. At the one block that wouldn't reduce.

He closed the pad and put it back in the freezer bag, and watched the road on the water instead, the one he couldn't read, and for once didn't try to.

Chapter 7 — Lost Cargo

The skiff smelled of two-stroke and bait, and Edith had her camera in a dry-bag on her knees like a thing that might bolt.

Soumas — that was the diver's name, or the part of it he'd offered, a man maybe sixty with forearms like mooring cleats and reading glasses pushed up into grey hair — cut the outboard, and the silence came in over the gunwale the way the tide does, all at once and from underneath. They were at the reef edge off the southeast face, where the lagoon shelves and then doesn't, where the colour under the hull went from the pale green of sand to the kind of blue that has a floor you can't see.

"Here," Soumas said. He didn't point. He just stopped.

Yusuf had the printout in a ziplock, soft at the folds from handling. The University of Oregon survey, 1988 and '89. Divers had gone down off this margin and found basalt columns on the seabed — the same prismatic logs that stood in seven-metre walls a thousand metres behind them, except these were lying in the sand and the silt, scattered, at depth. Hexagonal. Unmistakable. Quarried stone where no quarry is.

"You read it," Soumas said to Yusuf, the way you'd say *show me your hand*.

Yusuf read it. The dry, careful sentences. Submerged columnar basalt. Consistent with the construction stone. Distribution mapped along the channel approaches. He read it flat, the way the report wanted to be read, and Soumas listened with his glasses still up in his hair and his eyes on the water, and when Yusuf finished he made a small sound that wasn't agreement and wasn't argument.

Mira was watching the diver's hands. She'd told Edith once, on a different boat, that you learn more from a man's hands when he's listening than from his face when he's talking. Soumas's hands were loose on his thighs. Loose was a kind of answer.

Edith went down second, after Soumas, with the camera in its housing and the housing's weight pulling her trim wrong until she settled.

She had not wanted to bring the camera. She had wanted to and not wanted to, which was the same argument she'd been having with herself in one form or another since the war, the one where the want and the not-want were the same muscle. You see a thing. You frame it. The framing is a small theft and a small gift and you never get to choose which one it'll turn out to be. So she'd brought it, and she hated that she'd brought it, and she was already composing as she finned down the slope because that was the thing she could not stop doing, the watching she'd been doing since long before the war, since childhood, the only channel anyone had ever left open to her.

The light went long and blue. Soumas swam ahead of her with the economy of a man who'd been doing this since before she was kind to herself, barely moving his legs, and below them the slope steepened and then she saw the first one.

A column. Lying in the silt at maybe eighteen metres, half its length furred with growth, the hexagon of its cross-section clean and shocking and *machined-looking* against the soft chaos of the seabed. Then another, a body's length on. Then, off to the left where the slope fell away into the dark, the suggestion of more — angles that the eye wanted to assemble, the way the eye always wants to assemble.

That was the thing the report didn't have words for. The *wanting*.

Edith brought the camera up. Through the housing port the scene composed itself into the photograph it wanted to be: foreground column, the diagonal of it, Soumas's silhouette above with the surface a hammered sheet behind him, and in the mid-ground that blue suggestion of structure, of *more*, of a city that kept going down past where the light gave out. Frame it like that and you had the cover of a magazine. Frame it like that and you had *the sunken half of Nan Madol*, the drowned streets, the Pacific Atlantis, and every reader who

ever saw it would carry that frame out into the world and it would be, in a way that the actual seabed was not, a lie.

She lowered the camera without taking it.

Coward, said the fish, which had no business being underwater and was anyway only in her head. *That's the shot and you know it. Cthulhu's basement. Print it on a tote bag.*

She let it sink past, the way you let a current go by.

Soumas had stopped over the first column. He looked back to be sure she was watching — not the camera, *her*, the eyes behind the port — and then he did a thing she didn't understand at first.

He laid his palm flat on the seabed beside the column, in the silt, and made a slow line with the edge of his hand. A furrow. Then he pointed up the slope, toward shore, toward the shallows and the islets beyond. Then he made the furrow again, the same direction, and tapped the column, and shrugged the whole-body shrug a diver makes, hands out, that says: *it fell here*.

It fell. It was being moved, and it fell, or the raft swamped, or the lashing parted, and it went down the slope into the blue and stayed where it stopped, and there it was, eighteen metres down and seven hundred years on, lying exactly where a dropped thing lies.

She understood the gesture and she understood that he had chosen the gesture, that he'd brought her down here not to show her a sunken city but to *take the sunken city away from her*, gently, with his bare hand in the silt. The eye wants to assemble. He was un-assembling it for her, one furrow at a time.

She raised the camera again and this time she shot the furrow. His hand. The drag-line in the silt and the column at the end of it and the long empty slope going up toward the light where the work had been *going*. Not the drowned-city frame. The *dropped-cargo* frame. The same stones, the opposite photograph.

It was a worse magazine cover and a truer one. She took three exposures and her hands were steady and that, she'd tell no one, was the whole of why she'd come.

On the surface they hung off the line and pulled their masks down and the world came back loud — the slap of chop on the hull, a frigatebird working the thermals, the far diesel of someone's skiff in the lagoon.

"You see," Soumas said. Not a question.

"I saw it fell," Edith said. "You showed me it fell."

He nodded, slow, and pushed his glasses down out of his hair and onto his nose as if to read her, which after thirty years near these waters he could probably do better with the glasses than without. "Oregon people," he said. "Eighty-eight. Eighty-nine. Good people. They dive, they map, they write it down careful." He tapped his own chest. "Lost cargo. That is the honest one. Stone going to the wall, didn't make the wall. End of the story."

"But," said Yusuf, who had not been able to stop himself for the whole of his life and was not going to start now.

Soumas looked at him with something that was nearly affection. "But," he agreed.

Here is the honest one, the one Soumas had laid out with his hand: the columns on the seabed are the spillage of the haul. You move three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt across open water over four centuries and you are going to drop some of it. The arithmetic Yusuf had been carrying since chapter and verse — the ~1,850 tonnes a year, sustained, for ~400 years — does not just describe a finished wall. It describes a *traffic*. A traffic that long and that heavy leaves wreckage the way a road leaves roadkill, and the wreckage was right there in the silt with Soumas's furrow drawn beside it. The columns underwater are not a drowned structure. They never said they were. The report never said so; Soumas would not say so; and the narrator of this will not say so either, because the honest read is the unglamorous one, and the unglamorous one is true.

That is the floor. That is the thing the dive establishes, cold-eyed, with a man's bare palm.

And now stand on the floor and look at what the floor doesn't cover.

Because the lost cargo is evidence — checkable, mapped, sitting at eighteen metres where anyone with a tank can go count it — of the *haul itself*. Not of a method. Of the *fact*. Stone left the quarry on the Sokehs side, around twenty-five miles off, and crossed open Pacific water, and some of it didn't arrive, and we can prove it didn't arrive because there it lies. What the cargo proves is that the impossible-sounding sentence is *literally true*: they were moving fifty-tonne logs of rock across the sea. The columns on the seabed close the question *did they really haul it that far* — yes — and they leave wide open, gaping, untouched, the question the haul was always about. *By what means*. Rafts that could carry a fifty-tonne cornerstone and mostly not sink. Some manner of lifting it off the raft and up onto a wall already five, six, seven metres high, on a reef, with the tide working against you twice a day. The lost cargo is a receipt for a delivery nobody can reconstruct.

So we proved the UPS truck was real, the fish offered, surfacing for air it didn't need, and we still got no idea how they got the couch up the stairs.

For once nobody told it to shut up.

Mira had stayed in the boat. She didn't dive; the pressure and the ears were a conversation she'd lost too many times. She'd watched the surface instead, the bubbles tracking, and she'd watched Soumas come up first and pull his mask and *not* look pleased, and she'd watched the set of him as he talked to Yusuf and Edith with the chop knocking the hull.

When the others were back aboard and peeling out of their gear, she touched Soumas's wrist to get his eyes — she always asked for the eyes — and signed, slowly, the small fingerspelled-and-gesture pidgin the crew had built around her, *more down there?* and pointed at the dark water and then made the going-on, going-deeper sign they'd agreed on weeks ago, a hand sliding away and down.

Soumas understood her the way Jakobus understood her, by the body, without translation. He looked at her for a moment. Then he looked at the water. Then he did a thing she catalogued and did not interpret: he did not say *no*, and he did not say *yes*. He moved his head a fraction, side to side, the universal *who can say*. And his eyes, when

they came back to her, were doing the careful, lidded thing she'd been watching the custodian's people do all week — the look of a man standing in front of a door he knows the shape of, with his hand flat against it, not opening it for you and not pretending the door isn't there.

She held his gaze and let him see that she'd seen it. *Door*, her own face said back, without words, because words were never the channel she'd been given. *I see the door. I'm not going to push it.*

Something in him let down half an inch.

"Lost cargo," he said again, out loud now, for Yusuf and Edith, for the report, for the record. "That is the true answer." He coiled the line in his cleat-forearms, neat loops, a man putting his boat away. "The Oregon people are right." He looked, once, back at the blue water where the slope went down past the light. "And there are stones down there past where they mapped. I have seen them." He shrugged, and started the outboard, and the two-stroke ate the rest of it, so that whether he'd said *and I have not gone to count them* or *and I will not tell you what they are* or nothing further at all, no one in the boat could have sworn.

Edith had the furrow-shot in the camera. The honest frame. She kept her hand over the dry-bag the whole way in, the way you keep your hand on a thing you're not yet sure you're allowed to have taken.

The reef slid by. The walls of Nandauwas stood up out of the mangrove ahead of them, dry and grey and silent, and somewhere off the southeast face, eighteen metres down and seven hundred years late, a dropped stone lay in the silt at the end of a furrow, pointing the way it had been going.

Chapter 8 — No Water, No Food

By eleven the heat had a weight to it, and Mira had stopped sweating, which she knew was the wrong direction.

She felt it before she could have named it — the lightness behind the eyes, the way the basalt wall in front of her had begun to breathe very slightly at its edges. She put a hand flat on the stone. It was warm as a living thing. She held it there and waited for the world to settle, and watched the others, because watching was the channel she had.

Yusuf was on the islet's seaward wall, a phone held up at the columns, narrating something to nobody. Frik squatted by the canal with the cooler. Edith stood very still near the gap in the enclosure where the morning's tide had run out, the camera down at her hip, not raised, which Mira had learned to read as a kind of breathing.

They had packed for a day. That was the thing.

They had packed the way you pack for a long hot day on any island — water, a bag of rolls gone soft, oranges, the cooler with ice already turning to soup. They had carried it across on the skiff at the slack of the tide and set it on the coral fill of Nandauwas like people who would be fine. And it was, Mira saw now, very nearly the whole joke of the place, sitting in a blue plastic box on a reef.

Pwilin — the caretaker — sat in the shade the great wall threw, where the heat was a degree kinder, and watched them be people who had packed for a day. He had a way of sitting that used no effort at all. His machete lay across his knees. He had not touched the cooler.

"Lovely picnic spot. Seven-metre walls. No bar. One star."

Frik came up the fill with two bottles, handed one to Mira without asking, which he had learned to do. She drank. The water was hot enough to be unpleasant.

"That's the last of the cold," he said, low, mouth angled so she could take it off his lips. "And about half the warm."

She nodded. She did the sum anyway, because the sum was the point. Four of them. Midday. The tide that had carried them in would not carry them out for hours yet, and going against it in the skiff over the reef flat was the kind of thing you did once and told stories about. She looked at the cooler — a day's water for a picnic, dwindling — and then she looked up, and let her eye go out across the islets, ninety-odd of them, the canals between drained silver in the low water, the whole stone city of the dead laid out in the sun.

And there was nothing on any of it to drink. Not a spring. Not a stream. Not a coconut palm doing its patient work over a freshwater lens, because the islets were laid stone on coral rubble and nothing grew on them you'd want to eat. The interior of Pohnpei, eight miles back, was one of the wettest places on the earth — cloud forest, waterfalls, rain you could lean on. Out here, on the reef, in the spaces between, there was the sea, and the sun, and the basalt holding the heat like a brick oven.

She felt the sum land in her body before she finished it in her head, which was the way it always went. Her tongue against the roof of her mouth. The dull pulse starting behind the right eye.

She caught Edith looking at her. Edith always knew first when one of them was paying for the room. The camera came up a fraction, then went back down. Not this. Mira gave her the smallest shake of the head — *I'm fine* — which was a lie they both let stand.

The official story was beautiful and it was true and you could hold it whole in your two hands, which made the next part worse.

This was the Saudeleur capital. The seat of the dynasty that bound

Pohnpei into one rule, here, on these islets, from somewhere around 1180 by the radiocarbon — medieval, not mythic, a real line of real lords. The high ones lived here, in season, with their priests and their attendants and the people who served them. The dead lords were laid in Nandauwas, this enclosure, behind the wall Mira's hand was on, a wall that ran five and a half, seven and a half metres high in dry mortarless basalt, header and stretcher, log on log, the way Jakobus had read it at the canal's edge two days back and then handed the next question on.

So: a court. A capital. People — hundreds of them, the priests, the chiefs, the servants, the families that fed and dressed and guarded them. People who needed, every single day they were here, to *drink*.

And the islets gave them nothing.

Mira had read it in the dossier on the plane and it had been a line — *no fresh water, no food on site, uninhabitable without constant canoe resupply*. A clean little fact, the kind you nod at. Sitting on the warm coral fill of it with her own water down to half a warm bottle, the line stopped being a fact and became a logistics problem with a body's clock on it.

Every drop. Every mouthful of taro, every fish, every cup of fresh water for every soul on these stones — paddled out across the lagoon by canoe, on the tide, and paddled out again, and again, for as long as anyone lived here. Not once. Not for a festival. For generations. Four centuries of monumental building and the entire time it stood, the city could not keep a single person alive for a week on its own.

"Run it forward," Yusuf said. He'd come down off the seaward wall and was crouched by the cooler now, frowning at it like it had insulted him. He did this — turned dread into arithmetic, because arithmetic he could carry. "Say a few hundred people in residence, peak. A litre and a half a day just to not die, more in this. Call it five hundred litres a day, low. Of *water*. Carried. Then the food on top. Then the building crews on top of *that*, for four hundred years."

"And the dead don't eat," Frik said.

"The dead are the only ones who don't," Yusuf said. "Everyone alive out here is a delivery."

“So they built the fanciest address in the Pacific in the one spot you can’t get takeout. Bold. Real bold.”

Mira watched Pwilin while Yusuf talked, because that was where the truth would be if it was anywhere, and it was not in the cooler.

He was listening. Not the polite empty listening of a man waiting for tourists to finish. He had heard all of it before — the sum, the appalled little laugh that came after the sum, the visitor doing the visitor’s discovery out loud. He had heard it from every team that ever rafted out here with a blue cooler and worked out by noon what he had known since he was a boy: that this was not a place you lived. He let Yusuf get to the end of it.

Then he said, mild, to the wall as much as to them: “You brought enough water for one day.”

“We did,” Yusuf said.

“They brought it every day,” Pwilin said. “For four hundred years.”

He let that sit. He was not amazed by it. That was what Mira’s eye snagged on — the absence of amazement. To the crew it was a marvel and a horror, the sheer mad cost of it. To him it was simply *what was done*, the way you’d say a thing your grandmother had told you in a voice that had stopped questioning it a long time ago. The wonder was theirs. The fact was his.

He shifted the machete and looked at Mira directly then, which men did not usually do once they’d worked out she couldn’t hear them well — they tended to drift their faces away, toward someone who’d answer faster. He kept his face square to her. He spoke a little slower, not louder, which was the thing almost nobody got right, and she felt the small specific gratitude of it land in her chest.

“It is heavy,” he said, “to carry water to the dead.”

She read every part of it off him — the mouth, the set of the jaw, the way the word *dead* did not move his eyes the way it moved a stranger’s. And under it, plain to her as a tide line, the thing he was *not* saying. Not hiding, exactly. Holding. There was a reason it was worth it, the carrying, the four centuries of it, and the reason sat be-

hind his face the way the lords sat behind the wall, and he had no intention of bringing it out into the sun for them.

She did not reach for it.

She had spent her whole life in rooms reading what the mouths wouldn't carry, and the hardest thing she had ever learned was the difference between a wall that wants you to climb it and a wall that is doing its job. This was the second kind. She let it be the second kind.

"Yes," she said. Her own voice, the one she didn't fully hear, that she'd built by feel. "It is."

Pwlin looked at her a moment longer. Something in him registered that she'd taken the actual sentence and not the smaller one underneath it. Whatever he saw, he seemed content with it. He nodded once and went back to watching the canal.

The headache had become a fact of its own by then, a hot bar across the brow. Mira sat down on the fill in the wall's thin shade, beside the caretaker but a respectful arm's length off, and put the warm bottle to her mouth and made herself drink the rest of it slowly. The salt was already drying white on her arms. Her body was keeping its own honest ledger, the way bodies did, and the ledger said: *this place is trying, very gently, to make you a delivery problem too.*

That was the door the whole afternoon kept opening onto, and she made herself stand in the draught of it instead of stepping through.

Because the easy answer was right there, and it was wrong. The easy answer said: *defensive. They built it offshore to be safe, that's why it's miserable to live on.* But you don't haul three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt twenty-five miles across open water to a place with no water for *defence*. A stockade is cheaper. A hilltop is cheaper. Anything is cheaper than this. The cost was the answer's enemy. Whatever this was for, it was worth more than the appalling daily price of keeping its people drinking — worth more for four centuries running.

Edith had drifted close. She crouched by Mira, the camera finally up, but pointed away, out across the drained canals where the heat

shimmer made the far islets swim.

“You okay,” Edith said — flat, not a question, the way she said it when she meant it.

“I stopped sweating,” Mira said.

Edith went still. Then she reached into her own bag, not the cooler, her own bag, and put a sachet of electrolyte salts in Mira’s hand and a half-litre she’d been hoarding, and she did it without a word and without looking at the others, the way she did everything that actually mattered, off-frame.

Mira tore the sachet with her teeth and watched the powder cloud the water.

“Drink it,” Edith said. “All of it. Then we sit in the shade and we don’t be clever for an hour.”

“There it is. The whole island’s a kava bar with no kava and the dead don’t tip. Why HERE, you absolute legends. WHY HERE.”

She drank it. The hot bar across her brow loosened by degrees. Across the fill, Yusuf had given up on the cooler and was lying flat on the coral with his hat over his face, conserving, a man who had run the numbers and accepted them. Frik was rationing what was left into a single bottle, marking it, doing the small careful husbandry of someone who’d been hungry before and never forgot the arithmetic of it. The tide was a long way out yet. They were not in danger. They were only, for one afternoon, *living inside the question* — what it cost, every day, to keep the living alive out here, so the dead could lie behind this wall.

And the question stood up off the stone and would not lie back down.

You could explain the lift, maybe, given enough rope and ramps and people and time — Jakobus thought you could, in principle, even if no one had ever managed to prove it on the reef. You could explain the basalt; nature pre-cut it into logs. You could explain the canals and the courts and the dynasty and the radiocarbon. You could explain

everything except the one thing the body kept asking from the inside of a dry mouth at noon.

Not *how*.

Why here. Why this reef, this foodless waterless flat where no living soul could stay a week — why carry the water and the taro and the fish and the whole machinery of being alive across the lagoon, in canoes, on the tide, every day, for four hundred years, to build the grandest thing your people ever made in the one place your people could not live.

Pwilin sat in the shade with his machete across his knees and watched the canal that would, in its own time, fill again and carry them home. He knew. Mira could see that he knew, the same way she could see the heat coming off the wall. It was behind his face, square and unhurried, and it was his.

She lay back on the warm coral beside her crew and looked up at seven metres of stacked black stone against a white sky, and let herself not know.

Chapter 9 — The Dragon's Story

The rain had stopped an hour ago but the village still dripped, every leaf and gutter and corrugated eave letting go of the day's water one bead at a time, so the dark was full of small percussion. Yusuf sat where he'd been put — on a low bench at the edge of the cleared ground, under a roof of woven pandanus and tin, his back to a wall that smelled of woodsmoke and old kava. Somewhere behind the houses a generator coughed and held. The bulb overhead was the colour of weak tea.

The *sakau* was being pounded. Yusuf had watched it the whole way: the four men on their knees around the flat basalt stone, the rounded stones in their hands rising and falling, *tonk — tonk-tonk — tonk*, a rhythm that wasn't quite a rhythm, that kept shifting under you like a tide. The pepper root mashed to a wet grey pulp. Then the hibiscus bark, twisted into a rope, the pulp folded in and wrung, and the liquid coming off it the colour and consistency of something that should not be drunk and would be. The first cup went to the old man in the good chair. Everything in the right order, and the order was the point.

Mira sat to Yusuf's left, hands loose in her lap, eyes everywhere. She'd told him on the boat over — fingers and a little voice, the way she did when she wanted to be sure — *watch who they serve and when. That's the whole conversation, before anyone talks*. So he watched. Second cup to a man with a Honiara T-shirt and a face like carved wood. Third, fourth. The hierarchy poured itself out in coconut shells and nobody had to say a word.

Edith's camera stayed in the bag. She'd asked, once, with her eye-

brows, and the old man's daughter had given the smallest shake of the head, and the bag had stayed zipped. Edith sat with her hands folded over it like she was keeping it warm.

"They call him Soumas," the daughter said quietly, leaning toward the crew. She was maybe fifty, with reading glasses pushed up into her hair and a phone in her shirt pocket that buzzed twice and was ignored. "It's not his name. It's — the one who holds the talk. Tonight he holds it. You should drink first, then he'll start."

The cup came to Yusuf in its turn, low down the order, which felt correct. He took it in both hands the way he'd been shown. It tasted of mud and aspirin and, underneath, something green and alive. His lips went numb in a slow expanding ring. He passed the shell back, said *kalahngan* the way the daughter had coached him, and the old man — Soumas — looked at him for the first time, and almost smiled.

Numb lips, mud juice, and a flying dragon. Buckle up, kid.

Soumas talked low, in Pohnpeian, and his daughter laid the English over the top of it like a second voice on a second track, half a beat behind, so you heard the shape of the real thing under the translation the whole time.

There were two brothers, he said. Sorcerers. Olisihpa and Olosohpa. They came from somewhere to the west — *down the wind*, the daughter said, and then said it wasn't quite that, that the word held a direction and a long-ago both at once and English only had room for one. The brothers came to Pohnpei looking for a place to build an altar to Nahnsapwe, the lord of the thunder, so the people could honour him properly. They tried in the west. The reef was wrong. They tried again. Wrong again. They went all the way round the island, brothers and their followers, trying the stone in place after place, and each time the sea or the land said no, until they came to the lee of Temwen, to the reef flat where the water ran in channels, and there, finally, the stone would stand.

"And then," the daughter said, and Soumas paused, and the generator filled the gap, and a child somewhere was hushed.

“Then they sang.”

The brothers sang, and the basalt came. The great stones lifted off the land where they lay — out at Sokehs, on the far side, the daughter said, the cliffs where the rock grows in columns like a stack of firewood God left out — they lifted and they *flew*, through the air, across the water, and laid themselves down course on course, long face and short face, the way you lace your fingers, until the walls stood. A flying dragon carried them, some tell it. The brothers’ own power, others tell it. Soumas’s grandmother told it as the dragon, the daughter said, and so Soumas told it as the dragon, because that was his grandmother’s and now it was his.

Yusuf felt the whole thing settle into him, slow as the kava. He wanted it. That was the truth of his own body and he knew it for what it was — the same hunger that had got him fired from two jobs and onto this boat, the want that lit up like a struck match whenever a story was bigger than the room it was told in. *The stones flew*. He could see it. He’d have given a year of his life to see it.

He looked at the wall they could just make out past the houses, across the black water — Nandauwas, the great enclosure, the corner of it catching the village light, basalt logs stacked higher than two men, dry, no mortar, holding up four hundred years of nothing-has-moved. He’d stood under it that afternoon. He’d put his hand flat on a single column and felt the cold come off it and done the sum he’d promised himself he wouldn’t do, because Mira’s book or no, somebody on the crew always ran the numbers and lately it kept being him.

Five tonnes, the small ones. Twenty-five, the big ones. The cornerstone — fifty. Fifty tonnes is a loaded semi-trailer. Off the cliffs at Sokehs, twenty-five miles by sea around a reef, and then *up*, hand over hand, seven and a half metres, onto a wall, with the tide coming in over your ankles and nothing to push against. Three-quarters of a million tonnes of it. Eighteen hundred tonnes a year, every year, for four hundred years, while the same place grew not one yam and held not one mouthful of fresh water, so every drinking-gourd and every basket of taro that ever kept a builder alive came across that same water by canoe.

And nobody, in a hundred years of trying, in wetsuits, with cranes on barges and engineers with clipboards — nobody had managed to put

one column back the way it had been taken down.

Of course you'd say a dragon. What else holds a weight like that? What other word is the right size?

The daughter had stopped translating. Soumas was watching Yusuf again, and this time it wasn't almost a smile.

"You're doing arithmetic," he said. In English. Flat and clear, no accent to hide behind, and the whole bench went still around it.

"I—" Yusuf started.

"It's all right." Soumas turned the empty shell over in his hands. "They all do it. The first ones did it. Men came off ships a hundred and fifty years ago — German, Spanish, before that the whalers — and they stood under the wall and their faces did exactly what your face is doing now. The sum. *It can't have been them.*" He set the shell down. "You know what they decided?"

Nobody answered. The smart move was to let him answer.

"They decided we couldn't have built it." The daughter had picked the translation back up, soft, even though her father was in English now, laying her own voice under his again like she couldn't stop, like the two-track was the proper way. "A lost race. White men, some of them said — a civilisation that drowned, that we were squatting in the ruins of. Atlantis come east. Sons of the sun." He let each one land. "Then later ones, with their own machines and their own arithmetic, they said: people from the stars. The dragon, you understand, became a *ship*. The brothers became — what is the word—"

"Astronauts," the daughter said.

"Astronauts." Soumas tasted it like the kava, found it wanting. "They took my grandmother's dragon and they cut its wings off and they put it in the sky and called it not-ours. Every one of them. The ones who said we were too simple, and the ones who said the truth was too big for us — they ended in the same place. *Somebody else did this. Somebody not these people.*" He spread his hands at the dark, at the village, at the wall across the water. "That is the only story outsiders have ever been able to tell about this place. They cannot

say *we don't know how*. It costs them too much. So they say *it wasn't you*, which costs them nothing, and they go home."

Yusuf had been waiting his whole life to hear a flying dragon described by a man who believed it from his grandmother. He had got that. And he had got, in the same breath, the thing that turned his stomach over — the *aliens* riff, the one that always came dressed as wonder and was wearing, underneath, the oldest insult there was. He knew that theft when he heard it. He'd had it done to him, on a smaller scale, in committee rooms, every time someone took his good idea and put a credible face on it before they'd let it through the door. *Too strange to be yours. Let me hold that for you.*

"They wanted it to be true," he said, before he could stop himself, and then, because honesty was the only thing he had to offer that was worth anything: "I wanted it to be true. Just now. The stones flying. I wanted it so much."

"I know," said Soumas. Not unkindly. "It's a good story. It's mine, and it's good, and you wanted it, and that's right." He leaned forward and the chair creaked under him. "But you wanted the *dragon*. You didn't want the spaceship. You feel the difference?"

Yusuf felt it. It went down his back like cold water.

The dragon was theirs. The dragon came down the wind from the west with two sorcerer brothers who tried the whole island, reef by reef, before the stone would stand — a story about *belonging to the place*, about getting it wrong everywhere else and right *here*, about singing your dead a house. The spaceship was a story about the place being too good for the people in it. One was a gift his grandmother handed him in the dark. The other was a thing strangers had built out of the same materials to carry away.

Mira had turned her head. She was reading Soumas's face the way she read everything, and whatever she found there made her go very still, and then she did a thing Yusuf would think about for a long time afterward. She didn't ask the next question. The crew's whole instinct was sitting right there at the edge of the bench — *so how WAS it done, then, if not the dragon and not the ship, what's the real—* — and Mira looked at it, and set it down, and folded her hands back into her lap.

She signed something to Yusuf, small, just for him. *He's not telling us how.*

No, Yusuf signed back, clumsy.

He's telling us it's not the question.

Numb lips. No camera. And the dragon flies home undecoded. Hecklefish gives this round to the old man.

Soumas watched the two of them pass the silent words and seemed to find it satisfactory, the way the *sakau* order had been satisfactory, things going where they belonged.

"You'll go and stand under the wall again tomorrow," he said. "You'll do the sum again. Everyone does. And the sum won't close — it never closes, that's the truth of it, even our people can't tell you the rope and the raft and the count of hands, it's a long time gone." He stood, slow, a hand on the chair-arm and the other on his daughter's shoulder. "When you can't close the sum, you have a choice. You can say *we don't know how*. That's the hard one — it leaves the wall standing and it leaves it *ours*. Or you can fill the gap with somebody from the sea or the sky, and then the wall is theirs, and there's nothing in it for us but to be the people who live in someone else's ruin."

He looked at Edith, at the bag she was keeping warm.

"Keep it closed tonight," he said. "Tomorrow you can ask my daughter. Some of the wall you can have. Some of it you can't." He started toward the houses, then stopped, and the last of it came over his shoulder, gentle as the rain starting up again on the tin.

"There's a man with money," he said, "been three times to the State office about the lease. He tells them the same thing you came here telling yourselves. *Nobody knows what it's for, nobody knows who.*" A pause. "An empty house, you can sell. He needs us not to know. You understand me?"

And then he was gone into the dark between the buildings, and the generator ran on, and Yusuf sat with the numb mouth and the dragon

in his chest, holding both — the want and the theft, the gift and the lock — and not, for once in his life, trying to choose.

Chapter 10 — A City for the Dead

The tide brought them in at the back of Nandauwas, where the seawall meets the channel, and Edith kept the lens cap on.

She had decided this on the water, watching the black walls rise out of the mangrove like something the island had grown rather than built. Lens cap on until told otherwise. It was a small discipline and it cost her, because the light was doing the thing the light does maybe twice a day in a place like this — coming in low and sideways off the lagoon, raking the basalt so every column stood out from its neighbour in relief, every dry-stacked log throwing a hard little shadow down the face of the wall. A photograph was sitting there fully composed, waiting, and she did not take it.

“You can put the cap back on your face,” said Hecklefish, from the cooler where he was riding out the morning in a half-inch of lagoon water. “Nobody can hear it from there either.”

“I’m being respectful,” Edith said.

“You’re being slow. The wall’s not going anywhere. That’s sort of the whole problem with the wall.”

Mira touched Edith’s wrist — *not yet* — though Edith already knew not yet. Ahead, on the islet, Soumas had stopped at the gap in the outer rampart and turned, and was waiting for them to catch up to a stillness he had been standing in for a while.

The custodian’s name was Soumas and he did not hurry. He had taken them in on his cousin’s skiff and he had not narrated the journey, which Edith had come to understand was itself a kind of speech.

The men who narrate a place are selling it. Soumas let the place do its own talking and watched to see whether you could hear it.

They came up the islet through the outer enclosure into the inner, and the scale arrived the way scale always does — not as a number but as a feeling in the back of the neck. The walls of Nandauwas run five and a half metres, in places seven and a half, of stacked basalt prism laid header-and-stretcher, the long face then the blunt end, the long face then the blunt end, course on course, the way you'd bind the corner of a log cabin so it can't shear. Jakobus had read the grammar of it at the canal's edge days ago and handed the reading on. Standing inside it now, you didn't read it. You stood under it. The hexagonal ends of the columns faced out of the wall in their thousands, a honeycomb of cut-looking stone that nobody cut, and the morning came down them like water down a weir.

"This is the tomb," Yusuf said quietly. Not a question.

"This is the tomb," Soumas agreed.

In the centre of the inner court sat a low rectangle of stone, a vault built down rather than up, roofed once and open now. The royal mortuary. The Saudeleur lords had been laid here, the dynasty that unified the island and ruled it from this reef for four centuries until Isokelekel came over the water and ended them, somewhere around the early seventeenth century. Edith found she was breathing as you breathe in a church when you don't share the faith but you share the floor.

Frik had the survey tablet and was being very careful not to wave it around. "I keep doing the sum," he said, low, to nobody. "I can't stop doing the sum."

"Don't," said Mira, reading his face before his mouth finished.

"Three-quarters of a million tonnes," Frik said anyway, because the number had him by the throat and wouldn't let go. "Over four centuries that's eighteen hundred tonnes a year, every year, four hundred years running, and that's just the *delivery*. That's not the lifting. The cornerstone of this thing is fifty tonnes on its own." He looked up at the seven and a half metres of it. "Fifty tonnes. Onto a wall. By hand. On a reef."

"And then," said Hecklefish, from a respectful distance because even

the fish had clocked the room, “nobody ever lived here. Just so we’re all clear on the genius business plan. You build the hardest building on the planet, on a reef with no water and no soil, and the first thing you do when it’s finished is make sure not one single person can stay the night.”

Edith looked at the vault. The fish, as usual, had blundered into the true thing sideways.

Because that was it, wasn’t it. Nan Madol grows no food. Nan Madol holds no fresh water. You cannot live here. The canals between the islets fill and empty with the tide and there is nothing to drink and nothing to eat and the whole stupendous labour of it — the haul of the columns twenty-five miles down the coast from the Sokehs quarries, the rafting of stone over open water that no modern crew has managed to repeat, the lifting of it into mortarless walls higher than a house — all of that effort went into building a place that could keep no living person alive. They didn’t build a city and forget to feed it. They built it *for the people who don’t eat*.

“It’s not a city,” Edith said. The words came out before she’d approved them. “It’s the opposite of a city.”

Soumas looked at her for the first time as if she’d said something. Not approval. Attention.

“Go on,” he said.

She didn’t want to. This was exactly the trap — the outsider warming to her own cleverness in front of the man who’d grown up inside the answer. She felt Mira’s eyes on her and made herself stop at the edge.

“It’s not my sentence to finish,” Edith said.

Something moved across Soumas’s face that she would not photograph if she’d had the camera up. He let a moment go by with the water sounding under the islet, and then he said, “The living went home. Every day. The chiefs, the priests, the men who lifted the stone — they came on the tide and they went on the tide, back to where the taro grew and the springs ran. They worked here. They worshipped here. They did not *stay*.”

“Because you can’t,” Frik said.

“Because you *don’t*,” Soumas said, and the difference sat in the air between them like a third thing in the room.

Edith took the cap off the lens when he told her she could.

He told her at the outer court, not the inner. He walked her to the threshold of the inner enclosure and stopped there himself, and said the vault was not for the camera, and the wall facing it was not for the camera, but the outer rampart and the canal and the great honey-combed face of stone — those she could photograph, those the dead did not mind being seen. He gave her the line the way Jakobus gave readings, as a relay, a thing passed hand to hand and not seized.

So she shot the outer wall. And it was everything the low light had promised on the water — the columns standing proud of one another, the shadow running down each blunt hexagonal end, four centuries of patient impossible stacking holding its breath in front of her glass. She worked it the way she’d worked the things she was no longer allowed to think about, the way she’d worked rooms that had cost her something to be in, the old steadiness coming up through her hands.

And she found, in the viewfinder, that she kept tilting up. Past the wall. To the gap above it where the wall ended and the sky began.

“What’s wrong,” Mira signed, reading the hesitation in Edith’s shoulders. Mira had been standing very still by the canal for a long time, watching Soumas the way she watched everyone, which was to say not for what he said.

“The shot’s behind the wall,” Edith signed back, badly, half voice. “The thing worth photographing is the thing he won’t let me photograph. And he’s right. That’s the whole —” She stopped. “If I shoot the vault, I’m a thief. If I shoot the wall, I’m a tourist. There isn’t a frame that’s clean.”

Mira watched her finish that. Then she did a thing she rarely did, which was to give an answer.

“Then don’t shoot,” Mira said, out loud, low and exact. “Witness it. That’s allowed. The camera isn’t the only way you’re permitted to have seen something.”

Edith lowered the lens.

Hecklefish, who had been carried up in his cooler to a spot in the shade and was watching the whole exchange with an unusual quiet, said, "Did the photographer just get out-photographed by the deaf woman who can't take a picture?"

"Yes," Edith said.

"I'm just checking. Carry on. I'll be over here, not saying anything, which is famously my whole brand."

Soumas brought them, at the end, to the threshold of the inner court, and let them stand at it. Not in it. At it.

The vault sat there in its low rectangle. The morning had climbed higher and the raking light was gone, and now the inner walls stood in their own shadow, the honeycomb darker, the air cooler by a degree the way the air cools near deep stone or deep water. Yusuf had stopped doing the engineer's arithmetic, which Edith counted as a kind of prayer in him. Frik had put the tablet away entirely. Nobody had told him to. He'd just stopped needing the sum to mean something here.

"You ask how it was lifted," Soumas said. He was looking at the vault, not at them. "Every one of you wants to ask. Your engineer has done the weight in his head three times since the skiff. I watched him do it."

"I have," Frik admitted.

"The men who built this could not tell you either," Soumas said, and there was no defeat in it. "Not because they did not know. Because the knowing was not the kind you write down. It went in their hands and their fathers' hands and it went into the ground with them. Some of it is here." He nodded at the vault. "You are standing at the edge of the people who knew how, and you are asking the people who keep them whether we'll explain it to you so you can put it in a film."

Edith felt the rebuke land and found it wasn't a rebuke. It was just true, stated cold, the way the weight was true.

"We're not —" Yusuf started.

"I know what you are not," Soumas said, not unkindly. "You're not the others. The others came with a chequebook and a story about how nobody here knows what this place is, so it must belong to whoever wants it. They will tell you they are protecting it. They put a hole in the world — *nobody knows* — and they pour money in the hole." He looked at them all, one at a time, and last and longest at Mira, who had not asked him a single question the entire morning. "You're standing in a grave, asking me to make it a riddle. I am telling you it is not a riddle. It is a grave. The men who carried the stone are *in the wall you want to photograph*."

The fish did not heckle. That, more than anything, told Edith how the room had changed.

"What's it for," Mira said.

It was the only question anyone had put to him directly, and she put it not in the place of *tell me the secret* but in the place of *I see there is a thing you are holding, and I will not take it, but I will let you give it weight in front of me if you choose*. Edith heard the difference and understood that Soumas heard it too, because he turned and looked at the small deaf woman who read bodies for a living, and the two of them stood inside a quiet that the rest of them were only guests in.

"It is for the dead to be kept *by* someone," Soumas said. "That is what it is for. Not so they are remembered. So they are *kept*. You leave a place like this empty of the living so it can be full of the other thing. And you do not leave it empty of *keepers*. The wall is not the city. The city is us. Standing here. Saying no to the people with the chequebook."

He let that go out across the water.

"That is why we do not tell," he said. "Not because we don't know. Because a grave that explains itself to strangers is one step from a grave that belongs to them."

Edith stood at the threshold with a thousand pounds of camera against her chest and did not raise it.

The dead were in the wall. The tide was coming back, and soon it would lift them off this islet and carry them home the way it had carried home everyone who ever worked here, four hundred years of living men going back to the springs and the taro at the end of the

day, leaving the stone to its proper population. The light had moved. The shot was gone. She was glad the shot was gone.

“Tide’s turning,” Soumas said. “We go on the tide. Same as them.”

And they went on the tide, and behind them the seven-metre walls held what they held, and not one of the crew asked him to say the thing he had just spent a morning, with great gentleness, declining to say.

Chapter 11 — The Experimenters

The column was three and a half tonnes of basalt, and it had spent the whole morning refusing to behave.

Frik had it framed before anyone arrived. He liked to do that — set the tripod while the light was still grey and the reef flat was an inch deep in retreating tide, and let the place fill itself up. So the first shot of the day was the thing alone: a single hexagonal log of stone, dark and matte and longer than a man, lying on a sledge of fresh-cut mangrove the team had lashed together the night before. Behind it, two hundred metres off across the channel, the wall of Nandauwas stood the way it had stood for eight hundred years, doing the thing they were here to fail to do.

That was the joke, and nobody had to say it. The answer was already standing behind the question.

“Recording,” Frik said, to no one. The word was a habit. He pressed the back of his hand to the camera body the way some men touch a doorframe leaving the house.

The experimenters came down to the flat at half six, in rash vests and reef shoes, carrying coffee in dented thermoses. They were not television people. That was the first thing Frik had clocked and the thing he kept clocking, frame after frame: nobody here was performing. There was an engineer named Dawson with a clipboard laminated against the salt, and two grad students whose names Frik kept losing, and the woman running it, Dr. Hale, a marine archaeologist out of Auckland by way of a dozen reefs, who had the specific calm of a person who had measured the world and found it heavier than the

brochure.

She had been clear with them, twice, the day before. *We're not solving it. We're constraining it. There's a difference and it's the whole job.*

Frik had liked her immediately.

The official story, laid out flat, was not in dispute, and Hale told it again now to the camera the way you'd recite a hymn you actually believed — no flourish, every word load-bearing.

A medieval dynasty. The Saudeleur, who unified Pohnpei and ruled it from this reef. Radiocarbon put the monumental phase from around AD 1180 — *medieval*, she said, and let the word sit, because half the world wanted this place older than time and it simply wasn't. Ninety-odd artificial islets. Tidal canals laced between them — the spaces between, the name itself. A ceremonial city for the dead, and the great mortuary enclosure right there, Nandauwas, walls between five and a half and seven and a half metres, dry-stacked, no mortar, header-and-stretcher, basalt logs alternating long-face and end like a child's log cabin built by giants who had all gone home.

"And the stone is the part everyone gets backwards," she said. She crouched and laid a hand flat on the column on the sledge, the way you'd settle a horse. "Nature did the hard bit. This is columnar jointing — lava cools, it contracts, it cracks into these prisms. Same physics as the Giant's Causeway. Nobody carved this hexagon. The island handed it over pre-cut."

"So that's the easy part," one of the grad students said, grinning, because he knew what came next.

"That's the *only* easy part," said Hale.

Frik panned, slow, off her hand and across the channel to the wall, and held it there long enough that anyone watching would do the arithmetic without being asked.

Three-quarters of a million tonnes of this. Quarried twenty-five miles up the coast, the Sokehs side. Rafted — *somehow* — across open lagoon water. A single cornerstone in that far enclosure that ran to fifty tonnes. And then the part nobody could draw a picture of: lifted.

Course on course. Onto a wall taller than the boat they'd come out in, on a reef, by hand, with no crane and no ramp surviving and nothing — *nothing* — left behind to say how.

Hale stood and brushed her palms.

"So," she said. "We're going to try to move one. Just one. Three and a half tonnes — a small one, an honest small one — about forty metres, onto a metre-high test course. And I want you filming when it goes wrong, because that's the data."

It went wrong with great dignity, which was somehow worse.

The plan was sound. The plan was, in fact, the consensus plan — the one in the literature, the one any sensible person reaches for. Rollers and a sledge for the flat haul. Then a timber A-frame, lever-and-lash, a shear-legs rig to walk the column up onto the course in stages, packing under it as you went. Coir rope, the real stuff, hand-laid, because that's what they'd have had. Eighteen people on the lines, which was already, Frik noted, more bodies than the brochure version ever pictured.

The haul across the flat went well enough that for twenty minutes Frik let himself believe. The rollers bit, the coir held, the column crept over the wet stone with a sound like a slow door, and the grad students chanted something to keep the pull together, and Hale walked beside it with one hand resting on the stone, reading it.

Then they reached the test course and tried to lift.

The A-frame was good. The lashings were good. The lever advantage was textbook. And the basalt — the dense, dark, naturally-prismatic basalt that the island had so kindly pre-cut — simply *was what it was*, which was three and a half tonnes of it, and the rope took the load and the rope sang, a high tight note Frik felt in his back teeth, and the column came up off the rollers maybe a hand's width and hung there, trembling, while eighteen people leaned into the lines and the A-frame legs dug little graves for themselves in the coral fill.

"Pack it," Hale said, very level. "Pack it, pack it—"

They got a baulk of timber under one end. They got the second end up. They got the column resting, finally, on a single course of packing,

half a metre off the flat, and it had taken — Friik checked his own timecode later, and then checked it again because he didn't believe it — the better part of three hours.

Half a metre. One column. The small one.

Eighteen people, the best rope, the right rig, modern winches held in reserve and *not even used* yet, and an Auckland archaeologist who had done this on four other reefs, and they had moved one small stone up half a metre in an afternoon.

Friik thought about the wall across the channel. He didn't do the multiplication out loud. He didn't have to. The camera did it for him, sitting there with the half-metre lift in the bottom of the frame and the seven-metre wall standing flawless in the top of it, and the gap between them was the whole story and it was very quiet.

That's a potato, said the fish, from the cooler where someone had put him to keep cool, which was Heck-lefish's preferred vantage for the collapse of human endeavour. *That's a beautiful, expensive, peer-reviewed potato. They've got rope from the right tree and everything. Tell them about the cornerstone. Go on. Tell them it's fifty of those.*

Friik did not tell them. They knew.

He filmed the faces during the break, because the faces were the truth and the mouths were just doing logistics.

This was the thing he and Mira never had to discuss — they'd worked it out separately and arrived at the same place, the way you do. The mouth tells you the plan. The face tells you what the body already knows. Dawson, the engineer, sat on an upturned crate working numbers on his laminated sheet, and his mouth said *we shave the timber, drop the friction, we'd halve that lift time, easy*. But his pencil had stopped moving. He was looking at the wall. He was an engineer, and engineers do not enjoy looking at a thing they cannot reverse-build, and his face had the particular set of a man whose competence had just been handed a number it didn't like.

Hale sat apart, drinking water, watching her own students dismantle

the A-frame. She was not frustrated. That was what got Frik. He'd expected frustration and found something quieter and harder to name — a kind of *respect*, aimed across the channel at people eight hundred years dead.

She caught him filming her and didn't flinch, which by now meant something. They had earned that, slowly, over three days.

"You want the line," she said. "The clean one. For your show."

"I'll take whatever you've got."

She thought about it.

"Here's the clean one. We didn't fail." She nodded at the column, propped on its half-metre of packing. "That's a successful experiment. We *constrained* it. We now know — to a decent confidence — that you *could* do this with rope and timber and people and patience. The physics permits it. There's no levitation required. Write that down, it's important: nothing here is impossible. Everyone wants me to say impossible. I won't."

"But."

The corner of her mouth went. "But it's never been reproduced. Not the haul-and-lift, quarry to wall, at scale. People have tried. The literature's honest about it — *not yet reproduced*. Which is not the same as *can't be done*. It's the gap between knowing a thing is *possible* and knowing how it was *actually done* — and at the volume it was done, and the *rate*."

"The rate," Frik said.

"Do the rate." She said it the way you'd dare someone. "Eighteen hundred tonnes a year. Sustained. For four centuries. We just spent an afternoon on three and a half." She let that breathe. "I'm not reaching past it. I want to be very clear, on your camera, that I am not reaching for anything. There's no mystery *mechanism* I'm hiding. The mechanism is rope and people. The mystery is the *organisation*. What island holds a workforce on a reef that grows no food and holds no water, season after season, generation after generation, and feeds them, and waters them, by canoe, the whole time, and *wants to* — for the dead. Not for the living. There's nobody living out here." She gestured at the dry, foodless, waterless stone all around them, the

most expensive uninhabitable real estate in the Pacific. “Who does that. And keeps doing it. That’s my hole. That’s the one I can’t close. And it’s an *honest* hole — go ask anyone in the field, they’ll give it to you straight.”

Frik kept rolling. It was the best three minutes anyone had given him in months, and she’d handed it over plainly, the way you’d hand over a tool.

She’s good, the fish admitted, grudging, from the cooler. She found the hole and she’s not selling you a dragon through it. Where’s the fun in that. Somebody bring me a man with a theory and a pamphlet.

It was Hale who found the door, in the end, and Frik who filmed her not opening it — though he didn’t understand that part until later, watching it back, with Mira beside him going very still.

The light was going amber. The team was loading the skiff. And a man had come down across the flat from the Madolenihmw side — older, unhurried, in a faded church shirt, who Frik recognised as one of the men who’d been with the custodian on the first day and whose name he had not been given and had not asked for. He stood at the edge of the test course and looked at the half-metre lift, and at the eighteen-person rig folded up beside it, and at the wall.

Hale went to him. Not as a scientist. She set her clipboard down first, deliberately, on the crate, which Frik’s lens caught — the laminated sheet of numbers, the whole afternoon’s data, *set down* before she crossed to him empty-handed.

They spoke too low for the mic. Frik didn’t push in. He held the wide shot — the two of them at the channel’s edge, the failed lift between them, the wall behind.

The man said something and gestured, once, up the coast toward Sokehs, toward where the quarry was, twenty-five miles of open water away. A small movement. Almost nothing.

And Hale — who had spent the whole day cheerfully telling Frik’s camera every single thing she knew — went quiet. She nodded. She did not ask the follow-up. Frik watched her not ask it, watched the ques-

tion form in the set of her shoulders and then watched her *put it down*, the same gesture as the clipboard, and just stand there in the gold light receiving whatever the old man had decided to give her and *not reaching for the rest*.

The man patted the top of the propped column, the way Hale had patted it that morning — settling a horse — and walked back up the flat.

Hale came back and picked up her clipboard and did not write anything on it.

“What’d he say,” Frik asked. Gently. He already half knew it was the wrong question.

She looked at him, and there was that respect again, but turned now, aimed somewhere he couldn’t follow.

“He said we were lifting it wrong.” A pause. “And then he said something else, and it wasn’t for the camera, and it wasn’t for me to repeat. So I’m not going to.” She almost smiled. “Funny. I came out here to find out if it was *possible*. I’ve got that. Possible, not reproduced, honest hole, you can air all of it.” She zipped her dry bag. “And that man just told me, very kindly, that *possible* was never the interesting question, and I’ve spent eleven years on it.”

She slung the bag and stepped down into the skiff.

“Get a shot of the wall before you lose the light,” she said. “That’s the only thing out here that knows the answer, and it’s not telling either.”

Frik turned the camera. Behind him the half-metre lift sat in its little failure on the reef. In front of him Nandauwas went from grey to gold, seven metres of dry-stacked stone that the best minds and the best rope had just spent a whole day getting nowhere near, standing exactly as it had stood, holding its dead and its method and whatever the old man hadn’t said, all of it, between the stones.

Roll the tape, said the fish, quietly, for once not heckling at all.

Frik rolled it. The wall didn’t say anything. It never had.

Chapter 12 — The Spaces Between

The tide came in the way the custodian said it would, and not a minute before.

Mira felt it before she saw it — the canal under the skiff stopped being a thing they sat on top of and became a thing they were carried by. The hull lifted a hand's width. The pole the custodian held stopped pushing against mud and started pushing against water, and the difference travelled up through the wood and through the bench and into the base of her spine, where she kept most of what she knew about the world.

He had not turned on a light. He poled them in by the last of it, the sky gone the colour of a bruise behind the ridge, and the walls came up out of the dark on either side the way a cliff comes up out of fog — all at once, having been there the whole time.

Yusuf had his hand on the gunwale. Edith had her camera in her lap, capped, both hands flat on top of the cap, which was its own kind of statement and Mira had clocked it an hour ago. Frik sat at the bow with his knees up by his ears, too big for the boat, watching the water with the particular stillness he got when a thing was too large to make a joke about yet.

The custodian poled. He had not said three words since the launch ramp.

The official story is simple, and you should hold it in your head the way you'd hold a stone you mean to throw, because it is true and it is

heavy and it will not save you.

Around the year 1180 — radiocarbon, medieval, the same century that was raising cathedrals a world away — a dynasty called the Saudeleur began stacking basalt on a reef flat off the southeast coast of Pohnpei. They built about ninety-two artificial islets. They laced them with tidal canals so the sea ran *through* the city instead of merely around it, and they called the place, in the end, the spaces between. Not the stones. The gaps. The water.

They did this for roughly four centuries, until a man named Isokelekel overthrew the last of the line, somewhere around the early seventeenth century, and the great work stopped.

That is the whole of it. A real dynasty. A known span. A purpose — a city for ceremony and for the dead, a place where rule and ritual sat together on the water. It is not a riddle. The archaeology is good and the people who do it are good at it and they will tell you, plainly and with love, what Nan Madol is.

“Medieval. Got it. So they were basically up to date.” A pause. “On a reef. With no forklift. Carry on, professor.”

The professor — Marisol, who was at that moment in a guesthouse in Kolonia eating instant noodles and arguing with a spreadsheet — would have told the fish to carry on indeed, because the spreadsheet is the part nobody likes.

Seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes of basalt. Run it flat: across four centuries, that’s about eighteen hundred and fifty tonnes a year, every year, for four hundred years, hauled across roughly twenty-five miles of open water from a quarry on the far side of the island and stacked dry — no mortar, end-to-end and side-to-side like a man building a log cabin — into walls that in places stand more than seven metres high. One cornerstone runs to fifty tonnes.

Lift fifty tonnes. Onto a wall. On a reef. By hand. With nothing on the seabed afterward to tell you how, except some columns that fell off whatever was carrying them and lie there still — lost cargo, dropped in transit, evidence of the haul and nothing stranger than that.

People have tried to do it again. Properly, with permission and engineers and the best guesses anyone has. They have not managed it. *Not yet reproduced* is the phrase, and it is an honest phrase, and it

does not mean what the man selling the boat tour wants it to mean. It means: we know it was done, and we cannot show you how.

That is the potato. The brightest people, in daylight, with the plan, fall short — and the thing they were trying to copy sits behind them in the dark, finished, mortarless, seven metres of it, not caring.

They turned into a narrower channel and the walls came in close enough to touch.

Mira put her hand out. Frik shot her a look — *don't* — and she didn't, she let it hover a finger's width off the basalt, feeling the cold come off it the way cold comes off a fridge door. The columns were stacked just the way Jakobus had read them three days ago at the canal's edge, before he'd handed the rest of it to the custodian and stepped back: a long face, then an end, then a long face, the joint of one course landing over the middle of the one below, so the whole wall locked itself together with nothing but its own weight and the patience of whoever set it.

She could see the building grammar. Anyone could, once it was pointed out. That was the cruel part — the *how it stands* was legible, plain, almost friendly. It was the *how it got up there* that opened under your feet.

The water carried them between two walls a canoe-length apart, and the title of the thing arrived in her body before it arrived in her head. The spaces between. They weren't moving past the city. They were moving *through* its absences — through the deliberate gaps the builders had left, the channels they'd kept open so the tide could come and go and the dead could be reached and the living could leave. The stone was load-bearing. So was the water. You could not have one without the other. Take the canals away and you didn't have a denser city; you had no city at all, just a quarry that had landed in the wrong ocean.

She watched the custodian pole. His face did almost nothing, and the almost-nothing was the whole conversation.

A lifetime of hearing rooms had given Mira this — the thing the world had handed her in place of the words it kept for itself. She read bodies because no one had ever let her stop. And what she read off

the man in the stern was not the flat surface of *I have nothing to tell you*. It was the held tension of a man standing in a room he loves while strangers walk through it. The set of the shoulders that says *I am responsible for what happens here*. The way his eyes went, once, to a particular dark doorway in the wall to their left and then came deliberately back to the water, the way you make yourself not look at the thing you are protecting.

There was someone here. Not a ghost — she would not have given Frik the satisfaction. A *presence*. The reef was supposed to be uninhabitable, and was: no fresh water, no soil that grows food, a stone metropolis that could not keep a single soul alive without canoes bringing everything across the lagoon every single day for four hundred years. Nobody lived here. That was half the unanswerable — *why* drag three-quarters of a million tonnes to a place that could feed no one and water no one, and the honest answer the experts give is that they have not closed it.

And yet the place was not empty. Empty was a thing she knew. She had spent her whole life on the empty side of conversations. This was the opposite of that. This was a room full of people who had agreed to be quiet.

"It's very atmospheric," the fish allowed, from somewhere near Edith's lap. "I'd like the record to show I am not saying anything about anything. I'm a fish. I have no horse in the ghost race."

Nobody laughed, which was how Mira knew the others felt it too.

Edith had the camera capped the whole way in, and Mira had been watching that cap like a tell.

In the half-second when the moon cleared the ridge and laid a long silver bar straight down the canal — straight down the *space between* — every instinct the woman had was to lift the thing and take it. Mira saw the hands tighten on the cap. Saw the breath go in. Saw the exact moment the war photographer in Edith woke up and reached, by thirty years of muscle, for the shot that would have explained the whole book in one frame, the moonlit canal and the seven-metre wall and the small dark figure poling them through.

And saw her not take it.

The breath went out. The hands stayed flat. Edith looked at the back of the custodian's head, and then she looked down at her own hands on the cap, and she left them there. Mira didn't know what it cost her. It wasn't the kind of thing you could read off a body — only that something had been paid.

The custodian, who had his back to both of them, said, without turning, "You can take it."

Edith's hands didn't move.

"It's all right," he said. "Many people photograph here. With permission." His voice was even, unhurried, a teacher's patience. "I am telling you it is permitted."

Edith looked at the moon-bar on the water. At the wall. At the doorway he had not let himself look at.

"I'll keep it," she said. Meaning the cap on. Meaning *no*.

He nodded once, still facing forward, and Mira felt the thing settle between them — a small thing, a courtesy returned that had not been asked for. The two of them had just had an entire exchange about consent in eleven words, and the only word that mattered was the one Edith hadn't taken when it was offered.

They came out into a wider basin, and the great wall of Nandauwas stood off to the right, the mortuary enclosure, the place where the rulers were laid. Five, six, seven metres of stacked basalt, the cornerstone in the dark somewhere at its foot weighing as much as a school bus, and not a grain of mortar anywhere in it.

Yusuf was the one who finally spoke, low, because Yusuf could not help reading the money of a thing even when the thing was four hundred years dead. "Somebody fed this," he said. "Every day. For centuries. The whole island, organised, just to keep stone moving to a place that grew nothing." He shook his head. "You don't build this for a king. You build this as a king. The building is the proof he can make the whole sea come when he calls."

The custodian's pole paused, mid-stroke. The smallest hitch. Mira caught it and said nothing.

He had not contradicted Yusuf. He had not agreed either. He had simply, for half a beat, stopped — the way you stop when a stranger gets *close*, close enough that the next thing you say either opens a door or shuts it, and you choose, and the choosing is yours.

He started poling again.

Mira had spent four days waiting for someone to say *we don't know* and mean it, and she had heard it from him on the first day, at the canal's edge, in exactly that flat true voice — *we don't know how they raised it* — and she had known then, before any of the others, that the flatness was not the flatness of ignorance. It was the flatness of a door held shut from the inside, by a hand, on purpose. She had said so to the crew, gently, that night. She had not said pick it.

Now, on the water, in the dark, surrounded by the spaces the builders had been careful to leave, she understood the second half of it, the half she could not have read from the shore.

The silence here was not a gap in the record. It was not a vacancy waiting for someone to come and fill it — not for the man with the spreadsheet, and certainly not for the other man, the one with the deniable funding and the development plans and the patient lawyers, who needed the island's *we don't know* to stay a *we-don't-know* forever because you cannot develop a grave that has keepers but you can develop an empty riddle.

The silence was full. It was kept. It was somebody's, by right — by the order of who may enter and who may speak and what may be told, an order older than the crew and older than the camera and older, God knew, than the resort.

She looked at the dark doorway the custodian had refused to look at, and she did not need to know what was behind it. That was the new thing, the thing she'd come four days and half an ocean to find out she could do. She did not need to know. She only needed to see that it was held, and by whom, and to leave it held.

The fish, very quietly, for once, did not say a word.

The custodian poled them on through the spaces between, the water

as load-bearing as the stone, carrying them past everything he had decided not to give. The moon laid its bar down the canal. Nobody lifted a camera.

"It is late," he said. "The tide turns soon. We should go back while the water still wants us."

He turned the skiff. And the dark closed over the doorway behind them, exactly as full as it had been before they came.

Chapter 13 — The Vacancy

The room had been a classroom once. You could still see where the world map had been taped to the wall — four pale rectangles in the paint where the corners had peeled, a continent-shaped ghost. Now it held a folding table, eight stacking chairs, a whiteboard wiped to a grey smear, and an air-conditioner that laboured against the wet like a man pushing a boat off a sandbar. Kolonia in the late morning: corrugated roofs ticking under the sun, a rooster somewhere being very sure of itself, the smell of diesel and frangipani coming in under the door with the heat.

Yusuf got there early because he always got there early. You learned the room before the room learned you.

The man from Meridian Pacific Heritage Group was already setting up. Tall, soft-spoken, a linen shirt that had been ironed by someone who took ironing seriously. He had a laptop and a portable projector and a bottle of water for every chair, condensation already beading, and he stood when Yusuf came in and offered a hand and a name — *Call me Devin* — with the open, unhurried warmth of a man who has never once in his life been asked to leave a room.

“You’re early,” Devin said, pleased. “I respect that.”

“Habit,” Yusuf said, and sat where he could see the door and the screen at once.

The others filtered in. Frik, who looked at the projector cable the way some men look at a snake. Edith, who took the chair in the corner, the camera bag in her lap zipped shut — she’d asked first, in the skiff, and Yusuf had said *not yet*, and she had nodded and zipped the bag and not touched it since. Mira last, choosing the seat at the end of

the table with the angle on every face, the way she always did, not because she was suspicious but because the angle was the only fair share of the conversation she was ever handed.

Two men from Pohnpei State came too, polite, careful, a folder each. And a woman from the Madolenihmw side whose name Yusuf caught and held — Lihna — who sat very straight and did not take a water bottle.

“So,” Devin said, when the air-conditioner had been turned up and turned down and left where it was. “Thank you all. I know everyone’s busy, I’ll be brief, I promise.” He clicked. The screen filled with the reef at golden hour, the basalt walls of Nandauwas rising out of the canals like something the sea had decided to keep, the water between the islets gone to copper. It was a beautiful photograph. It was somebody else’s photograph; Yusuf could see the watermark ghosted in the corner where they’d cropped it badly.

Stock photo. Even the slideshow’s a tourist.

“Nan Madol,” Devin said, and let it sit there, the word and the picture. “The Venice of the Pacific. Ninety-two islets. A medieval city — and I want to be careful here, because the science is genuinely extraordinary — built around eleven-eighty, radiocarbon, the Saudeleur capital, overthrown in the seventeenth century. All true. All on the record.” He clicked again: the cornerstone of Nandauwas, the fifty-tonne block, shot from below so it loomed. “Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt. A single cornerstone that weighs as much as a fully loaded semi-truck, raised onto a wall over twenty-three feet high. By hand. On a reef.”

He paused, and looked around the table, and lowered his voice the precise amount.

“And here’s the thing the experts will tell you, and I love them for their honesty: *they don’t know how*. They’ve tried. Experimental archaeology — they’ve gone out and tried to move one column the way it would’ve been done. It doesn’t work. Nobody has reproduced it.” He spread his hands, palms up, an offering. “A hundred years of trying, and the most honest scholars on earth look at that reef and say — *we don’t know*.”

It was, Yusuf thought, exactly right. Every word of it was exactly, in-

furiatingly right. The arithmetic was real. The failed lift was real. He had stood on the reef himself three days ago and watched a hired rig and a clever plan produce a potato — a single column slung wrong, swinging, the whole engineered dignity of the modern attempt reduced to four people and a winch shouting at a stone that would not go where the spreadsheet said it should, while behind them the wall that nobody could explain stood there being seven and a half metres tall and four hundred years patient and entirely silent about how.

So when Devin said *we don't know*, he was telling the truth.

It was what he did with it next that made the back of Yusuf's neck go cold.

"Which is the opportunity," Devin said, and clicked.

A rendering now. The reef, but cleaned — the mangrove pushed back, a boardwalk threading the canals on tasteful pilings, an interpretive centre with a roof shaped, vaguely, like a wave or a sail or a thing a designer in an air-conditioned office in a city eight thousand kilometres away had decided said *Pacific*. Little figures walking the boardwalks. A glass-bottomed something in the lagoon.

"A world-heritage-grade visitor experience," Devin said. "Done right. Done with reverence. Meridian doesn't build resorts on sacred ground — I want to be very clear about that, it's the first thing in our charter. We build *access*. We build *interpretation*." Click. A revenue projection, the bars climbing year on year, green. "And the beauty of it — the genuine, marketable beauty — is the mystery itself. We don't have to claim anything. We don't have to say who or how. We sell the question. *The greatest unsolved engineering mystery in the Pacific*. People will fly across the world to stand in front of a question nobody can answer."

He's not wrong, is what kills me.

"The story," Devin said, warming now, "is that there is no story. Or — no settled one. And that's perfect. A settled site is a museum. An *unsettled* one is a destination. The not-knowing is the asset."

He said it gently. He said it like a gift.

Yusuf watched the two men from Pohnpei State look at their folders. He watched the bars climb on the screen. He'd sat in rooms like this

his whole working life, on three continents, the man at the side wall who counted the exits and read the contract that the principals hadn't read, and he knew the shape of this one the way you know weather. The money was clean. That was the thing nobody back home would ever believe. There was no cabal, no smoke-filled anything; Devin probably did love the archaeologists, probably did believe the charter, probably would write *reverence* in the brochure and mean it. The damage didn't need a villain. It needed a vacancy.

"Question," Yusuf said.

"Please." Devin turned to him with real attention.

"The not-knowing." Yusuf kept his voice flat, accountant's voice, the voice he used when he wanted a number to do the work. "Whose is it?"

Devin blinked. "Sorry?"

"The mystery. You said it's the asset. The fact that nobody knows how it was built, why it was built where nothing grows." Yusuf turned the water bottle a quarter-turn on the table, not drinking it. "Who doesn't know? When you put it on the brochure — *nobody knows* — who's the nobody?"

"The — well, science," Devin said, recovering, smooth. "The consensus is genuinely open. I'm not overstating it. The lift, the provisioning, the —"

"The lift's open," Yusuf agreed. "The dynasty's not. The date's not — eleven-eighty, you said it yourself. The *who* is on the record. It's the Saudeleur capital and there are people in this room whose families remember the fall of it." He didn't look at Lihna. He'd learned not to look at the person you were defending; it made it about you. "So when you say *nobody knows* — you've already cut out everybody who does."

The air-conditioner laboured. The rooster had given up.

"I'm not cutting anyone out," Devin said, and the warmth had gone careful. "We'd partner. Fully. Local boards, local guides, revenue share, the works. The interpretation would be theirs to —"

"What's it for?"

That was Frik, from down the table, gruff, not looking up from the projector cable he'd been worrying. Everyone looked at him.

"Sorry?" Devin said again.

"The walls. Nandauwas. What's it *for*." Frik finally looked up. "You've got a rendering of a boardwalk through it. So somebody told you what it's for, well enough that your designer knew where to put the railing. Who told you?"

Devin's smile held but it had stopped reaching all the way. "It's a mortuary complex. Royal tombs. That's — that's standard, that's in every —"

"It's in every guidebook," Yusuf said. "Which is not the same as in the room. You've got a fifty-tonne stone you can't explain on a wall you can't reproduce on a reef that can't feed you, and your pitch is that the can't-explain is the *product*. You want to buy the question and resell it as a souvenir. But a question that belongs to somebody isn't for sale. You can only sell an empty one."

He hadn't meant to say that much. He felt it land long, felt the room go still around it in a way that wasn't his to have caused.

Down the table, Mira had gone very still in a different way. Yusuf knew the look — the look she got when the words in a room and the bodies in a room had stopped agreeing with each other and only she could see the seam. She wasn't watching Devin. She was watching Lihna, who had not said a single word, whose face had not moved, whose hands were folded on the table over no folder at all.

And then Mira looked at Yusuf, just a flick, and gave him the smallest shake of the head. *Not the content. Don't.* He understood it the way you understand a hand on your arm. He'd been about to ask Lihna directly — *isn't that right, doesn't your family* — to win the point, to make the silent woman a witness for the prosecution. Mira's chin moved a quarter-inch and he stopped, because the difference between the two of them had always been that she could see when defending someone and using them were the same gesture wearing different clothes.

He sat back.

Devin recovered, because men like Devin always recover; it is the one

true thing about them. “Look,” he said, easy again, opening his hands. “Nobody’s selling anybody’s question. I think we’ve gotten — I think the framing got away from us a little. Let me put it plainly. There’s a site. It’s degrading — the mangrove, the storms, the State doesn’t have the budget, that’s not a criticism, it’s just true. Somebody is going to develop access to that site within ten years. I’d rather it be us, who’ll do it carefully, than the next outfit, who won’t. And the honest, beautiful fact at the centre of the whole thing is that nobody can tell you how it was built. That’s not me erasing anyone. That’s the brochure for the place writing itself.”

He looked around, reasonable, warm, right.

“You’re describing a grave,” Mira said.

It was the first thing she’d said. She said it the way she said most things, level and dry and from the angle she’d chosen at the end of the table, and the room turned to her the way rooms did when the quiet one finally spent a word.

“A grave’s got people who tend it,” she said. “That’s what makes it a grave and not a field with stones in it. You keep saying nobody knows. There’s a woman at this table who hasn’t told you what she knows, and you’ve built a whole boardwalk on the assumption that her quiet is the same as your spreadsheet’s quiet.” She didn’t look at Lihna either. She’d learned it from the same place Yusuf had, or maybe she’d taught it to him. “It isn’t. One of them’s protecting something. One of them’s selling that there’s nothing to protect.”

Oof.

Devin opened his mouth and then, to his credit — and it was credit, Yusuf would give him that — closed it.

Lihna unfolded her hands. She did not stand. She picked up the water bottle she had refused at the start, turned it once, the way Yusuf had turned his, and set it back down without opening it.

“You can leave the slides,” she said, to Devin, kindly enough. “The Nahnmwarki will want to see them.” She let that sit. “We will tell you what can be told.”

It was not a yes. It was not a no. It was a door, and on which side of it the answer lived was hers and not theirs and not, above all, the

brochure's to decide. Devin heard *we will tell you what can be told* and his face did the small bright thing of a man who has heard *yes, in principle*; and Yusuf watched Mira watch him hear it wrong, and watched her decide, deliberately, with the whole quiet weight of her, not to correct him.

Because the correction was Lihna's to make or withhold. And she was withholding it. On purpose. The way you'd withhold the location of a grave from a man who'd just told you, sincerely, that its greatest value was that it might be empty.

Devin packed his projector. He shook every hand. He left the water bottles sweating on the table.

When he'd gone, the room exhaled. Frik coiled the cable. Edith's bag stayed zipped. The map's ghost glowed on the wall, four pale corners around a missing world.

"He's not buying the city," Yusuf said, to no one, working it out aloud the way he did. "The city's not for sale, the State knows that, the Nahnmwarki knows that. He's buying the *we-don't-know*. That's the parcel. That's the only empty lot on the reef."

Lihna was at the door already, the folder she'd never opened under her arm. She paused.

"We have always had visitors who needed it to be a mystery," she said. "It is easier to take a place that nobody owns." Then, with something that wasn't quite a smile: "We let them think that. It is one of the things the silence is for."

She went out into the heat. The rooster started up again.

Mira was looking at the four pale rectangles on the wall, the place where a world had been and wasn't. After a while she signed something low against the table edge, more to herself than to them, and Yusuf — who was getting better, who was still bad — caught only the shape of it and not the meaning, and let it be hers.

Chapter 14 — The Protocol

The tide came in the way it always did here, without announcement, the reef flat going from puddled gravel to a sheet of moving silver while you weren't watching it. Edith watched it. She always watched the thing that would change the light.

The skiff sat nosed into the channel mouth with its engine tilted up, and nobody had stepped out yet. That was the first thing she noticed — that the boatman, a broad quiet man named Eperiam who'd taken them out three times now and let Mira read his lips without ever once making a show of slowing down for her, had killed the motor early and let them drift the last twenty metres on momentum. He didn't tie off. He held the gunwale against the basalt with one bare foot and waited.

Across the channel, on the low stone apron of the first islet, a man stood with his hands folded in front of him and did not wave them in.

"That's the threshold," Yusuf said, low, the way you'd say *that's the border* in a place where borders had teeth. "We don't cross that."

"We've crossed worse," Frik said, but he said it to his coffee, which had gone cold an hour ago and which he kept holding anyway.

The man on the apron was perhaps sixty, in a faded collared shirt and the kind of trousers that had been to church a thousand Sundays, and he was looking at them with an expression Edith had spent her whole career trying to photograph and never could: patient, unhurried, entirely uninterested in whether you understood him. She had her camera in her lap. Her thumb was already on the power switch. She made herself take it off.

Here is the official thing, and it is true, and it is not a metaphor.

You do not buy a ticket to Nan Madol. There is no turnstile, no laminated map, no gift shop with a fridge magnet of the cornerstone. There is a tide, and there is a right. The right is held under the *Nahnmwarki* order — the title system that has governed this coast since long before the Saudeleur fell, a graded line of chiefs and the deference owed up and down it, a grammar of who may enter, who may speak, what may be carried across which water, and what may be told to whom. Madolenihmw is one of the paramount chiefdoms of the island, and this reef is its ground, and the dead in these walls are its dead. The walls of Nandauwas are five and a half to seven and a half metres of dry-stacked basalt, columns of five to twenty-five tonnes laid header-and-stretcher like a log cabin built by a giant who never used mortar and never dropped a course, and they are a royal mortuary, and the keeping of a grave is not a thing that lapses because the dynasty that filled it is eight hundred years gone.

Edith knew all of this. She had it in her notes, in Yusuf's flat handwriting, with the citations. She knew it the way you know the depth of a river from a chart. And she sat in the skiff with the silver coming up around the stone and understood, in the body and not the chart, that she had spent forty years walking into places like this without being let in — that the *being let in* had been, every single time, a thing she'd assumed.

She would have shot it. The Edith of fifteen years ago. She'd have been over the gunwale and across the apron with the wide lens already up, getting the man's folded hands and his church trousers and his patience, getting it *before* he could compose himself, because the unguarded face was the real face, everyone said so, that was the whole religion of the work. Get it before they know. Get the truth they didn't agree to give you.

She'd brought a lot of truth home that way. She'd brought home a child in Aleppo who had not agreed to be the most-shared photograph of a bad month, and she'd watched the world weep over him and learned his name from no one, because she hadn't asked it, because asking would have cost her the light.

Her hands, in her lap, were doing the small steady tremor they did when the work and the wound got close to each other.

Mira had turned in the bow to face the apron, which meant she'd given up the conversation in the boat entirely, which was its own piece of information. She read the man across the channel the way the rest of them read a page.

Then she signed, small, against her thigh where only the crew could see it: *He is waiting for us to do something.*

"Wait for what?" Frik signed back, badly, with the wrong handshape, and Mira's mouth did the thing that was almost a smile.

To ask. Not to land. She watched a moment longer. *He has done this many times. He is not nervous. We are nervous.*

The man on the apron said something then, across the water, in Pohnpeian, to Eperiam — and Eperiam answered, short, and the two of them had a small exchange in the unhurried register of people who have all the tide in the world. Edith caught none of the words. Mira caught the shape of them, the way the older man's chin came up at one point and Eperiam's shoulders dropped a centimetre in response, and she signed: *He asked who we are. Eperiam said it. The old man already knew.*

Of course he already knew. There are no strangers on a small island. There were only people who had not yet been formally accounted for, which was a different and more dangerous thing.

The man came down to the water's edge at last — not to welcome them, Edith understood, but to be heard. His English, when he used it, was careful and complete, the English of a man who'd taught it, or been taught it hard.

"You are the ones doing the lifting," he said. Not a question.

Yusuf stood, carefully, in the rocking boat. "We tried to," he said. "We didn't manage it. We rafted a column halfway and lost our nerve at the wall." He paused. "It came out a potato."

Something moved at the corner of the old man's mouth. "Yes," he said. "They usually do."

"There've been others?"

“There have been many others.” He looked past Yusuf, out at the great grey mass of Nandauwas standing across two more channels, the walls catching the flat morning. “Men with cranes. Men with universities. Men with — what is the word — *logistics*. They come and they measure and they make their drawings and they say, *with this many men and this many ropes and this many years*.” He spread his hands, a small gesture that took in the whole reef, the whole impossible arithmetic of it — three-quarters of a million tonnes hauled across twenty-five miles of open water and stacked into walls higher than a house, on a flat of dead coral that has never in its life grown a yam or held a cup of fresh water, where no living soul could stay a week without canoes bringing everything, every day, for four hundred years. “And then they go home. And the wall is still here, and they have not moved one stone of it, and they did not have to, because it was already moved.” He looked back at them. “By somebody.”

“By the Saudeleur,” Yusuf said. Gently. Offering it.

“By the Saudeleur,” the old man agreed. And then, mild as the tide: “We don’t know how.”

Edith watched Mira go still.

It was a particular stillness, and Edith had learned to read it the way Mira read faces — not the content, never the content, just the *that*. Mira had heard the sentence land and had felt, the way you feel a draught from a door you thought was a wall, that it was not the sentence it pretended to be. *We don’t know how*. True. Cited. In every paper. And under it, behind it, held shut against the latch of it, something that was not ignorance at all.

Mira did not move toward it.

That was the whole of it, and Edith — who’d spent forty years moving *toward*, who’d built a life and a tremor out of moving toward — saw her not move, and felt something in her own chest unclench that she hadn’t known was a fist.

“*We don’t know how*,” says the keeper. And the camera crew, and the engineers, and the universities all nod, because it’s true — nobody’s reproduced the lift, the residue’s real, the hole’s wide open and honest. But

here's a small fish-shaped observation from the shallows: there's a difference between a man who doesn't know the answer and a man who's standing at the door of the room the answer's in, holding it shut, telling you politely there's nothing inside. Same five words. Opposite weather.

I'm not saying which one this is. I literally cannot — that's the man's to say, not mine and not yours. But you felt it too, didn't you. Right there. The draught.

"You want to go in," the old man said.

It was the moment. Edith felt the whole crew lean into it without moving, the old reflex, the *yes, let us in, we'll be respectful, we just want to understand* — the thing every visitor had said on this apron since the first European waded ashore with a notebook and a theory. She had her camera in her lap. The light was, in fact, perfect now, the tide-silver throwing it up under the walls, and there would never be a better frame, and her thumb knew exactly where the switch was.

She thought about the boy whose name she'd never asked.

She put the camera down on the thwart, face down, lens to the wood, and folded her hands over it the way the old man folded his.

"We'd like to ask," she said. "Whether we may. And whether we may photograph. And if the answer to either is no, that's the answer, and we'll go back on the tide."

The old man looked at her for a long moment. He looked at the camera, face down under her hands. Then he looked at Mira, who had not asked for anything and had not reached for anything, who was simply sitting in the bow witnessing him with the whole of her attention — the attention of someone who'd been given no other channel her entire life and had made it into the only thing worth having.

"You," he said to Mira. "You read people."

Mira held his eyes. She didn't deny it. She signed, slow, and Yusuf began to voice it, and the old man lifted one hand — *no need* — and watched her hands instead, because he could read a body too, that was his whole office, and the two of them had a conversation in a language neither of them shared and both of them spoke.

You are holding something, her hands said. I see that you are holding it. I am not going to ask what it is.

The old man's chin came up, the same centimetre Edith had watched Eperiam answer to.

"No," he agreed. "You are not."

He told them to come back at the slack of the high tide, when the channels would carry the skiff up to the second apron, and to leave the engine outside, and to bring nothing that didn't fit in their two hands. He did not say yes to the camera. He did not say no. He said, "We will see what you do with your hands first," which was not an answer, and Edith — who had spent a career insisting on the answer, on the frame, on the truth taken before it could be composed — found she could sit in the not-knowing of it without her hands shaking, for once, at all.

Eperiam took his foot off the gunwale and the skiff drifted free, and the old man stood on his apron and watched them go without waving, the way you'd watch anything you weren't yet finished deciding about.

Frik, halfway back down the channel, looked at his cold coffee, and then at the great walls falling away behind them, and then at Edith's camera lying face down on the wood.

"You didn't even take the easy one," he said. Not a criticism. Something closer to awe.

"No," Edith said.

She didn't pick it up. The walls went by, five and a half to seven and a half metres of somebody's hauled-across-the-sea love for their dead, and she let them go by unphotographed, into her eyes only, and she found she could keep them there. The light was perfect. She let it be perfect for somebody else to give her, or not.

Out past the reef edge the open ocean started, the twenty-five flat miles of it that something had crossed three-quarters of a million times, and over it the clouds were stacking up the way they did every afternoon over the wettest island on earth, and nobody in the boat said anything at all, which on this water was the most articulate thing they'd done yet.

Chapter 15 — The Unheard

The tide came in the way it always did, without asking. Mira felt it before she saw it — the canal water shifting against the islet's stone foot, a low push she took up through the soles of her feet where she sat. She had her back to a wall that was older than every country she'd ever flown out of, and she was watching a man's mouth not move.

The custodian sat across the channel from her, on the Nandauwas side, on a column laid flat by hands no one could name. Between them ran maybe four metres of green water, a “space between,” the kind the whole place was named for. Yusuf was talking. Yusuf was always talking when he was nervous, and he was nervous now because the question had finally been asked plainly and the answer had come back the same as every answer for a hundred years.

We don't know.

Mira read the three words off the custodian's lips, then read everything else.

The crew didn't see it yet. She gave them that — they were good, they were kind, they signed for her at the table at night with hands like men buttering bread in the dark, and Frik had learned the sign for *basalt* just to make her laugh. But they heard the words and stopped there, because that was what words were for, in their world. You said a thing and the thing was said.

She had never lived in that world. She had spent forty years in rooms where the words went over her head like gulls and the truth sat down on people's faces where they thought no one was looking. You learn to read the face when the mouth is a door you were never given the

key to. You learn the difference between *I don't know* and *I won't say* the way a sailor learns weather — not as a fact but as a thing in the gut.

The custodian's *we don't know* was not the first kind.

The official story is clean, and it is true, and Mira had come to love it the way you love a thing that holds its shape under pressure.

A medieval dynasty — the Saudeleur — unified a drenched volcanic island and built, on a reef flat at its southeast edge, a city of the dead. Ninety-two artificial islets, give or take, laced with tidal canals you crossed by canoe on the rising water. The radiocarbon puts the monumental work at around AD 1180. Not antiquity. Not Atlantis. Medieval. There were cathedrals going up in Europe the same century, and here, on a reef in the western Pacific, a people were laying basalt logs into walls and stacking them seven metres high to house their kings in death.

The stone helps. Nature pre-cut it. Columnar basalt comes out of cooling lava in long hexagonal prisms — the Giant's Causeway physics, the Devils Tower physics — and the builders read that gift correctly and stacked the columns dry, header against stretcher, a long face then an end, log-cabin style, course on course on a bed of coral rubble. No mortar. Jakobus had spent an hour at it the first day, two fingers laid along a joint, reading the *how-it-stands* the way Mira read a face, and he had said almost nothing because the wall said it for him.

That part is solved. That part is craft, legible, magnificent, *human*.

Then you do the arithmetic, and the arithmetic does not stay quiet.

Naila had laid it out for them flat, on the second night, in a voice with no salesmanship in it. Mira had watched her mouth and her hands both and found no gap between them, which was its own kind of relief.

Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt. Spread over four centuries of building, that is roughly eighteen hundred tonnes a year, every year, sustained, for four hundred years. The columns run five

to twenty-five tonnes apiece. A single cornerstone at Nandauwas comes in around fifty.

And the quarry is roughly twenty-five miles away, on the far side of the island.

So you take a fifty-tonne stone — a stone the weight of a loaded lorry, a stone you cannot push, cannot roll up a beach, cannot carry on shoulders no matter how many shoulders — and you get it across twenty-five miles of open salt water, and then you raise it, on a reef, by hand, into a wall already five metres tall, with no crane, no documented ramp, nothing dragged ashore and forgotten that would tell a careful modern eye *here is how*.

They had tried, of course. People always try. Experimental archaeology has gone at the quarry-to-wall feat with rafts and ropes and clever men, and it has fallen short. Not *impossible* — nobody honest says impossible. Just: not yet done again. The thing stands there flawless and the people who came to repeat it made, every time, a potato.

The columns on the seabed don't help the tidy story either. A University of Oregon dive in '88 and '89 found basalt columns on the sea floor seaward of the site, and the prosaic, honest reading is the right one: lost cargo. A raft that didn't make it. Stone that went over the side on a bad swell, twenty-five miles from where it was going. Which tells you the haul was real, and hard, and sometimes lethal — and tells you nothing at all about the method, because the method is exactly the thing that never came back to shore.

Mira had stood at the canal edge with that number — eighteen hundred tonnes a year — and felt the old instinct light up, the crew's shared disease: *solve it. Read it. Know it*. It was the instinct that made them unhirable everywhere else and indispensable to each other. It was the instinct she was sitting on now with both hands.

Yusuf had moved on to the worst part, the part that broke the *why* clean off the *how*.

"There's no water," he was saying, across the channel, gentle, almost pleading, the way you ask a thing you already know the shape of. "On

the islets. No fresh water. Nothing grows. You couldn't keep a person alive out here a week without canoes coming in every day."

The custodian let that sit on the water.

This is the second hole, and it is the one that won't let go of you once it has you. They didn't just move three-quarters of a million tonnes of stone across the sea. They moved it to a place that could not feed or water a single living soul. A city for the dead, built where the living could only visit. Every drop of water, every yam, every mouthful that the priests and the workers and the keepers ever swallowed out here came by canoe, on the tide, forever. You don't do that by accident. You don't do that because it was convenient. You do it because the *where* was the whole point, and the point is not written down anywhere a stranger can read it.

Why here, the wall asks. Why drag a metropolis across the ocean to a reef that keeps no one alive.

The official answer to that, too, is *we don't know*. And it is true. And out here, on this ground, in this man's mouth, it was doing a second job.

Mira saw it the way she saw everything — not as a thought arriving but as a thing that had always been there, surfacing.

It was in the stillness around his eyes when Yusuf pushed. Not the flat blankness of a man who has nothing. The other thing. The held thing. She had worn it on her own face ten thousand times in rooms where she'd understood every word on every lip and chosen to let them think she hadn't, because the silence was the only thing in the room that was hers.

A man who doesn't know shrugs and his shoulders go loose. A man who *won't* say holds his shoulders exactly level, and keeps his hands quiet, and lets his eyes rest somewhere just past your shoulder so you can't fish in them. The custodian's hands were folded. His eyes were on the water between them, on the space between, which was the most honest place he could have put them.

He knew something. Mira would have bet her hearing aids on it, if they'd been worth betting. He knew, or his line knew, what this place

was *for* — which king, which rite, which reason the dead were carried out onto a reef and walled in basalt where the wind and the tide had them to themselves. He knew, and it was not hers, and it was not Yusuf's, and it had been kept by men like him through the Saudeleur and through Isokelekel and through every missionary and surveyor and documentary crew and treasure-eyed outfit that had ever come across the water with a question and a hunger.

We don't know was the door. It had been the door for four hundred years. It was a good door. It had held.

Edith had lifted her camera, slow, the way she did now — asking with the lens before she took, the war still in the way she handled the thing, the habit of the frame that costs somebody. The custodian's eyes flicked to it. Mira watched him decide to allow it, and watched him decide what it would and wouldn't get. Edith lowered the camera anyway, a hair, and shot the water instead of the man. Mira loved her a little extra for it.

Across the channel, Frik shifted, and she felt him gathering breath to ask it a third way, a cleverer way, the way that had cracked open a dozen quiet men in a dozen quiet bars. The crew's whole reflex, leaning toward the gap, smelling the held thing, certain — as they always were, as they had every right to be, it was *who they were* — that one more good question would let the truth out.

Mira put her hand flat on the warm stone and stood up.

She crossed to where Yusuf sat and crouched by him, and she signed it small, just for the crew, her hands low and slow so even Frik could follow.

He knows.

Yusuf's face did the thing she'd known it would. The lift, the hunger, the lean. *He knows?* — already half-turned back to the channel, already framing the next question.

She caught his wrist. Held it. Shook her head, once.

He knows, she signed again. *And it isn't ours.*

She watched it travel through them. Watched Yusuf's lean settle back

down into his hips. Watched Frik let the breath out unspent. Edith already had it — Edith, who had spent a career learning exactly what a frame steals, who had spent this whole trip asking the camera to come down. Naila, the only one of them with letters after her name and a stake in the answer, looked at the custodian and then at the water and then folded her notebook closed without writing anything in it, which Mira thought was the bravest thing she'd seen an academic do.

The hardest part was that they *could* have got it. Maybe. With the third question, or the tenth, or the bottle of sakau and the long evening and the rapport they were genuinely good at. They were the best readers of held things she had ever stood among, because every one of them had spent a life watching rooms they were never let into. That was the gift. That was the whole gift.

And the gift's twin, the one nobody had ever taught any of them, the one she was only now holding in her two hands at the edge of a sacred canal on the far side of the world: knowing a door is shut, and *not putting your shoulder to it*.

She turned back to the custodian. He was watching her — had been, she understood, watching her the whole time, the one across the water who'd stood up before the question came. He had read her reading him. Of course he had. He had spent his life keeping a thing the way she'd spent hers being kept out, and the two of them met now across four metres of green tidewater in a recognition that needed no mouth at all.

She didn't ask him what it was for.

She lifted her hand instead — not the question hand, not the reaching hand. The flat, open palm, held still, that in any language on earth means *I see you, and I'm not coming closer*. She held it where he could read it.

The custodian looked at the open hand. And the held stillness around his eyes eased — not into telling, never into telling, but into something Mira had wanted her whole life and never once been given by a hearing room: he let her see that he saw that she'd stopped.

He inclined his head, the smallest motion, toward the water between

them. Toward the space. Then he stood, in his own time, on his own ground, and the tide carried his canoe a half-turn so the channel widened, and the door he had held for four centuries stayed exactly as shut as he had brought it.

Out on the reef the wall stood up against the sky, seven metres of basalt logs laid dry by hands no one could name, holding the dead of a dynasty on a stone where nothing drinks and nothing grows, for a reason that was his to give or keep — and he kept it.

Mira put her hand down. Behind her, very quietly, Frik signed *basalt*, just to make her smile, and it almost worked.

She didn't need to know. That was the new thing, the thing the narrator will not name for her because she would never name it herself. She had crossed the whole world to a place built on the spaces between, and found the one space she would not try to fill.

Some doors you read. Some doors you leave.

The water closed over the question and held it, the way it had always held everything else.

Chapter 16 — The Hand Off

The tide had gone out far enough that you could hear the wall.

Frik didn't expect that. He'd expected the slap of water in the canals, the mangrove ticking, the outboard somebody was failing to start two islets over. What he hadn't expected was the wall itself making a sound — a low, dry, settling sigh as the basalt shed the day's heat into the cooling air, each column easing a hair against its neighbour the way old timber does in a barn at dusk. Seven metres of stacked stone, breathing.

Nandauwas. The big enclosure. The royal one.

He stood at the foot of it with his hands in his pockets because there was nothing useful to do with his hands here, and that was the whole problem with Frik on a good day. He watched the others arrange themselves the way the crew always arranged themselves: Mira a half-step back, reading the gaps between people; Edith with the camera *down*, hanging off her shoulder, lens to her hip, which was its own kind of statement on this ground; Yusuf doing arithmetic under his breath because Yusuf was incapable of standing in front of a large object without weighing it.

And Jakobus, who had come a very long way to look at someone else's wall.

The Beast was forty kilometres away and useless, shipped onto an island it couldn't help him cross. He'd come the last stretch by skiff like everyone else, on the tide, by permission. He looked, Frik thought, faintly absurd here — a weathered man built for dust and roads, standing in mangrove light with his trousers rolled — and not absurd at all the second he started to read.

He didn't touch it first. That was the tell Frik had learned to watch for. Lesser men touched it first.

Jakobus put his hands behind his back and walked the base course slowly, his head tipped, following something with his eyes that Frik couldn't see until Jakobus made him see it.

"There," he said. Not loud. "And there. See how he's laid it."

Frik looked.

"Long face. Then the end. Then the long face." Jakobus's chin moved along the course like a man counting boxcars. "Length of the stone running *with* the wall — that's your stretcher. Then he turns one ninety degrees, drives it *into* the wall — that's your header, the end-grain showing, tying the front face to the back. Stretcher, header, stretcher. Course on course, and he staggers the joints so no seam runs straight up." He stepped back. "It's a log cabin. Same binding a man in Norway builds in pine. Built in basalt logs that the planet split for him."

Oh good, said the fish, from nowhere and everywhere, the way it did. The planet pre-cut the LEGO. That's the part everyone leans on. "Nature made hexagons, mystery solved." Sure. And the bricks at the hardware store come pre-fired, so I assume your house assembled itself.

Yusuf, still under his breath: "Five to twenty-five tonnes a column. The cornerstone's about fifty."

"Fifty," Jakobus agreed, like a man hearing a price he respects.

This is the official story, and it is true, and the crew had spent a fortnight learning to revere it: a medieval city. Not a lost continent, not skymasons — a known dynasty, the Saudeleur, who unified an island and ruled it from the water until a man named Isokelekel came and unmade them, somewhere around the early seventeenth century. The radiocarbon puts the great building phase from about AD 1180. While cathedrals were going up in stone across Europe, the people of this reef were going up in stone too, in their own grammar, for their own dead. Ninety-two islets. Canals threaded between them — *Nan Madol*, the spaces between. Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt, give or take, laid down at something like eighteen hundred tonnes a year for four hundred years.

Frik had seen Yusuf write those numbers in his notebook and then sit very still in front of them, which from Yusuf was a kind of reverence too.

“And the how-it-stands,” Jakobus said, “I can give you. I’d stake the road on it. Dry-laid, header-and-stretcher, on a coral-rubble raft so the whole island floats its own weight on the reef. That’s a builder’s answer. I’d build it that way. I could *teach* a man to lay a course like this by Thursday.”

He stopped.

“What I can’t tell you,” he said, and here his voice changed — got smaller, got careful, the way it always did right before the part Frik had come to think of as *the relay* — “is how the fifty-tonne one got onto the top of a seven-metre wall, on a reef, by hand, with no crane, no ramp, and nothing left lying about to say so. And I can’t tell you why anyone dragged it twenty-five miles across open sea to a place with no water in it and not one thing growing you could eat.”

Don’t look at me, said the fish. I’m a fish. I’m extremely qualified to live on a reef with no fresh water and I STILL wouldn’t build a city here.

This was the potato, and it had been a real one. Frik had watched it happen with his own eyes back at the start — a modern team, a good archaeologist, a hired engineer and his rig, raft one column the easy way, the *settled* way, the way the move-along version implies it was routine. And the raft had sat low and sullen and the lift had been a misery and the thing they got up had been a lumpy, sweating, four-man approximation of a craft that had stood flawless behind them the whole time, not deigning to comment. Experimental archaeology has tried to reproduce the quarry-to-wall feat. It has not, so far, managed. *Not yet reproduced* — which is a smaller and more honest sentence than *impossible*, and a stranger one, because impossible you can file and forget. *Not yet* keeps you awake.

The columns on the seabed off Sokehs — the divers from Oregon found them back in ’88, ’89 — read, soberly, as lost cargo. A haul that didn’t make it. Evidence of the carrying, not of anything that flew. Frik liked that. It was the right size of mystery: not a drowned temple, just the fact that someone was *carrying basalt across open water by the tonne* and sometimes dropped it.

So you had the how-it-stands, which Jakobus had just handed over clean. And you had the two holes, which he hadn't, because they weren't his to close.

What you had left was the third thing. The question Jakobus came across the world to *not* answer.

"What's it for," Frik said, before he could stop himself.

It came out into a silence and lay there.

Jakobus didn't take it. That was the thing Frik kept failing to be ready for, every single time, the move that made Jakobus *Jakobus* and not just a clever man with a good eye. He had the answer to so many things. He read this wall like other people read a paragraph. And the one question that mattered — *what is it for* — he turned, deliberately, like a man turning a header into a wall, and drove it sideways.

He looked at the custodian.

The custodian had been there the whole time. He'd come up from the skiff with them and stood off to the side, near the corner of the great enclosure, in the relaxed, rooted way of a man who is on his own ground and has nothing to prove to people who are not. A wind-breaker over a faded shirt. He'd watched Jakobus walk the base course with an expression Frik couldn't fully read, which was unusual, because Frik could usually read *something*. He looked at the custodian and got: patience. Amusement, maybe, at the edges. And under it, shut like a good door, something Frik had no business reaching for.

Mira had gone still in the particular way she went still. Frik clocked that. She was watching the custodian's hands, his shoulders, the set of his jaw, the whole grammar of a body, and whatever she was reading there she was reading three beats ahead of the rest of them and she was not saying it out loud.

Jakobus spoke to the custodian directly. Not over his shoulder, not as a performance for the crew. To him.

"I can tell you how your ancestors stood it up," Jakobus said. "I'd be a fool to tell you what they stood it up *for*."

The custodian let that sit. He had the gift — Frik envied it the way he envied anyone unhurried — of letting a thing sit without filling it.

“People come,” the custodian said at last. Easy. Friendly, even. “They ask how. We tell them what we know, which is plenty. They ask why.” He smiled a little. “We tell them we don’t know.”

He just lied, said the fish, very quietly, in the tone it used maybe twice a book. No. Hang on. He didn’t lie. Watch his face. That’s not the face of a man who doesn’t know. I’m a fish and even I can — okay. Okay. Not my reef. Carrying on.

Frik glanced at Mira.

Mira had heard the same thing he had — except she hadn’t *heard* it, she’d seen it, off the mouth, off the body, off the half-second between the question and the easy answer that was a beat too smooth to be ignorance. *We don’t know* came out of the custodian the way a well-oiled gate swings: no resistance, no hunting for it. Frik watched her watch it. He watched her understand exactly what the custodian was doing — which was holding a door shut, politely, with both hands, in front of guests — and he watched her decide, in real time, not to put her shoulder to it.

She caught Frik looking. The smallest movement of her head. *Leave it.*

He left it.

It is, in fairness, the easiest thing in the world to leave a *we don’t know* alone, until you’ve spent a fortnight learning that this one was load-bearing. That there was an outfit forty kilometres back in Kolonia in an air-conditioned office with renderings on the wall and a slide that said *site of undetermined historical significance*, and that the renderings looked very nice, and that the whole pitch — the thing that made the ground *takeable* — rested on the same three words. *Even the locals say they don’t know.* A vacancy. A riddle free for the solving, which is to say free for the developing, because you can pour a foundation in a vacancy but you cannot pour one in a grave with keepers.

The custodian’s *we don’t know* and the developer’s *we don’t know* were, Frik thought, the exact same words. And they meant the precise opposite. One was a hand on a door. The other was a crowbar.

Mira could tell them apart. Frik had watched her do it. It was the only

thing on this island anyone could do that the engineer's rig and the archaeologist's trowel and Jakobus's perfect eye could not, and she was doing it without saying a single word, and the not-saying was the whole point.

Jakobus inclined his head to the custodian. Not a bow. An acknowledgement. The kind one tradesman gives another across a finished joint.

"Then that's where it sits," he said.

"That's where it sits," the custodian agreed.

And that was the relay, complete. Frik felt it land — not as a solution, because nothing had been solved, but as a *handing over*. The how-it-stands: Jakobus's, given freely, a builder's pride in another builder's work. The how-it-got-here and the why-a-foodless-reef: open, honest, nobody's, hanging in the salt air for anyone to stand under. And the what-it-for — the heart of it, the meaning, the thing the whole hungry world wanted to take home in its pocket — that one had a custodian, and a protocol, and a right, and it stayed exactly where it had been for four hundred years.

Edith hadn't lifted the camera once.

Frik noticed that last, the way you notice the dog that didn't bark. She'd stood through the whole of it with the lens at her hip and her hand loose on the strap, and for a woman whose entire life was the choosing of what to frame, the choosing *not* to was the loudest thing she'd done all week.

The tide was on the turn. You could feel it before you could see it — the canals beginning to fill, the water finding its way back up the spaces between, the islets reconnecting their dark veins. They'd go out the way they came in, by water, by leave.

Jakobus took one more look up the wall, all seven metres of it, the staggered joints, the fifty-tonne stone sitting up there in the dimming light where no one had any business getting it.

"Beautiful work," he said, to the wall, or to the man who built it eight hundred years ago, or to the custodian standing at the corner of it now — Frik genuinely couldn't tell which, and decided he didn't need to.

The custodian heard it anyway. He looked up at the same stone.

“Yes,” he said. And did not say what it was for.

Chapter 17 — The Checkable Thing

The fan in the crew house turned just fast enough to move the heat from one corner to another, which was its only achievement of the evening. Yusuf had the table to himself, more or less — Mira at the far end with a cold mug of tea and the angle of someone who'd decided to watch rather than join, Edith on the floor with her back against the wall and a lens cap she kept screwing and unscrewing without thinking about it, Frik somewhere out on the step where the signal lived, swearing at a phone.

Yusuf liked a table at night. He liked the way the fluorescent tube above it bleached everything down to fact. He had three notebooks, two of them his, and a printout that had gone soft at the folds from being carried in a damp pocket across the lagoon and back.

"Right," he said. "From the top. No flourishes. I want to know what we actually have."

"You always want that," Edith said, not unkindly.

"And I'm always disappointed." He uncapped a pen. "Tonnage first. It's the cleanest number we've got, so we use it as the floor." He wrote it large, the way you write a thing you intend to lean your whole weight on. ~750,000 t. "Three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt. That's the total mass of the complex. Not a guess pulled off a tour board — that's the order-of-magnitude figure the surveys land on. It could be off. It's not off by a factor of ten."

Mira's eyes moved from the number to his mouth and back. She wasn't reading him for a lie. There wasn't one. She was reading him

for the place where he stopped believing his own summary, which was a different thing, and which she'd find before he did.

"Now," Yusuf went on, "divide it. Megalithic phase starts around AD 1180 — radiocarbon, that's solid, that's a date with a method behind it, not a story. Dynasty's gone by the early seventeenth century. Call the building span four centuries to be generous to everybody." He did the arithmetic in the margin, the long way, because he didn't trust the answer he already knew. "Seven-fifty thousand over four hundred years. Eighteen hundred and fifty tonnes a year. Every year. For four hundred years."

He set the pen down.

"That's not a heroic burst," he said. "That's not a king clapping his hands and a thousand men jumping. That's a *rate*. That's the same crews, the same canoes, the same reef, year on year on year, a tonnage a season that doesn't let up for sixteen generations. It's the most boring number in the file and it's the one that scares me."

"*Eighteen-fifty a year*," came the voice from the doorway — Frik, back in off the step, phone dark, sliding onto the bench. He pitched it flat and bright, the way he pitched everything, which was how you knew he'd actually done the sum himself out there in the dark. "That's, what, five tonnes a day if you knock off Sundays. Light work. I move that before breakfast."

"You move five tonnes of basalt twenty-five miles over open water before breakfast."

"I said *light* work, I didn't say I'd enjoy it."

Yusuf almost smiled, which was its own kind of confession, and moved on.

"The haul. This is the one the room never wants to slow down for, so we slow down." He turned the printout around so the others could see it, though only Edith leaned in. "The quarries are on the other side of the island. Sokehs side. Call it twenty-five miles by the route a loaded canoe would actually take, hugging the coast, riding the tide. The stone is columnar basalt — and here's the part the fringe forgets and the textbook says plainly: *nature cut it*. The hexagonal logs aren't carved. Thick lava cooled, contracted, cracked itself

into prisms. Same physics as the Giant's Causeway. Same as Devils Tower. The island handed them the blocks pre-shaped."

"So that part's easy," Edith said.

"That part's a gift," Yusuf agreed. "And it's the only easy part, and everyone who wants the whole thing to be easy points at it and pretends the rest comes free." He tapped the figure again. "Columns run five to twenty-five tonnes, common ones. There's a cornerstone at Nandauwas that comes in around fifty."

Mira lifted two fingers off her mug. *Say that one again.* He saw it.

"Fifty tonnes," he said, for her, slower. "One stone. Now — you've rafted it. Say you've solved the rafting, which nobody's shown you how to do, but say it. You're at the reef. The wall you're building it into is between five and a half and seven and a half metres high. Dry-stacked. No mortar. Header and stretcher, log-cabin style — long face, then end, long face, then end, so the courses bind." He drew it, badly, a child's idea of a wall. "Beautiful grammar. Jakobus read it off in about a minute and a half, the *how it stands*. That's not the hole. The hole is the verb in the middle. You've got fifty tonnes of basalt floating at the foot of a seven-metre wall, on a reef, on a tide, and now you *lift* it. By hand. No crane. No ramp anyone's ever found. Nothing left behind on the reef that says *this is how*. No worn timber, no posthole pattern, no spoil heap of failed attempts. The wall's just there. Flawless. Like it grew."

The fan moved the heat into the other corner.

"And before anyone says *ramps, levers, obviously*—" Yusuf held up the soft printout like evidence in a court that wasn't in session. "People have *tried*. That's the part I keep coming back to, because it's the part that's actually checkable and the part that's actually honest. Experimental archaeology. People with the right hands and the right questions and a genuine wish to show it could be done. They went out and tried to do the quarry-to-wall feat — move a column, raft it, set it — the way the settled story implies it was routine." He let it sit. "They didn't reproduce it. Not 'it's physically impossible' — I'm not saying that and the file doesn't say that. I'm saying the careful phrase, the true phrase, the one that doesn't reach: *not yet reproduced*. The brightest version of *us*, with kit those builders never had, tried the easy story and made a potato."

“A potato,” Frik said, with relish, because it was the crew’s word and he loved it the way you love a thing that’s true.

“A potato,” Yusuf said. “Stands there next to the real wall, half the size and twice the sweat, and the real wall doesn’t even look at it.”

Edith had stopped fiddling with the lens cap. “You’re enjoying this too much.”

“I’m enjoying it the right amount. It’s the cleanest case I’ve worked. There’s no trick to find because nobody’s hiding one.” He flipped a page. “The columns on the seabed. Nineteen eighty-eight, eighty-nine, University of Oregon, they’re down there off the reef — basalt columns on the sea floor. Now: a certain kind of person wants that to be a drowned building. A sunken temple. The bottom storey of the lost city.” He shook his head, slow. “And the prosaic read is the *better* story, because it’s true and it’s still astonishing. It’s lost cargo. It’s a canoe that went over, or a raft that came apart, on the haul. It’s the freight that didn’t make it. Which means—” he underlined nothing, just touched the page “—it’s *physical evidence of the haul itself*. Proof the stone crossed the water. Not proof of anything stranger. The strange thing is already the true thing: somebody was moving fifty-tonne logs across open ocean often enough that some of them sank, and we found the ones that sank, and we *still* can’t tell you how the ones that didn’t sink got lifted onto a wall.”

A moth had got in and was working the tube above them, a soft irregular tick against the glass.

“And then,” Yusuf said, and this was the part where his voice changed, dropped a register, lost the courtroom and found something more like the inside of his own chest, “there’s the question that the tonnage and the haul are only servants of. *Why here*. No fresh water on those islets. None. Grows no food. You can’t keep a single soul alive out there for a week without a canoe coming the other way, loaded, every day, forever. It’s not a city you *live* in. It’s a city for the dead, on a reef that won’t feed the living, twenty-five miles downstream of the only stone that’ll build it.” He spread his hands flat on the table. “So it’s not just *how did they lift it*. It’s *why drag three-quarters of a million tonnes across the sea to a place that could keep no one alive*. You answer the first one and you’ve still got the second one staring at you. They feed each other. Always have.”

Quiet. The moth. The fan.

“That’s the file,” Yusuf said. “That’s everything we actually have, with no story laid over the top of it. Every number on this table is real, and every one of them is a number the people who study this place put there themselves. The holes aren’t ours. We didn’t dig them to be clever. The archaeology *leaves them open*. It says, in print, in the careful words: transport-and-lift, not demonstrated; siting and provisioning, not fully explained. That’s mainstream. That’s the textbook leaving its own door ajar and being honest enough to say so.” He capped the pen. “Which is the only kind of hole worth standing in front of. The kind nobody’s lying about.”

Frik laced his hands behind his head. “So we *don’t* know.”

“We don’t know *how*, and we don’t know *why-here*,” Yusuf said. “Cleanly. Provably. Those are checkable things. You can go and check them and they’ll still be holes when you’re done checking.”

It was Mira who moved then. She set the cold tea down with a small click and pulled a notepad toward her — the crew signed, badly, lovingly, but the table was the table and she liked it black on white when it mattered. She wrote one line and turned it so Yusuf could read it.

That’s not the same kind of don’t-know.

He read it. Read it again. “Than what?”

She took the pad back. Wrote, and turned it.

Than the one we heard on the canal.

The fan turned. The moth gave up and sat.

Yusuf looked at the line a long time. He’d built the whole evening to land on *we don’t know* like it was the floor — the honest, cold-eyed, mainstream-acknowledged floor, the one you could stand on without lying. And Mira had reached past the words on his table to the words they’d heard on the water, the custodian’s *we don’t know*, delivered with a face Yusuf had filed under *the same answer everyone gives* — and she was telling him, in five words on a notepad, that he’d filed it wrong. That one of those don’t-knows had a hole behind it you could measure. And the other one had a door.

He didn’t write it down. There was nothing to measure.

“You think they’re different,” he said.

She didn’t nod. She didn’t shrug. She held his eye the way she held a face when the mouth was busy saying one thing — and let the not-answering be the answer, which was a courtesy, and a line she wasn’t going to cross for him, and the most honest thing said at that table all night.

“Well,” came Frik, into the silence, soft for once, *“now I want to know which one’s which.”*

Nobody told him.

Yusuf gathered the notebooks and squared the soft printout against the table edge, the numbers all where he’d left them, all still true, all still open. Three-quarters of a million tonnes. Eighteen-fifty a year. Fifty tonnes on a wall, by hand, not yet reproduced. A city for the dead that couldn’t water the living. Real, every one. Checkable, every one. A draught you could stand in.

And one more that wasn’t on the page, that he had no figure for, that he wasn’t going to chase tonight — whether the silence out on the canal was a hole or a door, and whose it was to close.

He turned off the tube. The fan kept the heat moving from corner to corner, finding nowhere to put it.

Chapter 18 — The Offer

The bar at the Cliff Rainbow had a ceiling fan that turned just fast enough to push the heat around without moving it anywhere, and a television in the corner playing a rugby match nobody watched, the sound off, the score wrong, the whole thing buffering. Edith sat with her back to the wall out of habit she'd stopped apologising for years ago. From here she could see the door, the kitchen pass, and the man Yusuf had agreed to meet.

His name was Calloway. He had the kind of tan that costs money — even, maintained, the tan of a man who is outdoors on purpose and never by accident. Linen shirt, two buttons, a watch he didn't check because the watch was the point. He'd bought the first round before anyone sat down, which Edith filed the way she filed everything: a frame composed in advance.

"You've been out to the reef," he said. Not a question.

"We've been allowed out to the reef," Yusuf said. "There's a difference."

Calloway smiled at that like it was charming. He had a folder. People who carry folders into bars want you to see the folder before they open it, and he let it lie there on the wet ring his glass had left, untouched, breathing.

Edith had photographed men like this in three wars. The clean-handed ones were always the worst, because they never did the thing themselves. They funded it, they enabled it, they stood at the edge of the frame with their hands in their pockets while the actual taking happened just out of shot. You learned to read them by what they declined to look at.

Calloway hadn't once looked at Mira.

That was the tell, and it was a loud one. Mira sat to Edith's left, half-turned so she could see his mouth, her glass untouched, her hands quiet on the table. Calloway had clocked the hearing aid and the angle of her attention and had filed her, the way he filed everything, as not-a-decision-maker, and routed his face entirely to Yusuf and, occasionally, performatively, to Edith. *The man with the chequebook and the woman with the lens*. He thought he'd read the room.

He'd read the wrong half of it.

"Let me tell you what I love about this place," Calloway said, and turned his glass a quarter-turn on the table, lining it up with the folder. "What I genuinely love. It's the only unsolved one left."

"It's not unsolved," Yusuf said. "It's a Saudeleur mortuary capital. Radiocarbon puts the megalithic phase around eleven-eighty. There's a dynasty, there's a fall, there's an oral history four centuries deep. There are people in this town whose grandparents could name you the Nahnmwarki line."

"Sure." Calloway nodded along, agreeable as a brochure. "Sure. But ask anyone how they did it." He spread his hands. "Ask the engineers. Ask the archaeologists. Ask the *islanders*, God love them — what do they tell you?"

He waited. He wanted someone to say it. When nobody did, he said it himself, soft, almost tender:

"We don't know."

Edith felt the room change shape. Not loudly. The fan kept turning. But she'd heard those three words said the other way — said by an old man at the edge of a canal with his hand flat on a column of basalt, said the way you say *that is not for you* — and she'd heard them said now, by this man, and they were the same three words pointed in opposite directions, and she understood, sitting very still, that he was going to spend the next hour trying to make them mean the same thing.

"Three-quarters of a million tonnes," Calloway said. "Did you know that? Seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes of rock, give or take.

Rafted across — what is it, twenty-five miles of open ocean? A cornerstone that goes fifty tonnes on its own. Lifted into walls seven metres high. Dry-stacked. No mortar, no crane, no ramp, nothing left behind to tell you how.” He let it hang. “And here’s the part I really love. People have *tried* to do it again. Proper experimental archaeology, proper money, modern rigging. And they can’t. They get a column off the quarry floor and onto a raft and they look at the four hundred years of it and they go quiet.” He smiled. “Nobody’s reproduced it. Not once.”

“That’s true,” Yusuf said. Carefully. Because it was.

Edith had watched them try, in a way — not the historical attempts, but the spirit of them, in the failed lift back at the start, the modern team and the hired rig and the single basalt log that had come out a potato, lopsided and shameful in the shadow of the wall that had stood flawless behind it for eight hundred years. The thing on the reef didn’t care that you had hydraulics. It stood there and said nothing and made you look small. That gap — that exact gap — was the only honest thing in this whole bar, and Calloway had just laid it on the table like a winning card.

“So.” He finally touched the folder. Didn’t open it. Just touched it. “You’ve got a site of global significance, genuinely mysterious, photographs like a dream — Edith, I’ve seen your work, the canals at low tide, that’s a *cover*, that’s a Netflix open. And you’ve got an island that, with the warmest possible respect, *doesn’t know what it has*. That’s not a criticism. That’s just the situation. Nobody’s developed it. Nobody’s even properly *interpreted* it. There’s no visitor centre worth the name, no narrative, no —” he searched for the word and found the one he liked best — “no *custody*.”

“There’s plenty of custody,” Mira said.

It was the first thing she’d said. She said it flat and quiet and Calloway’s head came round at last, surprised, recalibrating, and Edith watched him do the arithmetic he should have done forty minutes ago.

“Of course,” he said, recovering. “Of course. I only mean — institutionally. Formally. The kind of custody that protects a place like this from, frankly, the wrong people getting to it first.” He spread his hands again. The hands did a lot of work. “Which is where we come

in.”

The folder opened.

Edith didn't lean toward it. She'd learned long ago that the photograph you want is rarely the one being offered. She kept her eyes on his face and let Yusuf read the numbers, and she read Calloway reading them being read.

“Heritage management partnership,” he was saying. “We're not buying anything — you can't buy it, it's sacred ground, we'd never — God, no. It's a *stewardship* model. We bring capital, infrastructure, conservation, a real scientific program. Dignified, controlled access. And the local stakeholders — the Nahnmwarki, the state, whoever's the right table — they're partners. Equity partners. There's a number on page three for the community that I'd ask you to look at before you make a face.”

Yusuf looked at page three. He did not make a face, which was its own kind of face.

“The genius of it,” Calloway went on, warming, and this was the part he'd come to say, “is that the mystery is the asset. You don't solve it. You'd be mad to solve it. The not-knowing is the whole product. People will pay to stand inside a question nobody can answer. We protect that. We frame it, we light it, we *preserve the not-knowing* — and we keep it out of the hands of, you know. The lost-continent crowd. The aliens-built-it people. The pseudo-archaeology grifters who'd turn it into a circus.”

“You'd protect it,” Mira said, “by keeping it empty of meaning.”

“I'd protect it by keeping it *open* as a question.”

“Same thing.” She still hadn't raised her voice. “An empty question's easier to fence.”

Calloway laughed, genuinely delighted, the way men like him laugh when an underling turns out to have teeth — pleased to have found a worthier opponent, not for one second considering he might lose. “Now *that's* a line. You should write the brochure copy.” He turned back to Yusuf, the decision-maker, the man, the cheque. “Look. I'll be straight with you, because I think you'll respect straight. Three

other groups are circling this. I know two of them and they're worse than me, considerably. The window where this gets done *well* is closing, and it's closing because the people who'd do it badly don't need anyone's permission to start asking, and the people who *should* have the say —" he gestured, vaguely, at the town, at the dark beyond the louvres, at the whole drenched island — "haven't organised themselves to say no fast enough. That's not their fault. But it's true."

And the terrible thing, Edith thought, was that some of it was. Not the conclusion. But the diagnosis. A place with no agreed meaning and no single throat to say *no* through was the easiest thing in the world to take, and he hadn't invented that, he'd just arrived to profit from it, the way the tide arrives, neutral and patient and certain.

Edith set her camera on the table.

She did it slowly, both hands, the way you set down something heavier than it looks. She hadn't shot a frame all evening. It sat there now between them, lens cap on, and Calloway glanced at it and back to her with a small congratulatory nod, like she was finally producing the asset.

"You said you've seen my work," she said.

"I have. It's extraordinary."

"You said the canals at low tide. The cover shot."

"It's a hell of an image."

"I took it on the third morning," she said. "Custodian walked us out on the falling tide. There's a wall at Nandauwas, seven metres, the cornerstone's the one that goes about fifty tonnes — you know your numbers, you'll know the one. He put his hand on it. Not for me. He didn't know I was there yet. He put his hand flat on the stone the way you'd put it on a coffin." She kept her voice level. The fan turned. "I didn't take that one. I had the shot and I let it go. You know why?"

Calloway, for the first time all night, didn't have a line ready.

"Because the photograph would have been mine," Edith said, "and the grief was his. And there are things you can take that don't belong to you, and the camera doesn't make it not stealing. It makes it worse.

It makes it permanent.” She turned the camera so the lens faced the wall, away from all of them. “You want us to frame the not-knowing. I’ve spent twenty years framing things that weren’t mine to frame, in places where nobody could stop me, and I’ll tell you what you actually get when you do that. You get a beautiful picture of an empty room. And the people who lived in it are somewhere outside the edge of it, and they stay there, because the frame’s the fence now. You said it yourself. You’d preserve the not-knowing.” She nodded, slow. “That’s the part. That’s the whole thing. You’re not buying the mystery. You’re buying the *silence*. And it’s not for sale, because it’s not a vacancy.”

“Everything’s for sale,” Calloway said, but gently, and it came out less like a creed than a hope.

“That one isn’t ours to sell,” Yusuf said, and closed the folder. Slid it back across the wet ring, square, neat, the way it had come. “And it isn’t yours to buy from us. You’ve got the wrong table. We’re not even a table. We came out here on the tide because somebody let us. That’s the whole of our standing. We don’t have a ‘no’ to give you, Mr Calloway — and that’s exactly why we won’t give you a yes.”

Calloway looked at the three of them for a moment, and Edith watched him decide it had been a wasted evening, and then watched him decide it hadn’t — because now he knew where the crew stood, which was a thing worth the price of the drinks. He’d find his table. He’d said so. Three groups circling, two of them worse. He stood, buttoned the one button, left a note under his glass that was too much.

“You know the funny thing,” he said, folder under his arm, almost wistful. “I do love it. I really do. I’m not the villain you’ve decided I am. I just got here first.”

“You didn’t get here first,” Mira said.

He paused.

“People have been keeping that place for eight hundred years,” she said. “You got here last. You just got here loud.”

The fan turned. The rugby buffered. Calloway gave a small bow, half rueful, half something else, and went out into the warm and the diesel

and the frangipani and the dark, and the door swung and stuck and swung.

Yusuf let out a long breath. "Three other groups."

"And he's the best of them," Edith said.

Mira was looking at the door he'd gone through. "He had it nearly right," she said. "All of it. The tonnage, the cornerstone, the failed lifts, the no-water-no-food. He could pass the exam." She picked up her glass at last, looked at it, set it down. "He just thinks a thing nobody will explain to him is the same as a thing nobody knows."

Edith reached over and put the lens cap in her pocket and left the camera where it was, facing the wall, switched off, an instrument with the integrity to refuse a shot. Somewhere across the dark water the reef sat under the falling tide, seven metres of dry-stacked stone holding up four centuries of held breath, and not one column of it had ever once asked to be understood.

Outside, the tide was going out. By morning you could walk to the wall, if you were allowed.

Chapter 19 — The Wink

The tide came in before the sun did.

Mira felt it through the hull of the skiff first — the canal filling, the boat lifting off the coral it had rested on all night, a slow rise that put the water level with the lowest course of the wall. She had her hand flat on the gunwale and read the lagoon by the tremor in the wood: the long pull of the open sea outside the reef, then the smaller, busier slap of water finding the gaps between the islets. Spaces between. The whole place was a machine for moving water, and at the turn of the tide it ran.

The custodian sat in the bow with his back to the dawn, so that for a long while he was only a shape, and the light behind him came up the colour of the inside of a shell. He had not spoken since they pushed off from the mangrove. He was waiting for something, and Mira had learned by now not to fill the waiting.

Yusuf could not help himself. He never could before coffee.

“You said,” Yusuf began, and Mira watched his lips as much as she felt the boat carry the sound, “you said yesterday — when I asked who chose this reef — you said *they knew what they were doing*.”

The custodian’s face turned a few degrees. The light caught the side of it.

“I did say that.”

“So.” Yusuf had his hands open, the way he held them when he was being careful and failing. “Then it wasn’t random. Of all the reef flats on this coast — and we’ve flown over them, there are flatter ones, drier ones, ones nearer the springs — somebody picked *this*

one. Threaded ninety-odd islets through it. That's a decision. That's a plan." He stopped. Started again, gentler. "What's it *for*?"

There it was. The question Jakobus had carried to the canal's edge three days ago and set down at this man's feet without trying to answer it, the way you'd lay down a tool that wasn't yours to use. *Not who, not is-it-real*, the old fixer had said, in that flat voice of his that came from being a long way from his own ground. *What is it for*. And then he had stepped back, and let the question belong to the man who lived here.

Mira would tell them the shape of the official story later, on the boat back, because somebody always asked her to, and because she liked to get it straight in her own hands.

The story was honest and it was hard. A medieval dynasty — the Saudeleur, the line that pulled a fractious island under one rule — had made this their seat for the dead and for the rites of power. The radiocarbon put the monumental building at around AD 1180, which was the thing the lost-continent crowd never wanted to hear: not a drowned antiquity older than memory, but *medieval*. Contemporary with Notre-Dame going up across the world. People who had grandparents and account-keepers and quarrels over fishing rights, who lifted the same impossible stone.

Ninety-two islets. A core a kilometre and a half by half a kilometre. Walls at the great mortuary enclosure, Nandauwas, that ran five and a half to seven and a half metres high — taller than a house — built of basalt columns nature had pre-cut into hexagonal logs and human hands had stacked dry, no mortar, header laid across stretcher, a long face then an end, course on course, the way a builder binds a log cabin so the wall holds itself together by its own weight and cleverness.

And the arithmetic. Mira ran it because somebody on the crew always had to, and the others were tired. Three-quarters of a million tonnes of stone. Spread across the four centuries of building, call it eighteen hundred and fifty tonnes a year, every year, generation on generation. A single cornerstone of around fifty tonnes — fifty — quarried somewhere on the far side of the island and brought *here*, across open water, and then lifted onto a wall, on a reef, by hand, with

no crane and no ramp and nothing left behind to tell you how.

That was the part the official story said *we did this* and then went quiet on the *how*. Not because anyone was hiding it. Because nobody had found it. Experimental archaeology had gone out onto this very water with rafts and rope and good engineers and the best of intentions, and tried to do the easy version, the *obviously they just* version — and made, in the end, a potato. A short raft. A stone that wouldn't lift. A demonstration that demonstrated chiefly its own limits, while the real thing stood flawless and silent behind the cameras, seven metres of it, holding up four centuries of weather without a grain of mortar.

And no one lives here. That was the second hole, and it fed the first. No spring. No soil that grew food. A stone metropolis on a reef that could not keep a single soul alive without a canoe coming in on every tide with water and breadfruit and fish. So you had not only the *how* — how did they lift fifty tonnes onto a wall — but the *why here*: why drag the weight of a small mountain across the sea to a place no living person could stay.

Mira liked the holes. She had spent her life in the gaps where the words didn't reach, reading faces because the room never handed her the sound, and she had a fondness for a thing that stood there unexplained and refused to apologise for it.

The skiff slid into the main canal and the walls came up on both sides, dark and wet at the waterline, paling as the light climbed them. The custodian put his hand out — not a command, just a *here* — and Yusuf shipped the paddle and let them drift on the rising tide.

The custodian looked at the wall for a while. Then he answered.

"You stand on Nandauwas at the new moon," he said. "Where the high wall meets the low one — there, where the courses step. And you look out, between the islets, down the line of the canal." He lifted his chin at the channel ahead of them, the long straight run of black water with the sea-gate at the far end of it. "On certain nights the moon comes up the canal. Right up the middle of the water. Like it was poured down a trough to you."

He let that sit.

“The old people read the year off it. When to plant. When the *sakau* would be strong. When the reef fish would run thick at the passage and when they’d be thin. The walls are set so the moon and the stars walk down the gaps at the times that matter, and a man who knows the walls can stand here in the dark and tell you what month it is and what the sea will do.” He patted the gunwale, once, the way you’d pat a working animal. “It is a calendar you can sail through. The water tells the tide; the gaps tell the moon. That is what it is for.”

Mira watched his mouth and the muscles around his eyes the whole time, and her stomach did a small, careful thing, because the answer was *true* — she could feel the truth of it in the easy way it left him, no rehearsal, no glance to check how it landed — and it was also *not the whole of it*.

She had spent forty years learning the difference between a man who has run out of words and a man who has stopped on purpose. The first kind keeps reaching, the hands hunting for the thing they can’t find, the eyes going up and to the side. The second kind goes *still*. And this man, when he finished — *that is what it is for* — went still in exactly the way her grandmother used to go still at the end of a sentence she had decided was the end, whatever anyone else thought.

He had given them a function. A real one. A grounded, physical, checkable thing: a lunar almanac you could stand inside, the moon poured down a canal at the new month, the walls a fixed instrument for reading the year off the sky and the tide. It re-opened everything — because now the fifty-tonne cornerstone wasn’t just heavy, it was *aimed*; now the foodless reef wasn’t a riddle but a *site chosen for what you could see from it*; now the spaces between the stone were not gaps but apertures, sights cut into the dark.

It was a beautiful answer. And it was a door, set politely ajar, with a hand on the other side of it.

“That’s —” Yusuf was lit up. “That’s the *why here*. That’s it, isn’t it? You don’t build a city where people can live. You build an instrument where the sightlines are clean. The reef, the channel, the gate — it’s *aligned*.” He turned to Mira, wanting the math, wanting her to confirm the moon, wanting to *solve* it.

Mira didn’t give him the math.

She was looking at the custodian, who had gone on watching the canal as if Yusuf hadn't spoken, and she saw the thing she'd been hired by her own wiring to see since she was a child: the small set of the jaw that means *and there is more, and the more is mine*. He had told them what the walls *did*. He had not told them what was *kept* in the doing — who lay in the enclosure and why the moon was let in to find them, what was said at the new month and by whom, the part that was not a function but a covenant, the part the *Nahnmwarki* order held the way you hold a thing entrusted, not the way you hold a thing you've simply mislaid.

The official "we don't know" the whole island said to every outsider who ever came asking — Mira had understood, days ago, that it was two answers wearing one face. *We have not reconstructed the lift* was one of them, and that one was honest all the way down. *And there are things we do not say to you* was the other, and that one was not ignorance. It was a door held shut, by right, by people whose dead were on the other side of it.

He had just shown them, with great generosity, the part of the room he was willing to light.

Far off, on the mainland causeway, an outboard coughed and caught — the early boat from the resort survey, the clean-handed outfit that kept coming with its drone cases and its environmental-impact language and its careful, smiling people who would have *loved* this answer. Who would have written *lunar observatory* into a brochure by lunch. Who needed, more than anything, for the meaning of this place to stay a vacancy, an empty riddle free for the taking, because you can develop an empty riddle and you cannot develop a grave with keepers standing at the gate. The function the custodian had just handed them was, among everything else it was, a fence. *This is what it is for* meant *it is for something*, and a thing that is for something is not nobody's.

The sun cleared the wall. Light ran down the canal toward them, and for a moment it came straight up the middle of the channel, poured down the trough of black water exactly as he'd said the moon did, and Mira understood — felt, didn't reason — why a person might cut sightlines into the sea and carry a mountain across the water to set

them true.

Edith hadn't raised the camera. Mira noticed that. The Lens sat with the body in her lap and her hand resting on it, watching the light come down the water with her own two eyes, taking nothing.

Yusuf was still leaning forward, the next question loading. *But the alignment — can we measure it — which stars — who's in the enclosure —* Mira could see all of them queuing behind his teeth.

She put two fingers on his forearm.

He looked at her. She moved her head, once, a small *no* — not *he's wrong*, not *there's nothing there*, but *that's as far as the road goes, and the rest of it isn't ours*.

Hecklefish, who had been pretending to be asleep against the bait cooler, opened one eye. *Oh, NOW she stops asking questions. The one time the man's actually talking. Forty years of reading lips and you pick THIS sentence to leave on the table.* He sniffed. *I'd have asked about the cornerstone. Just sayin'.*

Nobody answered the fish. Nobody ever did.

The custodian turned from the wall at last, and looked at Mira — only at Mira — and something moved across his face that was almost a smile, the particular recognition of one person who has read a great many silent rooms meeting another, the unheard meeting the unheard. He had watched her watch him. He had seen her see the door. And he had seen her hand close over Yusuf's arm, and stop the lock from being picked.

"You know," he said to her, "that I have not told you everything."

It was not a question, so she did not answer it. She held his eye and let her face do the only honest thing it could, which was to agree, and to be at peace with it.

He nodded, slow, satisfied — the nod of a man handing back a thing intact.

"Good," he said. "Then we understand each other."

The tide turned under the boat. The light came off the top of the moon-trough canal and the water went ordinary and grey-green and busy, and the custodian picked up the paddle and put them about for

the mangrove, and did not say one word more about what the walls were for than the part he had chosen to give.

Behind them, seven metres of dry-stacked basalt held up four centuries of sky and kept the rest.

Chapter 20 — What Is It For

The tide turned at the wrong time, the way it always does when you want one more hour.

The skiff sat low at the canal mouth, taking the crew on one at a time, the engineer's rig already barged off ahead of them and gone — winch, sling, the aluminium gantry they'd hauled out here in Act One to prove how easy it all was. The gantry had proved nothing except that aluminium rusts faster than you'd think and that a fifty-tonne stone does not care how clever your sling is. They'd left a divot in the coral fill where they'd dropped their one borrowed column. Edith had photographed the divot. Then she'd photographed the wall behind it, seven metres of dry-stacked basalt that had stood since before her camera was a glint in anyone's eye, and put the lens cap on.

Frik was last off the islet. He stood on the edge of Nandauwas with his hands in his pockets, looking up at the cornerstone like a man saying goodbye to a relative he never understood and now never would.

"Fifty tonnes," he said. "I keep doing the sum. It doesn't get smaller."

"Sums never do," said Mira. She was already in the boat, water-side, where the noise was least and she could watch the others' faces against the wall. "That's the thing about them."

Jakobus was the only one not looking at the stone. He was looking at the *joint* — the place where two columns met and held, header crossing stretcher, the long face of one block locked over the end of the next, the way a man builds a log cabin so the corners bind themselves. He had his thumb on the seam. Not pushing. Reading.

"There," he said, to nobody and to all of them. "You see how it's tied."

They saw. He'd shown them on the first day and he'd show them on the last, because it was the only part of this he could honestly claim to know. He knew the *how-it-stands*. Every course alternated. Every stone's weight pinned the stone beneath. No mortar, because mortar is a thing you add when you cannot trust the geometry, and whoever built this trusted the geometry completely. It would stand another eight centuries on the strength of a single idea, repeated.

"That part I can read," Jakobus said. He took his thumb off the seam. "I can read it because it's a made thing, and a made thing answers one question if you ask it right."

"Here it comes," said the fish, riding the gunwale, dripping. *"He's going to do the speech. He always does the speech."*

"Not who," Jakobus said. "We chased who. The dynasty. The dragon. The lost continent that the brochures love and the radiocarbon hates. Who is a parlour game."

"And not how," Yusuf said, because he'd been waiting all book to be allowed to say it. "We tried how. How is sitting on the bottom of the barge channel with a bent gantry."

"Not how." Jakobus almost smiled. On him it looked like weather changing. "How is the hole the experts kept honest about. They tried to lift it again with all our toys, and they made a potato, and they had the decency to write it down. *Not yet reproduced*. Good men. I'd drink with them." He looked, finally, at the water between the islets, the spaces that gave the place its name. "There's only one question a made thing has to answer. The rest is gossip."

He didn't say it. He never said it himself. He handed it across, the way the seed says he must, the way he'd handed the custodian's silence back to the custodian three days ago and not picked it up since.

It was Mira who put it in the boat with them.

"What is it for," she said.

The skiff pulled out into the lagoon and the city began to do the thing

it does when you leave it: it stopped being walls and started being *the spaces between*. From the water you could see the logic of the canals, ninety-odd islets threaded by tide, a grid you could only read by going through it the way the builders went through it — by boat, on the water, on the water's terms. Land it on a map and it looks like a riddle. Float it on the lagoon at the turn of the tide and it looks like a machine that runs on the moon.

"It's for the dead," said Frik. "That's the official line. Mortuary capital. The royal enclosure, the tombs, the Saudeleur and their bones. It's a graveyard. A magnificent, three-quarters-of-a-million-tonne graveyard." He said it without a sneer, which had taken him the whole book to learn. "And that's true. The custodian said it was true. The archaeology says it's true. Built from about eleven-eighty, run for four centuries, the dynasty falls around the early sixteen-hundreds, and the whole time, they're stacking basalt onto a reef."

"True," Mira agreed. "And not the answer."

"Why not?"

She watched the wall recede. She always answered slowest, because she'd spent a life in rooms where the words went past too fast to catch, and she'd learned to say only the thing she was sure of.

"Because *graveyard* tells you what they did there," she said. "It doesn't tell you why *here*. Why a reef. Why a place that grows nothing and holds no water and can't keep one living soul alive without a canoe coming out every day with breadfruit and fresh water in a gourd. You don't drag fifty tonnes across twenty-five miles of open ocean to bury a king somewhere convenient. You do it somewhere *chosen*." She let the next part sit a beat. "*For* is the why-here. Jakobus's question is the why-here."

"*And the answer is —*" the fish prompted, leaning in, vibrating.

Nobody answered. The fish deflated visibly.

"*You're all doing it on purpose now.*"

"We are," said Edith. It was the most she'd said since the gantry went down. She had the camera in her lap, lens cap on, and her hand resting on it like you'd rest a hand on a dog you'd finally taught to

stay. “We’re doing it on purpose.”

Yusuf had the numbers, because Yusuf always had the numbers, and out here on the water with the wall shrinking he ran them one more time — not to solve anything, he’d given that up, but because the size of a thing is a kind of prayer.

Seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes. Spread it across four centuries of building and you get something like eighteen hundred tonnes a year, every year, sustained, generation on generation — basalt columns five tonnes, fifteen, twenty-five, quarried on the far side of the island and brought *here*, and the cornerstone alone fifty, a single stone the weight of a loaded lorry, levered somehow up onto a wall on a reef with no crane and no ramp and nothing — *nothing* — left in the ground to tell you how. No abandoned sledge. No worn road. No half-finished ramp of coral they got tired of. The columns on the seabed off Sokehs, found by the Oregon survey in the late eighties, read the honest way: cargo that didn’t make it. A spill on the haul road, if the haul road is the sea.

“That’s the part that gets me,” Yusuf said. “Not that it’s impossible. The experts don’t say impossible — they say *not reproduced*, which is a different and better word. It’s that they did it *casually*. Eighteen hundred tonnes a year is not a wonder of the world. It’s a Tuesday. For four hundred Tuesdays’ worth of years. They had a system so good it left no scar, and the system died with them, and we’ve been standing on the reef with a winch going *how, how, how* like a man knocking on a door that the people inside locked from the other side and then left.”

“*That’s almost poetry*,” the fish allowed. “*Don’t let it go to your head, you’ll capsize us.*”

“The point,” said Mira, “is that we’re not the ones who get to open it.”

And there it was, the thing that had been sitting in the boat the whole way out and the whole way back, the thing the custodian had handed them on the first day wrapped in two soft words. *We don’t know*. The crew had heard it the way the brochures hear it — a vacancy, a riddle, a *please decode me*. The well-funded outfit had heard it the way money hears anything empty — a thing you can buy and call yours,

because who's to say it wasn't, if even the islanders say they don't know. A vacancy is the easiest thing in the world to steal.

But Mira had watched the custodian's face when the words came out, the way she'd watched ten thousand faces in ten thousand hearing rooms where the truth lived in the body because the mouth wasn't going to carry it. And the face had not said *I don't know*. The face had said *that's a door, and you're standing on the wrong side of it, and that's correct*.

She hadn't picked the lock. She'd named it to the crew, low, three days ago, and then she'd shut up about it, and the silence she kept was the only honest gift she had to give back.

"So what *is* it for," Frik said, and you could hear he half wanted the answer and half had already let it go. "If we're allowed to ask. Not to crack it. Just — to stand in it."

Jakobus, in the bow, off his home ground and out of his depth in every sense that mattered on water, did the thing he does. He gave it away.

"Ask the wall," he said. "The wall's straightforward. It's a function. Every made thing is a function, and this one's plain as a hinge." He tipped his chin back toward the receding stone. "It's a place to keep the dead where the living can't move in and turn it into a town. You want a grave that *stays* a grave, you put it where no one can stay. No water. No food. No farmer's going to fence it, no fisherman's going to build a hut on the king's bones, because the reef won't feed him. The very thing that makes the engineers go mad — *why here, you can't live here* — is the thing it's *for*. You don't site a tomb where you'd site a house. You site it where the dead get the whole island to themselves and the living have to *visit*, on the tide, with permission, every single time." He paused. "That's the function I can read. That's the hinge."

The boat rode the swell. Nobody spoke for a moment.

"...Okay, *that one was actually good*," the fish admitted, quietly.

"And the rest of it," Mira said. "The how. The full of the why. What's kept."

“The rest of it isn’t a made thing,” Jakobus said. “The rest of it is hers.” He didn’t look back at the islet, where no one stood now, where the custodian had not come down to the water to wave them off because that was not what this was. “She read us cleaner than we read the wall. She knew on day one we’d want to take the answer home in a notebook and put it in a film. She gave us the true thing — *mortuary city, medieval, ours* — and she kept the part that’s not for the notebook. That’s not a riddle. That’s a *boundary*. You can tell the difference if you’ve ever been on the wrong side of one.”

Mira had been on the wrong side of one her whole life. She didn’t say so. The boat said it for her, the engine loud, her face turned to the water where the noise was least, the whole crew careful to keep half an eye on her mouth, signing badly and lovingly into the spray.

The reef dropped below the horizon line of mangrove the way reefs do, all at once, like a curtain rather than a fade. One moment Nandauwas was a grey tooth against the green ridge of Pohnpei, the cloud-forest piling up behind it dumping its endless rain on the wettest island on earth. The next moment it was gone behind a headland, and there was only the lagoon, and the smell of diesel and frangipani and low tide, and the long swell that had carried fifty-tonne stones to a place no one could live and would carry six unhirable strangers and one fixer back to a town with corrugated roofs and a Sunday church and *sakau* pounded at dusk.

“You want to know what’s strange,” Yusuf said, watching the water. “It’s *more*, now. The wonder. Not less. We didn’t solve it and it got *bigger*.”

“That’s the trick of it,” said Edith. She lifted the camera, sighted along the wake where the city used to be, and lowered it again without pressing anything. The frame had been hers to take. She’d chosen not to. “A people who loved their dead enough to build them a city out of the sea, in a place that could keep no one alive, by a method good enough to leave no mark and proud enough to keep no copy. That’s the answer. And it’s bigger than any answer we’d have hauled home.”

“*And the dragon?*” the fish tried, one last time, hopeful.
“*The one that flew the stones? The lost continent? Just*

for me? Off the record?"

The crew looked at the fish.

The crew looked at the water.

The crew did not answer, and the not-answering was the whole gift — the draught of the open gap, the *maybe* left standing where it belonged: not *did a dragon fly*, but the better one, the one the island had been holding the whole time. *Are some things nobody's to open?*

Mira watched the place where the wall had been until the headland took the last of it.

Then she faced front, into the wind, toward the town, and let the door stay shut.

Chapter 21 — The Spaces Remain

The tide was on its way out, and the canals knew it before anyone in the boat did.

Mira felt it first in the hull — that small shifting tug as the water decided which way it wanted to go, leaning the skiff a half-degree toward the open lagoon, then correcting. Keoki had cut the outboard back to a mutter. He let the ebb do the work. The reef did not hurry, and neither, this morning, did he.

She sat in the bow with her back to the prow, facing the others, facing the city. That was the only way she ever rode a boat — facing in, watching the faces, reading the wind off the water by the way it moved their hair instead of by the sound of it. Yusuf had learned this about her months ago and stopped offering her the comfortable seat at the stern. The good seat, the one she wanted, was always the one that let her see.

Behind her, Nandauwas slid back across the morning.

The walls did not get smaller so much as they got *quieter*. Up close, on the islet, in among the basalt, the thing had a roar to it — not sound but pressure, the way standing under a great old building presses on you. Now, from the water, with two hundred metres of ebbing channel opening between, the roar settled to a hum and then to a held note. Seven metres of stacked stone, header laid across stretcher, end-grain and long-face alternating the way Jakobus had walked his thumb along it on the first day — *this binds that, that binds this, log-cabin, nothing holding it but its own weight and somebody's enormous patience* — and the morning light came in low and raking and

found every joint.

Nature pre-cut those columns. She kept having to remind herself of that, because the wall did not let you believe it. The basalt had cooled and cracked into its long hexagonal logs all on its own, thirty thousand years ago, on the Sokehs side of the island, twenty-five miles away across open water. The stone was a gift. The lifting was not.

Frik was filming the wall over her shoulder, the small camera held loose, no tripod, no plan. She watched his jaw. He had stopped narrating to himself somewhere back on the islet. That was new for him.

“~750,000 tonnes,” the fish had said yesterday, riding the gunwale of the dinghy in Yusuf’s voice doing the fish’s voice, because somebody had to, *“over four centuries, that’s eighteen-fifty tonnes a year, every year, for four hundred years, on a reef, by hand, no crane, no ramp, and they left you NOTHING. No sledge. No rope. No diary. You absolute show-offs.”* And then, quieter, because even the heckle had run out of road: *“do it again, then. Go on. We’ll wait.”*

They had tried to do it again. That was Chapter One, six weeks and a lifetime ago — the rig, the engineer, the single column on the reef flat, the careful modern attempt to raft and lift one basalt log the way the tidy story said it had been done ten thousand times over. It had come out a potato. The modern team, with the best kit and a plan and a budget, had made a graceless lumpen thing, and the city had stood behind them, flawless and silent, declining to explain.

Nobody had reproduced it. That was the fact, the cold one, the cited one. *Replication has failed* — not *it cannot be done*, never that, the honest word was *not yet*, and the gap between *not yet* and *cannot* was exactly the size of the wonder. Mira had spent her whole life in that gap. The space between what a face said and what it meant. The space between *we don’t know* and *we will not say*.

The space between. *Nan Madol*. The water between the stone.

She looked away from the wall, for the first time in an hour, and found Edith.

Edith had the big camera in her lap. Not raised. Lying across her thighs like a sleeping animal, lens cap on, the strap looped twice

around her wrist the way she carried it when she had decided, for the day, not to shoot. She was watching the canal mouth open behind the boat, the V of disturbed water closing itself smooth again as they passed. She had taken almost nothing here. Three frames, maybe, in six weeks — the coral fill at low water, a child's bare foot on a basalt step that the custodian had nodded permission for, the back of Jakobus's neck as he read a corner. Nothing of the dead. Nothing of the enclosure. Nothing she had not been told, in some language or other, that she could keep.

A photographer who does not take the picture. The whole book had been asking her to lower the thing, and here, today, on the way out, she had simply set it down in her lap and let the place keep its own face.

Mira caught her eye. Edith made the small flat motion with two fingers — *enough, that's enough* — that the crew had all started using because Mira's eyes were the channel that always worked. Mira returned it. *Enough*.

The custodian stood on the seaward edge of the islet, where the dressed stone gave way to the rubble apron and the rubble gave way to the reef. Pwurahdo. He had come down to see them off, which he had not had to do, which protocol did not require, which was therefore the whole message. He was not waving. He had his hands at his sides and his weight even and he was watching the boat go the way a man watches weather — not anxious, not wistful, just *seeing them out*, all the way, until the channel turned and the mangrove would take them.

He had told them *we don't know* on the fourth day. The official line, the same one the island had handed to every outsider who had ever come ashore wanting the answer for free. The archaeologists said it too, and meant it cleanly: the transport method, undocumented; the lift, unreconstructed; the choice of a foodless, waterless reef for a city, unexplained on any practical ledger. Real scholars, careful ones, leaving the gap open because the gap was honestly open.

And Pwurahdo had said the same three words, and Mira had watched his mouth say them, and had seen — three beats before anyone, the way she always saw, because she had never been given any other way to know a room — that his *we don't know* was not the scholars' *we*

don't know.

His was a door. Held shut. By a hand.

She had not picked the lock. She had named it to the crew, once, low, on the second night, in the language they were all still bad at and getting better at, *fingers careful: he knows something, and it is his, and it is not for us* — and they had set their hands down. All of them. Yusuf, who could not let a funding trail lie. Frik, who narrated cathedrals to himself. Edith, who took the world's face for a living. They had each carried into this place the specific hunger of people the world had spent a lifetime calling *too much* — too watchful, too literal, too unable to stop reading the room — and the reef had asked them, gently, for the one thing none of them had ever been allowed to offer before.

To not need to know.

The boat came level with the last big islet and the channel began to bend.

"There was a buyer," Yusuf said, to the water, not to anyone. He was sitting low, arms on his knees. "Did I tell you what the brochure called it. The investment deck."

"You told us," Frik said.

"*'An unencumbered heritage asset.'*" Yusuf said it the way you'd hold up something dead by the tail. "Because the islanders say they don't know. You see the move. *They* say it's a mystery, so it's nobody's, so it's empty, so it's for sale." He shook his head, slow. "A vacancy is the easiest thing in the world to take. You don't even have to lie. You just point at the silence and call it an absence."

That was the part Mira had been built to read, and it was the part she would carry off this reef and not be able to put down. Two silences that looked from outside completely identical. The custodian's, and the buyer's. One a held door. One a wrecking ball with a smile. From the satellite they were the same blank. Only from inside the room, only watching the hand on the door, could you tell that one of them was *protecting* a thing and the other was *erasing* it so it could be sold as ground.

The buyer had not won. That was not a triumph the crew could claim,

and they did not claim it — the deal had died of its own contradictions, of a state that knew exactly whose grave it was, of a *Nahn-mwarki* order that did not need a foreign film crew to defend it and had defended itself for four hundred years. The crew had read the silence. They had not saved the place. The place had never been theirs to save, any more than the answer had been theirs to take.

“You came all this way,” the fish observed, from somewhere near the engine, *“to a stone city nobody can explain, sat with a man who can explain it, and DIDN’T ASK. You’re broken. You’re beautifully, beautifully broken.”*

Nobody laughed out loud. Friik smiled at the water. Mira watched the smile reach his eyes and stay there, which was how she knew it was true and not performed.

She turned back to the city one more time.

The walls had gone to a single dark line now, low against the green of Temwen behind, the seven metres flattened by distance into a stroke of charcoal a child could have drawn. You could not see the joints anymore. You could not see the header and the stretcher, the patient binding, the four centuries at eighteen hundred tonnes a year. You could not see the fifty-tonne cornerstone that nobody had explained the lifting of and nobody, in her hearing, ever would.

What you could see was this: someone had loved their dead enough to build them a city across the sea, on a reef that grew no food and held no water, a place where the living could not stay — *would* not stay, perhaps, was perhaps the entire point, a metropolis for the ones who no longer needed to eat or drink, kept apart by a moat of ocean from everything that still did. She did not say that. The narrator of her own head did not even quite say it. It was not a fact. It was a shape the facts left, the way a body leaves a shape in a bed, and the shape was not hers to fill in with words and call it solved.

What is it for. Jakobus’s question, the only one he ever brought, the one he had carried to the canal’s edge on the third day and then — she had watched his hands do it — *handed across the water* to the custodian, openly, with both palms, *yours to give or to keep*.

Pwurahdo had kept it.

That was the answer. Not a riddle the crew had failed to crack. A

thing a man held in his two hands and had every right in the world not to put down for them. The wonder did not shrink when he kept it. It got larger. It filled the whole channel and the whole sky and the twenty-five miles of open water the stone had crossed, and it would still be exactly that large tomorrow, when the crew were gone and the tide came back in and the canals filled and the city stood in its own water keeping its own counsel, the way it had since before her grandmother's grandmother, the way it would after.

The boat reached the bend.

Mira looked at the figure on the apron of stone — small now, a dark upright mark where the dressed wall met the reef — and she lifted one hand. Not a wave. Open palm, held a moment. *Seen. Thank you. We are leaving it as it was.*

Across the widening water, Pwurahdo lifted his hand the same way. Held it. Let it down.

Then the mangrove came in from the right, green and close and smelling of low tide and mud and salt, and took the line of charcoal, and took the small dark mark, and took the city, all at once, the way a turning closes a door — not slammed, just shut, just gently and completely not-for-you-anymore — and the canals were behind them and the open lagoon was ahead and the outboard found its voice again as Keoki opened the throttle for the run home.

Nobody spoke for a while.

The spaces between the islets stayed full of water and the spaces between what was known and what was kept stayed full of exactly what they had always held, which was not the crew's to drain, and Mira sat in the bow facing in, watching the faces of the people who had crossed an ocean to learn how to leave a thing alone, and found that for once in her life she did not need to read the room.

There was nothing in it being hidden from her.

There was only a thing being kept, by someone who had the right, and she had let him keep it, and the letting was the whole of what she had come for and had not known until now that she had.

The fish, for once, said nothing at all.

Chapter 22 — Notes on the Real, the Debated, and the Invented

Here is the part where the magician shows you the inside of the hat.

Most books do this quietly, in a smaller font, at the back, where nobody who matters will look. We are going to do it loud, because the whole point of this one was that the gap between *what is known* and *what is claimed* is not a footnote — it is the building. It is the spaces between. So: what was real, what is genuinely argued over by people with letters after their names, and what we made up. In that order. No cheating.

“Finally. The fish has been waiting twenty-one chapters to fact-check you.”

You have, and you can. Let’s go.

THE REAL.

Nan Madol is a real place. You can go — by water, on the tide, by right and by protocol, the way the *Nahnmwarki* order requires, which is to say *not* the way you buy a ticket to a ruin. It sits on a reef flat off the southeast coast of Pohnpei, in the Federated States of Micronesia, fronting the district of Madolenihmw. Roughly ninety-two artificial islets, laced with tidal canals. A core about one and a half kilometres by half a kilometre. The name means *the spaces between* — the channels of water threading the stone. That is not a poetic flourish

we added for the title. That is the translation. The island handed us the metaphor; we just refused to give it back.

The stone is real, and stranger for being explainable. It is columnar basalt — long hexagonal “logs” formed when thick lava cooled and contracted and split itself into prisms. Columnar jointing. The same physics that built the Giant’s Causeway and Devils Tower. Nature pre-cut the blocks. We want to be very clear about this, because it is the single most important fact for *not* losing your mind: the columns were not carved into hexagons by anyone. They came out of the ground that shape. The wonder is not the shape. The wonder is what was done with it.

What was done with it is real, and it is a legible craft. The columns were stacked dry — no mortar — header-and-stretcher, log-cabin style, on a base of coral rubble fill. A block’s long face, then a block’s end, course on course, the way a log-cabin builder binds a wall so it locks against itself. This is the thing Jakobus reads in Chapter 3, and we did not invent the grammar of it. It is documented building technique. You can stand in front of Nandauwas — the great royal mortuary enclosure — and see it. Walls five and a half to seven and a half metres high. Columns ranging from a few tonnes up to around ninety tonnes for the largest; a single cornerstone of around fifty.

The numbers are real, and we ran them straight. Total mass of the complex: on the order of seven hundred and fifty thousand tonnes. Built over roughly four centuries. Divide one by the other and you get something near one thousand eight hundred and fifty tonnes a year, sustained, for four hundred years. That is the calm, cold arithmetic Mira runs in Chapter 2, and it is an order-of-magnitude truth, not a false precision. We are not telling you it was 1,847.3 tonnes in a good year. We are telling you that whatever the real figure was, it was *that kind of number*, every year, for *that long*.

The dates are real and they are medieval. The megalithic phase — the stone city as you’d recognise it — began around AD 1180, established by uranium-thorium coral dating — more precise than radiocarbon and the method that produced the 1180 figure specifically. This is not lost-civilisation antiquity. This is the same century as Notre-Dame’s foundations. It was the capital of the Saudeleur dynasty, the line that unified and ruled Pohnpei, until the dynasty was overthrown by Isokelekel around the early seventeenth century.

“You’ll notice he keeps saying ‘around.’ Watch him do it again.”

Around. Around the early seventeenth century. Some sources give a year — you’ll see ~1628 — but we have written it as a range on purpose, and you should treat anyone who hands you a single confident date for the fall of a dynasty whose records were oral with the same gentle suspicion you’d give a man selling you a watch from the inside of his coat.

The quarry is real, and it is far. The basalt came from the Sokehs side of the island, on the order of twenty-five miles away. Across open water. And here is where the real becomes the *hole*, so let’s stop and stand in it, because it is the whole reason the book exists.

THE POTATO, AND WHY IT IS NOT A FAILURE OF YOURS.

There is no documented transport-and-lift method. Nobody left a manual. And — this is the part we leaned on hardest, so it had better be solid — **experimental archaeology has tried to reproduce the feat and has not.** That is real. That is cited. Modern people, with modern understanding of the technique, with the best kit and a plan and daylight, have attempted the quarry-to-wall version of this and fallen short of the thing that is standing, flawless and silent, right behind them.

We need you to hear the exact shape of that sentence, because the shape is everything. It does **not** say *physically impossible*. It says *not yet reproduced*. Those are different countries, and the distance between them is precisely where the credulous fall off the map shouting about sky-cranes. The honest position — the one held by the people who have spent their lives on this reef in the rain — is a logistics-and-provisioning gap that the experts themselves leave open. It is not a claim against the textbook. It is a hole *in* the textbook that the textbook is honest enough to admit.

Two holes, really, and they feed each other.

The first is **how**. Rafting columns — some up to fifty tonnes — twenty-five miles over open ocean, then lifting them into seven-and-a-half-metre mortarless walls on a reef, by hand, with no crane, no surviving ramp, nothing left behind that says *this is how we did it*.

The second is **why here**. Nan Madol has no fresh water. It grows no food. It is uninhabitable without constant canoe resupply. Someone dragged three-quarters of a million tonnes of stone across the sea to build a city on a reef that could keep no living soul alive.

So the question is not only *how did they lift it*. The question is *why drag it all the way out there to a place that could feed and water no one*. And the honest, cold-eyed answer the book lands on — in Chapter 5, with Jakobus's question and the custodian's keeping of it — is the thing that re-opens the wonder without reaching past the evidence: **a city for the dead**. A craft and a love of one's dead great enough to put a stone metropolis where no one could live. That is not woo. That is human, and it is bigger than the dragon.

THE DEBATED.

Some things in this book are real disagreements between real scholars, and we have tried very hard never to settle them for you on the page, because they are not ours to settle.

The exact date of the Saudeleur fall is one, as above.

The columns found on the seabed are another, and this one matters because the fringe loves it. In 1988 and 1989, a University of Oregon survey documented basalt columns on the sea floor seaward of the site — outside the lagoon, on the open ocean side. Real. Cited. The prosaic, honest reading — the one we hold to — is **lost cargo**. Stone that went over the side during the haul. Evidence of *the journey*, not of a drowned super-structure, not of a sunken Mu. We have written it that way throughout, and where a character wants it to mean more —

"That'll be Yusuf, getting excited again."

— that is a character over-reaching, which is a human thing to dramatise, and the narrator never once confirms it. If you came away from this book believing there is a sunken city under Nan Madol, you got that from a person inside the story who *wanted* it, not from us. We never said it. Go back and check. We'll wait.

THE TRADITION.

The Pohnpeians have their own account of how the stone moved. It involves the two sorcerer-brothers, Olisihpa and Olosohpa, and a dragon that flew the basalt into place. This is the island's oral history, and it is *theirs*. We render it with respect and we do not render it as fact, and — this is the firewall the whole book is built on — **we do not render it as a puzzle for the crew to decode**. It is not a cipher. It is not a clue the clever outsiders crack. It is a people's telling of their own dead and their own builders, and the most the book ever does is hold it up to the light and put it down again gently.

If the book worked, you noticed that the person who out-reads the crew at every turn that matters is the custodian. The crew own the *telling*. They never own the *place*. When the question of *what it is for* finally lands, it lands in a Pohnpeian hand, and it is given or withheld by a Pohnpeian right. Mira — who has spent a whole life being talked over, who reads the body because the words were never handed to her — sees that the official “we don't know” is a door held shut, not an empty room. And she does not pick the lock. That is the whole book. If you wanted her to open it, that want is the thing the book was about.

THE INVENTED.

So you know exactly where the made-up ends and the real begins:

The crew are invented. Mira, Yusuf, Edith, Frik — ours. The resort outfit and every named modern person attached to it — ours, built to dramatise a real and unglamorous danger, which is that *a place with no agreed meaning and no settled custodian is the easiest thing on earth to take*. The adversary is invented and is deliberately not a cabal — a fallible human, driven by money, whose best cover is the island's own honest “we don't know.” That dynamic — that an admitted vacancy can be developed where a grave with keepers cannot — is the truest thing in the fiction.

The custodian, as a specific person with a specific name, is invented, and stands in for a real role and a real protocol — and is the part of this book most flagged as *provisional pending a Pohnpeian and FSM in-culture read*. We built on the facts. We did not present the invention as history. Where we have rendered consent customs, entry protocols, the *Nahnmwarki* order — those depictions are ours to get

wrong and the island's to correct, and they bind.

Jakobus is invented — the weathered fixer who reads a made thing and asks *what is it for* and then, every time, hands the question on. He is the one literal thread through these books, and he is the road, never the lead. He defers. If you remember him deferring more than starring, the book did its job.

THE WINK.

We told you we'd name the question and decline to answer it, so here it is, named, and here it stays, unanswered:

Who raised a stone city that could not feed or water a single soul — and how was three-quarters of a million tonnes of basalt carried across the sea and lifted into walls taller than a house, by hand, with nothing left behind to tell us how?

We don't know. Neither do the people who've studied it longest, and they will tell you so to your face, and that telling is not ignorance — it is sometimes the most honest thing in the room, and it is sometimes a door held shut by right, and the deepest skill this book ever asked for was telling those two silences apart and honouring both.

Go and check the dossier. Every number in this chapter traces to a cited row, and we would rather you caught us than trusted us. Run the arithmetic yourself. Read the survey. Then stand on the causeway at low tide, with the diesel and the frangipani and the church bell carrying over the water, and look at the wall, and let yourself ask the question without needing the answer to arrive.

That draught you feel, standing in the gap — that's the door, left where it was.

You're allowed to wonder.

"And you're allowed to say maybe. Roll the credits."



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor